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WARTIME FATIGUE

War takes a toll on all kingdoms, more so when the fighting is active and close at hand. As long as the threat of Pitax's armies remains, the PCs' kingdom suffers as detailed below.

Avinash's Forces Are Raiding: If, when a Kingdom turn begins, Avinash's forces are still active, with at least one of his armies undefeated in the PCs' kingdom, the kingdom gains 1d6+4 Unrest and increases a Ruin of the party's choice by 2; the other three Ruins each increase by 1.

Avinash's Forces Were Defeated: If, when a Kingdom turn begins, Avinash's armies have been defeated and the general has retreated into his palace in Pitax, the kingdom gains 1d4 Unrest and increases a Ruin of the party's choice by 1.

Field Armies Were Defeated: If Avinash's forces and all four field armies have been defeated, Pitax's aggression against the PCs' kingdom is dramatically reduced. In this event, at the start of a Kingdom turn, the kingdom gains 1 Unrest and does not increase any Ruins.

King Irovetti is Defeated: Once the PCs defeat Irovetti (either by killing him, forcing him to abandon the region, or securing his surrender), the War of the River Kings ends and wartime fatigue penalties to the kingdom no longer accrue.

to find a way to strike back at Pitax, so when the War of the River Kings begins, the PCs seem to her to be the perfect tool for this task. Within a few days of the start of this part, Ilora contacts them as detailed in encounter site **GU3**.

Ilora's has much to reveal about the tactics and training used by Pitax's armies. The PCs must spend several hours speaking to her, and within a few days, the intelligence spreads to all of the PC armies. Thereafter, all armies gain a +1 bonus on all checks made during War encounters against Irovetti's armies; this bonus stacks with all other bonuses.

Ilora can also reveal the locations of all of the Pitaxian army's remote campsites, including the Catspaw Camp (encounter site **RU3**), Tusker's Raiders (encounter site **GL1**), the Marshaling Ground (encounter site **GL2**), and the tragic fate of Littletown (encounter site **PX1**).

WARTIME EXPLORATION

When this part begins, King Irovetti mobilizes his troops throughout the regions bordering Pitax. At this point, four of the encounter areas presented in Chapter 2 become modified by the presence of field army encampments as detailed on the following pages. If the PCs defeat these four field armies, King Irovetti realizes he may have acted a bit rash and recalls his forces back to his capital city for an extended period of time, during which the PCs can infiltrate Pitax in an attempt to end the war for good.

KINGDOM TURNS DURING THE WAR

The Rushlight Tournament begins on the first Fireday of the month, so by the time it concludes and the war begins, the PCs should have a few weeks to react before the next Kingdom turn begins. When the war starts, Pitax has several different armies as listed below.

Avinash's Forces: These three armies are detailed as part of Irovetti's First Strike (page 348). If that War encounter ended with the PCs losing the hex, defeating Avinash's remaining armies before the end of the month prevents them from spreading through the kingdom. If any of Avinash's armies still exist when a Kingdom turn begins at the end of each month, one of his defeated armies (the GM chooses which) is replenished in the conquered settlement with new forces from Pitax, then each army moves one hex in a direction of your choice, automatically causing that hex to become lost as it is claimed by Pitax.

Field Armies: These four armies of Pitaxian soldiers are detailed under Field Army Encounters (page 351); Irovetti holds them back to help maintain control in Pitax's zone. With the exception of the wyverns in Littletown, who do not leave that location, these armies can react to seek out PC armies within the zone, at your discretion. If a field army attacks the PCs in a hex other than their listed encampment, adjust the battlefield terrain as you see fit.

Pitax Regroups: Once Avinash's forces and the four field armies are defeated, King Irovetti orders his forces to regroup in his capital city. No further encounters with Pitaxian armies occur in the Stolen Lands for 2 months. After this point, if Irovetti still remains in charge, you can have new field armies or forces under Avinash's command begin to threaten the PCs' kingdom again, but this adventure expects the PCs to have dealt with King Irovetti personally by then.

NATURE'S WRATH — SEVERE 13

Nyrissa doesn't sit idly by as Pitax goes to war against the PCs. As the war unfolds, she warps reality within her domain to allow a horrific tempest to bleed through from the First World to strike at the PCs sometime during this part, hoping to further tax their resources and resolve. The timing of this encounter is left to you.

The storm's gathering clouds are impossible to miss, but the strange, supernatural element can be interpreted by PCs who are expert in Survival. When Nyrissa's Tempest rolls initiative with its Stealth check, it uses the PCs' Survival DCs rather than Perception DCs to determine success. If the tempest fails to beat even one PC's Survival DC, the party has enough time to attempt

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a DC 42 Survival check to prepare for the hazard. On a success, the PCs and any armies with them secure emergency shelter from the environment and gain some defense against the tempest (as detailed below).

NYRISSA'S TEMPEST HAZARD 16

RARE COMPLEX ENVIRONMENTAL MAGICAL

Stealth +32 (expert)

Description Sudden dark clouds gather in the sky above, and moments later, blasts of lightning and swirling tornadoes begin to rip the landscape apart.

Disable Nature DC 42 (master) to note the magical nature of the storm and to perform a quick ritual and prayer to the fey spirits of the region to cause the tempest to disperse, or *dispel magic* (9th level, counteract DC 36) to counteract the tempest immediately.

Raging Storm ↷ Trigger The PCs fail an attempt to Disable the tempest, or 10 minutes pass without any attempt to leave the area (whichever comes first); **Effect** Bolts of lightning lance down from above. If the PCs managed to succeed at a Survival check to prepare for the storm, their armies are protected and only one PC (determined randomly) is targeted by this bolt, otherwise all PCs and armies are targeted by bolts. Against PCs, the bolt inflicts 10d6 electricity damage (DC 38 basic Reflex save). Against armies, the bolt inflicts 1 point of damage (DC 30 Mobility check negates). Then, whether or not the PCs managed to take shelter, roll initiative for Nyrissa's Tempest.

Routine (4 actions) If the PCs successfully sought shelter with a Survival check, the storm takes no actions if the GM fails a DC 16 flat check. Otherwise, the storm takes four of the following actions, each determined by rolling a d4, during the round. On each successive round, the number of actions the storm takes is reduced by 1; when the storm is reduced to 0 actions in this way, the hazard ends.

1 Thunderclap A blast of sound rips through the region. Unsheltered armies must attempt a DC 30 Morale check or increase their shaken value by 1. Unsheltered PCs take 10d6 sonic damage (DC 38 basic Fortitude save).

2 Lightning The tempest takes its Raging Storm reaction as a single action.

3 Tornado A tornado funnel extends down from the storm to unerringly strike at a PC, who must attempt a DC 38 Fortitude save.

Critical Success The PC escapes unscathed.

Success The PC is knocked prone and takes 8d6 bludgeoning damage.

Failure The PC is hurled through the air, taking 8d6 bludgeoning damage and then falling 1d6×10 feet for appropriate falling damage, landing prone.

Critical Failure As failure, but 8d6 bludgeoning damage and a fall of 2d8 × 10 feet.

4 Renewal Blasts of wind tear through the area but do no real damage. Attempt a DC 11 flat check; on a success, the number of actions the storm takes next round is not reduced as usual.

FIELD ARMY ENCOUNTERS

During the War of the River Kings, the following hex encounters from Chapter 2 are modified as follows.

GL1. TUSKERS' STOMPING GROUND SEVERE 13

STANDARD WARFARE

The hill-giant chieftain Kob Moleg has gathered a large force of hill giants to serve at his side, and when King Irovetti first approached him with an offer of alliance, Kob Moleg proved his worth as chieftain by considering the tactics of the offer. Rather than attacking Irovetti and his army, Kob Moleg agreed to the offer, after securing for himself a sizable payment of treasure and tribute. He agreed to split some of his hill giants off to aid on the surprise attack against the PCs' kingdom, but he retained



NYRISSA'S TEMPEST

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most of his hill giants here, in a sprawling field of mud and gravel. If the PCs haven't attacked any of Pitax's other field armies yet, the giants are on low alert and automatically start combat with an initiative result of 0.

Battlefield: After weeks of marshaling and training and combat drilling, most of this hex has been trampled into mud and gravel. This doesn't bother larger creatures like giants or their mammoth mounts, but PC armies treat the terrain of this otherwise open battlefield as difficult terrain. There are two armies of Tusker's riders stationed here.



KOB MOLEG

TUSKER RIDERS (2 ARMIES) ARMY 14

See page 349

Scouting +24

Creature: The commander of the Tuskers, Kob Moleg, does not take part in the battle. As combat begins, though, his vantage point atop a low hill may present to the PCs a tempting target. If the PCs wish to confront Kob Moleg themselves, they can do so during the battle itself in hopes of bolstering the conditions of this War encounter's results in their favor. Kob Moleg is astounded by the PCs' audacity to confront him in person, but he quickly realizes that defeating them (or at least capturing them) could give him the perfect leverage against King Irovetti to demand even more outlandish tributes. Kob Moleg fights with a greatclub that has jagged shards of metal nailed to it, granting him increased damage and the versatile piercing trait with this unusual weapon. Kob-Moleg fights to the death.

KOB MOLEG CREATURE 16

UNIQUE | CE | LARGE | EARTH | GIANT | HUMANOID

Variant male hill giant (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 170)

Perception +27; low-light vision

Languages Common, Jotun

Skills Athletics +31, Intimidation +30, Survival +29, Warfare Lore +27

Str +9, **Dex** +5, **Con** +6, **Int** +1, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +6

Items *+2 greater striking spiked greatclub*, *+2 resilient hide armor*, sack with 5 rocks

AC 39; **Fort** +30, **Ref** +27, **Will** +27

HP 295

Attack of Opportunity ↷

Catch Rock ↷

Speed 35 feet

Melee ❖ *spiked greatclub* +33 (backswing, reach 10 feet, shove, versatile P), **Damage** 3d12+17 bludgeoning

Melee ❖ fist +31 (agile, reach 10 feet), **Damage** 1d6+17 bludgeoning plus Grab

Ranged ❖ rock +29 (brutal, range increment 120 feet), **Damage** 1d8+17 bludgeoning

Kob's Ruinous Strike ❖❖ Kob Moleg makes a melee Strike. If he hits and deals damage, the target is frightened 1, or frightened 2 on a critical hit.

Throw Rock ❖

Wide Swing ❖ As hill giant.

Treasure: Kob Moleg has accumulated 872 gp, a *+2 striking flail* and a *+1 striking thundering warhammer*. His spiked greatclub isn't particularly valuable beyond its runes, but a collector might cough up 5 gp for the weapon. It's too large, in any event, for a Medium or smaller creature to wield.

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GL2. MARSHALING GROUND — SEVERE 13

STANDARD

Here, on the easternmost edge of what Irovetti likes to think of as Pitax's border (although in truth it's a no-man's land), the nomadic warriors known as the Pitax Horde wait for the order to attack. Unfortunately, Irovetti's recent alliance with the Tuskers, a traditional enemy of the Pitax Horde, has put a strain on the warriors' morale. They'll still fight if presented with an invading army, but more out of a lust for battle than loyalty to Pitax.

If the PCs enter this hex without being accompanied by an army, they'll have a chance to observe the Pitax Horde.

If the PCs establish diplomatic contact with the Horde and shift its leader's attitude from hostile to helpful, he lets the PCs' army pass. If the PCs agree to destroy the Tusker's Riders at encounter site **GL1**, the Pitax Horde will even join the PCs in the march against Irovetti.

A successful DC 33 Society check or DC 29 Hills, Politics, or similar Lore check is enough for the PCs to recognize that the nomadic warriors gathered here are from numerous smaller clans throughout Glenebon, and that the Tusker hill giants are their traditional enemies. If, instead of approaching members of the Horde with intent to battle, the PCs seek to show them that they've defeated Kob Moleg (the giant's armor or weapon are sufficient for these purposes), a PC can attempt a DC 33 Diplomacy or Intimidation check to impress upon some of the warriors that the PCs should be the ones the warriors are working for. On a success, the PCs convince two of the seven clans to defect to their cause; on a critical success they convince four of the clans to defect. A defection like this automatically triggers a battle, but any of the defected armies that survive agree to join the PCs' forces.

Battlefield: The Pitax Horde knows the open plains and rolling dells of this area well and can use the terrain to their advantage if they are attacked here.

PITAX HORDE (7 ARMIES) — ARMY 10

CN INFANTRY

Scouting +19 (+22 in encounter site **GL2**)

Description The Pitax Horde consists of human warriors from seven different minor clans in Glenebon.

AC 30; **Maneuver** +22 (+24 in encounter site **GL2**); **Morale** +16

HP 5 (RT 2)

Melee greater magic axes +25

Tactics Live off the Land, Merciless, Toughened Soldiers

PX1. LITTLETOWN — SEVERE 13

LANDMARK RESOURCE

Just before the war began, King Irovetti used Littletown as "currency" to pull together a wyvern army. His agents worked to contact numerous flocks of wyverns of the Glenebon Uplands and southern Pitax, promising them an entire town of cattle and humans if they would band together to aid King Irovetti in the coming war. If proof of the atrocities that King Irovetti allowed to happen here come to full light, the citizens of Pitax will be even more receptive to new rule.

Battlefield: The ruins of Littletown consist of burnt buildings and rubble strewn throughout the streets. The entire battlefield functions as difficult terrain, although the flying wyverns ignore this element. A small group of the Littletown wyverns was sent to attack the PCs' kingdom in Irovetti's first strike against the PCs.

WYVERN FLIGHTS (4 ARMIES) — ARMY 12

CE SKIRMISHER

Scouting +23, darkvision

RU3. CATSPAW CAMP — MODERATE 13

STANDARD

The Catspaw Marauders consist of a displaced thieves' guild, forced out of the city of Hajoth Hakados in Numeria a year ago after a failed coup against the city's leaders. Many of the Catspaws were slain, but enough survived to remain a significant threat. They became a mercenary company for hire in the River Kingdoms, rebuilding their numbers until they came to Irovetti's attention. Impressed by their loyalty to each other, he paid them a significant amount of money from Pitax's treasury to join his army. When the war begins, the Catspaw Marauders create a semi-permanent camp amid a small copse of trees in this hex.

The Marauders are uninterested in betraying Pitax as long as their leader, Alasen, lives. This adventure assumes that the PCs won't confront Alasen until later (page 389), but if the PCs manage to confront her here, they may be able to break the morale of these mercenaries with one stealthy assassination mission. The logistics of this are left to the GM to devise.

Battlefield: The Catspaw Marauders' camp includes two fortifications—a trench and a tower. When the battle begins, one of the Catspaw Marauder armies has fortified in the trench, and another is within the tower. The other two armies move to engage foes while the fortified ones use ranged attacks.

CATSPAW MARAUDERS (4 ARMIES) — ARMY 11

CN SKIRMISHER

Scouting +21

Description The Catspaw Marauders consist mostly of humans and half-elves who fight with kukris and longbows.

AC 31; **Maneuver** +24; **Morale** +18

HP 4 (RT 2)

Melee kukris +23

Melee magic longbows +26

Tactics Ambush, Low-Light Vision, Sharpshooter

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PART 3:

THE GHOST OF WHITEROSE

Armies aren't the only weapons that King Irovetti has ready to use against the PCs. Having lived the adventurer's life for several years himself, he has a good idea what kinds of folks are attracted to the dangerous lifestyle. And as such, he's prepared a dangerous trap for overly curious PCs—a trap set atop a distant hill in the Branthlend Mountain foothills at an abandoned abbey and winery, now cursed and haunted by a dangerous ghost.

SETTING THE BAIT

The way in which you introduce this part of the chapter is left to you. The PCs could simply stumble upon Whiterose Abbey as they're exploring, but with the proper foreshadowing and implied threat, a visit to Whiterose can be much more than an extra-detailed hex encounter.

King Irovetti knows that the PCs are the heart and soul of their kingdom. If the PCs can be eliminated, he reasons, their kingdom will fall all the easier to his armies. Yet Irovetti knows that, having deceived the PCs once already, he'll need to be far more subtle if he hopes to get them to investigate Whiterose and expose themselves to the dangers that wait there.

Irovetti hopes to lure the PCs into his trap by tricking someone he thinks the PCs will listen to into believing false tales of a new threat to their kingdom. Perhaps this information comes to the PCs from someone they already know, or perhaps it comes from someone new to the PCs, such as an NPC working for Mivon or another River Kingdom who wants to get into the good

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graces of the PCs. You can choose any NPC other than Ilora Nuski to pass this information on to the PCs—not only should Ilora remain a source of trustworthy information, but King Irovetti can't use her because he doesn't know where she is.

One elegant way to introduce the information engineered to get them to investigate Whiterose is as the result of the PCs taking an Infiltration kingdom activity (page 526) to try to learn something about Pitax. On a success, you can supply the PCs with the disinformation, but on a critical success, you should inform the PCs that something seems off about the intelligence. It's still worth investigating, but in this case, the PCs should know beforehand that they might well be walking into a trap.

The PCs could also learn the information from an officer they capture and interrogate. Irovetti has informed several of his key commanders of the ambush for the PCs he's set up at Whiterose, and by giving his commanders a convenient bit of information to give up under the duress of an interrogation, they might gain mercy from the PCs even as they're sending them into a trap.

The nature of the lure is simple: Irovetti wants the PCs to believe that he has developed a way to create a massive *cloudkill* effect using a modified *horn of fog*, the talents of a master poisoner from Daggermark, and a mystical font said to lie within the abandoned Whiterose Abbey. The truly devious part of Irovetti's plan is that even if the PCs learn that there is no actual "*horn of cloudkill*," the rumors of his interest in Whiterose—or perhaps merely the rumors of a font that can enhance poisons, drugs, and potions—will likely be enough to reel the PCs into the trap.

THE POISON PLOT

30 XP

The PCs learn of a plot by King Irovetti to create a poison-spewing magical horn. They must travel to Whiterose Abbey (encounter site **GU2**) to investigate the information, determine if such a device actually exists, and if it does, capture or destroy it.

Source: An NPC unknowingly carrying false information.

Completion: Discover that no such device exists and survive the assassination attempt by Irovetti's agents.

Reward: Apart from the experience points earned for completing this quest, traveling to Whiterose Abbey gives the PCs the chance to gather some information about Irovetti's past and his link with the nymph Nyrissa and the sword *Briar*.

WHITEROSE ABBEY

Briar is more than a sword to Nyrissa—it is a fundamental part of her being, and without the sword she is not whole. Crafted from a fragment of her own soul, the blade holds Nyrissa's capacity for love. Said to be the weapon that would one day slay her, *Briar* was created by the Eldest to punish Nyrissa for her claims that she was equal among them. One of the Eldest in particular, the Lantern King, used *Briar* as one of several tools to curse her, whisking the sword away to the Material Plane. This curse makes it impossible for Nyrissa to find *Briar* as long as it remains quiescent on the Material Plane. King Irovetti is but the latest in a long line of champions Nyrissa chose to seek the sword, though he is the first to have found it. Yet Nyrissa chose her champion poorly, for Irovetti now hides the sword from her. See Chapter 10 for the full story of *Briar* and its tragic connection to Nyrissa.

The Lantern King's sense of humor means that, each time Nyrissa's focus shifts to a new kingdom, he sends his agents out to relocate *Briar*'s hiding spot to somewhere within the potential kingdom Nyrissa is focused on at that time, knowing that she'll never find it and taking cruel delight in how close she comes to recovering the sword. When Nyrissa's attentions turned to the Stolen Lands years ago, the Lantern King's agents chose Whiterose Hill as *Briar*'s new hiding spot, placing it in a subterranean pool below the hill.

The pool and the hill itself were far from unpopulated. Above, Whiterose Hill had long been the site of an abbey dedicated to Cayden Cailean and built by priests from Galt, while downhill a small winery produced high-quality, small-batch wine and beer. A cave entrance near the winery led deep under the hill to the pool, where a nereid named Evindra had dwelt long before the priests came to the hill. For many years, Evindra remained hidden from the priests, watching quietly in hiding each time they came to the pool to gather the remarkably pure waters to aid in the production of their beer, but eventually the need for companionship drove Evindra to reveal herself. The priests welcomed her presence, seeing her as a benevolent spirit once she began to teach them the secret of how to enhance the quality of their brewing even further using a combination of primal magic and more precise methods of water filtration. The priests themselves agreed to limit their trips to her home, visiting her only once each year when their grain harvest began.

When the Lantern King's agent, a unique shapeshifting fey creature named Werendegar ("Weren" for short), arrived with *Briar* not so many years ago, he tricked Evindra into believing the weapon was a cursed sword that needed to be hidden from the world. She fell for the smooth-talking fey's lies, and never told the abbey priests of her new role.

It all came to an end when a new priest, Barlin Gablivix, arrived at Whiterose Abbey. When his lechery

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and embarrassing antics caused him to fall out of favor at a temple to Cayden Cailean in Galt (just a year before the Red Revolution would tear that nation apart), the church gave Barlin a choice: excommunication or exile. He chose the latter and was sent to Whiterose Abbey, a place the church assumed would be remote enough that Barlin would have the chance to reflect on his choices while gaining the guidance of the local priests to mend his ways. At first, Barlin's skill at gardening and cultivating vineyards was seen by the priests as a great boon, but when they finally revealed to the halfling their secret—that their beer production was aided by a fey ally—he became obsessed with Evindra.

One night, Barlin stole Evindra's shawl and gained a considerable bargaining chip. He forced Evindra to assume elemental form, and then imprisoned her in a water clock that would prevent her from returning to her true form, so he could keep her to himself. Soon after, the gardener discovered the treasure Evindra had been guarding—an exquisite sword. As soon as Barlin touched the weapon, its suppressed personality stirred, influencing Barlin and amplifying his jealousy and paranoia. It was only a matter of days before *Briar* drove Barlin to believe that the other priests at the abbey coveted his "bottled bride." Driven beyond reason, he used *Briar* to slay everyone else in the Abbey, then retreated into hiding near the subterranean pool. The abbey's remote location and the fact that those who had financed it in the first place had been slain during Galt's recent Red Revolution ensured the gardener's isolation for many years.

It wasn't until recently that Irovetti's agents discovered Whiterose was the site of *Briar*'s hidden vault. They found the subterranean chamber and the fanatic gardener therein. A battle ensued, but they prevailed—after slaying the gardener, they returned to Pitax with *Briar* and other treasures Barlin had hoarded, including Evindra's shawl. They left Evindra herself trapped in her water clock simply because they didn't find where Barlin had stashed the elegant device away.

Yet the ill times at Whiterose did not end. Barlin lost his name and his life when he rose as a ghost, finally bringing a bit of truth to the old stories that the place is haunted. This latest development is unknown to Irovetti—he chose Whiterose as a place to spring his trap on the PCs partially because of its remote location and partially because if the PCs succumbed at a supposedly haunted abbey, suspicion would be levied against the supposed ghosts and not himself. To ensure such a fate meets the PCs when they arrive, the king of Pitax sent one of his most dangerous minions—a wererat murderer named Gaetane—along with a small group of soldiers to set up an ambush. Yet the would-be murderers have found, much to their discomfort, that the rumors of Whiterose being haunted and infested by dangerous vermin are disturbingly accurate, and as a result they've had some difficulty in preparing their deadly reception for the PCs.

RESEARCHING WHITEROSE ABBEY

EXPLORATION | CONCENTRATE | SECRET

Once the PCs hear about Whiterose Abbey or learn of Irovetti's supposed plot, they may wish to do a bit of research on the site before they visit it. Attempting a DC 25 Alcohol or Cayden Cailean Lore check or a DC 30 Crafting or Society check to Recall Knowledge, or at a DC 30 Diplomacy check to Gather Information can potentially reveal more information.

Critical Success The PC learns the success and failure information, but also that the priests of Whiterose Abbey were said to have an alliance with a fey creature that dwelt in a subterranean pool somewhere under the hill, and it was through her grace and advice that the priests were able to brew such potent alcohol. The priests were likely not slain by bandits, though, as none of the abbey's valuables ever surfaced in illicit markets where bandit-stolen treasures would have likely to have been sold. Prevailing theory is that the priests fell to internal treachery involving a poisoner or an alchemist, for today, the flora on Whiterose Hill grows strangely.

Success The PC learns the failure information, but also that Whiterose Abbey was founded about 75 years ago, financed by a church of Cayden Cailean in Galt. The priests were master brewers and vintners, and beer brewed in their blessed vats gained unusual potency and marvelous flavor. The priests of the abbey were slaughtered and the site plundered, rumor holds, by bandits, back in 4668 AR. No in-depth investigation was performed, as the financing church had fallen to Galt's Red Revolution several years prior, leaving Whiterose and its abbot, Ildeben, to fend for themselves.

Failure Whiterose Abbey is abandoned and has been for decades. It was built by the church of Cayden Cailean, and for many years the priests who dwelt there were renowned for their rich and potent beer. It's located about a dozen miles southeast of Mount Branthlend.

Critical Failure The PC learns the failure information, but also incorrect information that the priests were slaughtered by a band of brigands led by an alchemist who poisoned the abbey's wine.

WHITEROSE HILL

Patches of white roses still grow on parts of Whiterose Hill, but in the absence of *Briar*'s influence and the presence of the Gardener's ghostly powers, the land has grown wild and dangerous. Thick swaths of kudzu-like vegetation grow on the hill, and the wide path that once led up to the abbey itself is now little more than an overgrown trail. A low stone wall encircles the hill,

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built decades ago by the priests to delineate the land granted them by the church. This same stone wall now marks the extent of the Gardener's influence—inside the wall, the air feels strangely thick and humid, almost as if the hill were under an immense greenhouse rather than on the slopes of a temperate mountain range. The Gardener's influence manifests in other ways as well, causing vegetation to shift and writhe at times without an apparent breeze and causing weeds and vermin to grow to excessive size and strength. At night, the susurrus of the fields and vegetation rustling is unnerving in the still air, and languid fireflies the size of apples bob and dip in the air generating motes of sickly green and pale yellow light. A PC who succeeds at a DC 25 Nature check to Recall Knowledge confirms that the wilds seem unnaturally verdant here and that a magical influence is likely behind the hearty growth. A critical success on this check reveals that the boundaries between this world and the First World are thin in this region. Yet for all this eerie atmosphere, the Gardener himself does not manifest directly except in a few specific locations detailed in the encounter text.

Few signs remain of the expansive vineyards and grain fields that once surrounded the hill, although here and there, overgrown posts and tangles of wild grapes hint at the region's past. The stone abbey looms at the hill's peak; while the ruins of the winery stand to the south at the hill's base. A long (now overgrown) trail winds down the hill from the abbey through the overgrown vineyard—once a scenic route intended to give the workers time to admire the regional beauty on each trip to and from the winery, but now a barely recognizable trail that winds up to area **A1**. No map of the hill itself is provided, as beyond the encounters associated with the Abbey at its peak, the winery down on its lower slope, or the cavern below, no dangers exist on the now overgrown hillside.

Whiterose Hill is located at area **GU2** of the Glenebon Uplands. With the Branthlend Mountains in the background, the hill itself is just one of many in the region, but it's the only one in the whole of the uplands with a structure at its peak. As the PCs approach, hints of an overgrown trail become obvious in places. It's merely a DC 15 Survival check to follow the path, which finally grows more distinct for a few hundred feet as it approaches the abbey plaza from the west—those who take the road come to area **A1**.

A1. PLAZA

Atop Whiterose Hill, at the end of the overgrown track, lies a weed-choked plaza. To one side stands a vine-draped bell tower. Facing the plaza, the weathered doors of the abandoned abbey hang askew.

The plaza is surrounded by light undergrowth within 20 feet of its border and heavy undergrowth elsewhere. Success on a DC 20 Survival or DC 25 Perception check reveals recent footprints in the area; these prints were left by the ambushers to give the impression that troops recently massed in the plaza before entering the abbey, in hope of luring the PCs within. A critical success on this check suggests that the prints look suspiciously like they might have been staged.

The road leads down the hill before fading away entirely into undergrowth. The winding trail through the vineyard to the winery to the north is almost entirely overgrown as it leaves the plaza to the northeast—a successful DC 25 Survival or DC 30 Perception check is enough to note the path's route. If the PCs follow this trail, a ten-minute winding walk through overgrown vineyards leads to the ruined winery sheltered in the lee of the hill's northern face (area **A14**).

A2. BELL TOWER TRIVIAL 14

A trio of fallen iron bells lies amid a pile of broken beams on the floor of this partially collapsed stone tower.

The first time the PCs enter this tower, they'll automatically hear what sounds like bells ringing from a vast distance. The ringing continues until the fallen bells are touched, at which point the sound ceases—an unnerving but harmless effect of the Gardener's influence over the area.

Creature: A Pitax warden is hidden atop this tower, standing guard. If he spots the PCs approaching, he descends and warns his companions in area **A6**, who ready their ambush. If he's caught here by surprise, he uses *telekinetic maneuver* to shove a PC into one of the fallen bells to create a loud thud that alerts his companions inside the abbey, who then prepare their ambush without him; he fights to the death in this case.

PITAX WARDEN CREATURE 12

See page 336

Initiative Perception +22

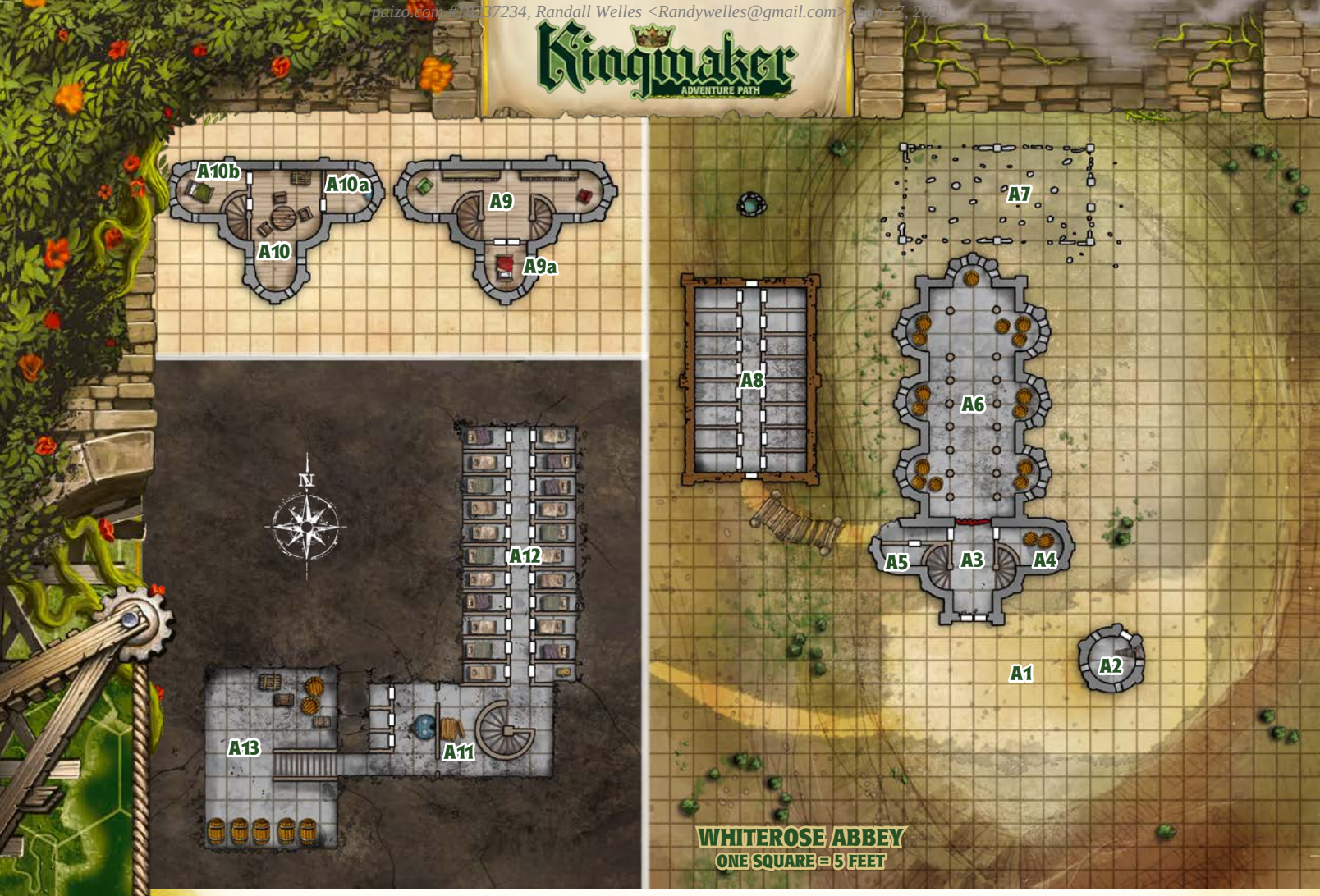
A3. NARTHEX

The walls and ceiling of this room are tiled in vine patterns. Spiral stairs curve down to the west and up to the east. Between two doors on opposite sides of the room, a heavy curtain divides the narthex from the sanctuary.

The ruined double door can easily be opened, but the creaking noise that results alerts the ambushers who wait in area **A6**. The stairs to the east lead up to area **A9**, while those to the west lead down to **A11**.

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A4. VESTRY

A number of hooks extend from the wall of this abandoned vestry; heaps of ancient cloth are piled on the floor below.

Treasure: The mounds of cloth are nothing more than rotted cloaks and old robes bearing the symbol of Cayden Cailean, but a successful DC 30 Perception check made while investigating the row of hooks reveals that one of them can be triggered like a switch. Doing so causes a cleverly-hidden niche on the wall just above to swing open, revealing a hollow space within which sits three greater ghost charge bombs (*Pathfinder Advanced Player's Guide* 253), three *greater healing potions*, and two *panacea potions*.

A5. WASHROOM

Judging by the broken basins, this must have once been a washroom and lavatory.

The first PC to look into one of the basins sees that it is filled with crystal-clear water, but upon blinking, the water vanishes; this is a harmless but eerie effect of the building's strange condition.

A6. SANCTUARY SEVERE 14

This long, colonnaded hall is marked by three rounded bays along either side, each containing dusty old barrels. Piles of wood mark where kneeling benches have long since fallen to ruin. Overhead, wooden rafters form a complex network of supports for the roof; on the floor are numerous bedrolls and alchemical supplies of obviously recent manufacture.

The bedrolls are used by the soldiers, but they've arranged them along with several alchemical supplies so that it looks like a group of "poisoners" has set up shop in here to keep the ruse going a few precious moments longer once the PCs arrive. Success on a DC 30 Crafting check is enough to confirm that the alchemical "laboratory" is cleverly staged and is not a functional workspace.

Creatures: Gaetane and his four wardens lie in wait in this room. If the PCs catch them unawares, they are at rest, sparring, talking in hushed tones, or playing cards while they wait—they scramble for weapons and attack as soon as they recover from the surprise of being ambushed themselves. If they have time to prepare, the wardens hide amid the barrels and prepare to ambush the party.

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Gaetane himself hides in the rafters 20 feet above. The wererat remains in the rafters (which provide standard cover from those on the ground below) and fires arrows at the PCs, preferably at human targets (and specifically a human target he has activated his *oathbow* against). He does his best to avoid melee if possible.

Gaetane fights until reduced to 40 Hit Points, at which point he cowardly surrenders and attempts to bargain with the PCs, offering to exchange information for his life. If any other soldiers remain alive at this time, they drop their weapons and surrender as well. In this case, you can use Gaetane to fill the PCs in on the truth about the "poison plot." When it comes time to infiltrate Pitax in the next part of the adventure, Gaetane can be a potential source of intelligence on the city.

The four Pitax wardens are quite unnerved by the strange aura of the place and are frightened 1 for the duration of the battle. They cannot reduce their frightened level below 1 while they remain on Whiterose Hill. A PC who succeeds at a DC 25 Perception check to Sense Motive sees that the soldiers are visibly uncomfortable about being in the area for some reason; a critical success confirms they fear the entire site around them.

GAETANE CREATURE 14

UNIQUE | LE | MEDIUM | BEAST | HUMAN | HUMANOID | WERECREATURE

Male human wererat ranger (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 329)

Perception +27; low-light vision, scent (imprecise) 30 feet

Languages Common, rat empathy

Skills Acrobatics +28, Athletics +26 (+28 to Climb or Swim), Nature +22, Stealth +28, Survival +25

Str +4, **Dex** +6, **Con** +4, **Int** +0, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +2

Items *+1 resilient chain shirt*, *oathbow* (20 arrows)

Rat Empathy (divination, primal) Gaetane can communicate with rodents.

AC 36; **Fort** +25, **Ref** +28, **Will** +25

HP 315; **Weaknesses** silver 15

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ jaws +28 (finesse), **Damage** 2d10+10 piercing plus curse of the wererat

Melee ❖ claw +28 (agile, finesse), **Damage** 2d8+10 slashing

Ranged ❖ *oathbow* +30 (deadly d10, range 100 feet, reload 0, volley 30 ft.); **Damage** 2d8+10 piercing

Change Shape ❖ (concentrate, polymorph, primal, transmutation) as wererat; human with fist +24 for 1d4+10 bludgeoning, or Small rat with Speed 30 feet, climb 10 feet.

Curse of the Wererat (curse, necromancy, primal); as wererat (DC 34 Fort save)

Deadly Aim ❖ **Requirement** Gaetane hasn't attempted a Strike during his turn yet; **Effect** Gaetane makes a ranged Strike against his target at a –2 penalty. He gains a +6 circumstance bonus to damage on that Strike.

Distracting Shot If Gaetane critically hits a creature with a ranged weapon, or hits a creature at least twice on the same turn with a ranged weapon, and if that creature is one he has used his *oathbow* to swear an oath to destroy, that creature is flat-footed until the stat of Gaetane's next turn.

Hunted Shot ❖ **Frequency** once per round; **Effect** Gaetane makes two ranged *oathbow* Strikes against a target. If both hit the same target, combine their damage for the purpose of resistances and weaknesses. He applies his multiple attack penalty to each Strike normally.

Moon Frenzy (polymorph, primal, transmutation) As wererat.

Targeting Shot ❖ (concentrate) **Requirement** Gaetane is currently suffering a multiple attack penalty; **Effect** Gaetane aims carefully, then makes an *oathbow* Strike; he ignores the target's concealed condition and all cover.



GAETANE

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PITAX WARDENS (4) CREATURE 12

See page 336

Initiative Perception +22

A7. OVERGROWN GRAVEYARD MODERATE 14

Stone markers with weathered inscriptions mark this as a place where the faithful lie in repose. Each stone is engraved with the emblem of a rose winding around a wine goblet.

The graveyard is covered in heavy undergrowth. An examination of the gravestones reveals that the majority of them bear the same death date, including the grave of Abbot Ildeben (in a fit of guilt after his murderous rampage, the gardener himself buried all his victims here). Although none of their spirits haunt the graves, the Gardener's influence causes the weeds in the place to rustle and writhe constantly.

Creatures: The real danger in this area isn't the spirits of the dead, but rather two particularly dangerous viper vines that lie in heaps amid the undergrowth. Influenced by the presence of the Gardener's spirit, these carnivorous plants have grown large and powerful. When they rise up to attack (using Stealth to roll initiative), the impression is, if only temporarily, of the entire graveyard uprooting to attack, for these viper vines have infested the entire area with their twitching roots (which also enhances their existing tremorsense within the area to be precise). The viper vines pursue foes throughout the hilltop area, but do not chase foes into buildings or further than two-hundred feet from the graveyard's boundaries. If they do exit the graveyard, their tremorsense reverts to imprecise and they lose their Grasping Roots action until the plants have 24 hours to reintegrate their root network into the area's soil. The viper vines fight to the death.

OVERGROWN VIPER VINES (2) CREATURE 14

RARE N LARGE PLANT

Variant viper vines (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 287)

Perception 24, low-light vision, tremorsense (precise in area **A7**, otherwise imprecise) 60 feet

Skills Athletics +29, Stealth +26

Str +8, **Dex** +5, **Con** +7, **Int** –4, **Wis** +5, **Cha** –3

AC 35; **Fort** +28, **Ref** +26, **Will** +24

HP 290; **Resistances** poison 15

Cold Vulnerability As viper vine.

Speed 20 feet

Melee ❖ jaws +29 (reach 10 feet), **Damage** 3d6+13 piercing plus 3d6 poison

Melee ❖ vine +29 (agile, reach 15 feet), **Damage** 3d10+13 bludgeoning plus Grab

Captivating Pollen ❖ enchantment, incapacitation, mental, poison) As viper vine.

Constrict ❖ 3d8+10 bludgeoning, DC 35.

Grasping Roots ↷ **Trigger** a creature attempts a Move action in area **A7**; **Requirement** the overgrown viper vine is in area **A7**; **Effect** The viper vine manipulates its roots to cause foliage around the triggering creature to suddenly seem to spring to life. The triggering creature must attempt a DC 35 Reflex saving throw.

Critical Success The target is unaffected.

Success The target treats the first square of its movement as difficult terrain.

Failure The target becomes immobilized by the foliage, (escape DC 35).

Critical Failure As failure but the target also falls prone.

A8. CONTEMPLATION QUARTERS

A long central hall is flanked by a row of doors on either side. Every door is ajar, and the rooms are virtually identical in their sparse furnishings.

These rooms were the study and meditation chambers for the most devoted priests who had completed their training and taken their vows before the abbot and the assembled brethren.

An overgrown well behind the empty building drops a full 80 feet into the cold water of area **A16** below. If the PCs make an excessive amount of noise at this area, the Gardener's ghost may rise up from the well to attack at your option; see area **A16** for details.

A9. LIBRARY

Moldering books and scrolls sit on the sagging wooden shelves that line the walls of this chamber. Another stairwell curves up to the floor above; to the south a wooden double door hangs open to reveal a small bedroom.

The few surviving books are mundane tomes on religion, viticulture, and old tales of bravery by religious figures from a variety of faiths. The room to the south (area **A9a**) was the librarian's bedroom.

Treasure: A drawer in a narrow desk against the bedroom's west wall contains the librarian's personal journal, a small leather affair with elaborate knotted designs, as well as a thick tome with soggy leather covers. The journal indicates that the librarian had a growing worry about "the gardener's" interest in unnatural topics. He describes a book that he obtained for the gardener but ended up not giving him—after seeing the book, the librarian held it back, telling the gardener that he had been cheated by the bookseller; this story refers to the tome with the sodden covers. The book has no title and is written in Aklo. It is difficult to read, but if consulted for 10 minutes, it grants a +2 circumstance

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bonus on Recall Knowledge checks dealing with astrology, astronomy, or the stars. The book is worth 10 gp, but it can also be used to momentarily distract the Gardener when he is encountered (see area **A16**).

A10. ABBOT'S CHAMBERS

This room holds a desk engraved with the icon of a wine cup, perhaps indicating the study of a leader of the order. Moldering tapestries depicting Cayden Cailean making wine and beer hang askew from the walls. A large and quite old bloodstain mars the floor to the south.

This was the room in which the gardener murdered Abbot Ildeben. Area **A10a** to the east was the abbot's personal shrine, while area **A10b** was his bedroom—neither room contains valuables.

Hazard: The first time any PCs enter this area, a haunt created by the murderous act that took the abbot's life strikes out at them.

CUTTHROAT HAUNT — HAZARD 14

RARE HAUNT

Stealth DC 41 (master)

Description The pain and agony endured by Abbot Ildeben as the Gardener cut his throat lingers on in this room.

Disable DC 38 Diplomacy check to appeal to the haunt and convince it the PCs aren't the source of its pain, or DC 33 Religion to rebuke the haunt in Cayden Cailean's name.

Slash Throat ↻ (divine, necromancy) **Trigger** A creature comes within 5 feet of the bloodstain; **Effect** A spectral sickle manifests behind the triggering creature, then slices around to cut at that creature's throat. The target must attempt a DC 39 Fortitude save.

Critical Success The target is unaffected.

Success The target takes 4d10 negative damage.

Failure The target takes 4d10+35 negative damage and is drained 1. An eerie white scar manifests on the target's neck; this scar persists as long as the drained effect caused by this haunt lasts.

Critical Failure As failure but 4d10+70 negative damage and drained 2. The eerie white scar periodically appears to drip with blood, but this is purely an unsettling cosmetic side-effect; it does no additional damage to the victim.

Reset 1 hour.

A11. KITCHENS

Large clay and stone ovens fill the far wall, and the open room has tables for preparing food and basins for washing. Crocks once filled with knives, long spoons, and other kitchen supplies have spilled their contents onto the countertops, which are covered with a film of dust and debris.

This room is where the priests once cooked and prepared meals. The stairs here lead up to area **A3**.

A12. PRIESTS' CELLS — MODERATE 14

This long hallway contains nearly two dozen narrow cells, each furnished with an equally narrow bed. Old bloodstains mar the walls and floor in many places here.

Hazard: It was here that the gardener slew the majority of the abbey's priests so long ago, moving from room to room as he quietly opened throats. When guilt overtook him, he returned later to drag the bodies outside and buried them in the graveyard, but the spirits of the murdered priests returned here, infusing these cells with a dangerous haunt.

LIGHTS OF THE LOST — HAZARD 16

RARE COMPLEX HAUNT

Stealth DC 42 (master)

Description The murdered spirits of the slain priests manifest as churning, glowing spheres of floating, blood-red wine that drift and slither through the air. Within each can be glimpsed a silently screaming face.

Disable DC 42 Diplomacy check to promise the restless spirits that justice will be served and the cause of their pain will be punished, or DC 36 Religion to invoke Cayden Cailean to calm the haunt.

AC 39; **Fort** +23, **Ref** +26, **Will** +29

Hardness 25; **HP** 106 (BT 53); **Immunities** critical hits, object immunities, precision damage; **Weaknesses** positive 15

Waves of Fear ↻ (divine, emotion, enchantment, fear, mental) **Trigger** A creature opens any of the doors into a priest's cell; **Effect** Waves of fear wash through area **A12** as all creatures in the room realize that, one by one, their loved ones are being murdered and that they will be the last to be slain. Every creature in area **A12** must attempt a DC 37 Will save.

Critical Success The creature is unaffected.

Success The creature becomes frightened 1.

Failure The creature becomes frightened 2 and stunned 1.

Critical Failure The creature becomes frightened 3 and stunned 3.

Routine (3 actions) Up to four different creatures in area **A12** are each targeted by one of the floating, churning spheres of wine drifting through the air; it hurtles toward them and douses them with wine that turns to life-draining blood as it strikes unerringly. The haunt cannot target the same creature more than once each round. After the haunt is reduced to its broken threshold of 53 HP, it can target no more than two different creatures. A creature targeted by the lights of the lost must attempt a DC 37 Fortitude save.

Critical Success The creature is unaffected.

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Success The creature takes 4d6 negative damage and is sickened 1 from drunkenness.

Failure The creature takes 8d6 negative damage and is sickened 2.

Critical Failure The takes 16d6 negative damage, is sickened 3, and becomes doomed 1. As long as the creature is doomed from this trap, they cannot reduce their sickened condition below 1, and they take a –1 circumstance penalty on all further saving throws made against fear effects as lingering traces of the terror the priests felt loom in their memories.

Reset 1 hour.

A13. WINE CELLARS

This wine cellar is filled with wooden racks containing hundreds of wine bottles, their corks sealed with white wax stamped with the rose-entwined goblet sigil of the abbey.

Treasure: Although most of the wine has soured, a dozen bottles of incredibly fine Whiterose chardonnay remain. It's difficult to tell these remaining 12 viable bottles apart from the rest, but a successful DC 30 Alcohol Lore check to Recall Knowledge is enough to note them. Each of these bottles have aged quite well and is worth 100 gp. Loading up all of the bottles for transport elsewhere to have them sorted and inspected requires transport of a total of 8 Bulk of bottles.

A14. RUINED WINERY LOW 14

Whiterose Abbey built its crushing, filtering, fermenting, and cooperage facility on the lower slope of the hill, next to a tunnel entrance in the side of the hill leading to the mystic subterranean pool that long served as the lair of the abbey's "guardian spirit," Evindra. Today, the buildings that once sat against the cliffs along the northern face of Whiterose Hill have fallen into ruins, but the entrance to the tunnel, while somewhat overgrown with hanging vines, is still quite obvious to anyone who approaches. Several more buildings in much greater states of disrepair lie amid the overgrowth just to the south of the two still-standing structures near the hill's base. If the PCs followed the trail from area **A1** down the hill, all remnants of that trail fade away into the undergrowth within a hundred feet of this area, but by the time this occurs on the walk, the buildings themselves are readily apparent.

Creatures: While the smaller of the two ruined buildings (area **A14b**) contains little of interest, the larger building has become the den of a pair of irlgaunts that clambered into the ruins through a hole in the roof. They

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scuttle out to investigate any unusual sounds in the area, potentially ambushing PCs who emerge later from area **A15**, but flee if reduced to fewer than 50 Hit Points.

IRLGAUNTS (2) CREATURE 13

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 148
Initiative Perception +24

A15. CISTERN TUNNEL

This long tunnel bores straight into the hillside. For the first hundred feet or so, the tunnel contains long side tunnels opposite narrow alcoves. These side tunnels are dead ends that were once used as cool storage. Some still contain barrels of supplies, lumber, and tools or large barrels of wine long since soured.

After the storage tunnels, the main tunnel proceeds a further 900 or so feet to the northwest.

A16. THE CISTERN SEVERE 14

The tunnel ends at a large, vaulted cavern filled with a crescent-shaped pool of softly rippling, crystal-clear water. The southeast arc of the pool cuts across the end of the passage, separating the tunnel from a cavern floor covered with softly writhing green mold and pale fungus; a rickety-looking wooden bridge spans the fifteen-foot gap. On the cavern floor itself, numerous large wine casks lie around a large central pool of glowing blue water. Along the ceiling thirty feet above, what appear to be a half-dozen pinpoints of light slowly wriggle and move, almost as if forming and reforming strange constellations in a false night sky.

For many years, Evindra watched over *Briar* in this chamber. Charged with keeping the sword hidden and safe by the duplicitous fey Werendegar, Evindra chose to keep *Briar* hidden in the cistern itself, which was already infused with energies from the First World. The waters from this cistern were also used by the abbey's priests to enhance the beer they produced, never realizing the true source of the cistern's power.

A hole in the ceiling near the western wall extends up to the well near area **A8**. During daytime, the hole allows faint sunlight into the cavern, but at night it's a DC 25 Perception check to notice the hole from below.

Creatures: The ghost known now only as the Gardener haunts this chamber, though his presence can be felt throughout the entirety of Whiterose Hill. The ghost spends his time either manipulating the fungus that grows on the central island here or "stargazing" upon the constantly shifting constellations above. He remains infused into the walls, water, and floor of this chamber for 1d6+2 rounds after the first PC enters the place, after which he emerges in eerie silence from the walls; he rolls for initiative using Stealth. As the Gardener advances, the "stars" near the ceiling begin to spin and spiral as if caught in a vortex.

The "stars" are in fact four ancient will-o'-wisps that have grown powerful feeding upon the ghost's anger and jealousy; they have allied with the ghost by forming strange patterns of stars for him to gaze upon. When the ghost rises up to attack the PCs, the will-o'-wisps join the Gardener in the battle as they do not wish to see their banquet of fear destroyed.

The Gardener uses his Corrupting Gaze throughout combat. While his transformation into a ghost resulted in the loss of much of his sorcerous power when he lived, he retains a small selection of powerful spells. On



THE GARDENER

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the first round, he casts *haste* on himself and the will-o'-wisps, then uses Quickened Casting to cast *phantasmal killer*. On the second round, he casts *black tentacles*. On the third round, he uses Telekinetic Assault on the most heavily armored foe and then moves to an advantageous position to set up a *vampiric exsanguination* on the subsequent round. The Gardener then attacks with his Draining Touch, alternating that with his remaining spells against foes who maintain ranged superiority. He fights until destroyed, pursuing his victims anywhere they flee on Whiterose Hill. The Gardener can be laid to rest by releasing or killing the nereid trapped in the hidden water clock (see treasure and *Briar*'s Guardian below).



THE GARDENER CREATURE 16

UNIQUE | LE | SMALL | GHOST | INCORPOREAL | SPIRIT | UNDEAD

Male halfling ghost (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 166)

Perception +24; darkvision

Languages Common, Gnome, Halfling

Skills Crafting +28, Deception +33, Nature +26, Religion +26, Stealth +30

Str –5, **Dex** +6, **Con** +3, **Int** +6, **Wis** +2, **Cha** +9

Site Bound As ghost.

AC 36; **Fort** +27, **Ref** +30, **Will** +26

HP 220, negative healing, rejuvenation; **Immunities** death effects, disease, paralyzed, poison, precision, unconscious; **Resistances** all damage 15 (except force, *ghost touch*, or positive; double resistance vs. non-magical)

Rejuvenation (divine, necromancy) Releasing the nereid and allowing her to leave this place (or, alternatively, killing her) allows the Gardener to move on to the afterlife.

Speed fly 25 feet

Melee ❖ ghostly hand +27 (agile, finesse, magical), **Damage** 4d8+12 negative

Arcane Spontaneous Spells DC 34, attack +28; **8th** (1 slot) *vampiric exsanguination*; **7th** (1 slot) *haste*; **6th** (1 slot) *phantasmal killer*; **5th** (1 slot) *black tentacles*; **4th** (1 slot) *confusion*; **3rd** (1 slot) *slow*; **2nd** (1 slot) *mirror image*; **1st** (1 slot) *ray of enfeeblement*; **Cantrips (8th)** *daze*, *dancing lights*, *electric arc*, *ray of frost*, *telekinetic projectile*

Corrupting Gaze ❖❖ as ghost, but 9d6 negative (DC 37 basic Will save).

Draining Touch ❖❖ as ghost.

Quickened Casting ❖ (concentrate, metamagic) **Frequency** once per day. If the Gardener's next action is to cast a 6th- or lower level spell, reduce the number of actions to cast it by 1 (minimum 1 action).

Telekinetic Assault ❖❖ (divine, evocation) as ghost, but 9d6 bludgeoning (DC 37 basic Reflex save).

ANCIENT WISPS (4) CREATURE 10

RARE | CE | SMALL | ABERRATION | AIR

Variant will-o'-wisps (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 333)

Perception +22; darkvision

Languages Aklo, Common

Skills Acrobatics +23, Deception +20, Intimidation +20, Stealth +21

Str –5, **Dex** +7, **Con** +0, **Int** +4, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +4

AC 33; **Fort** +16, **Ref** +23, **Will** +20

HP 130; Immunities magic

Glow (aura, light) 30 feet. As will-o'-wisp, but can also appear as a tiny pinpoint of light.

Magic Immunity As will-o'-wisp.

Speed fly 50 feet

Melee ❖ shock +23 (electricity, magical), **Damage** 2d12+10 electricity

Feed on Fear ❖ (concentrate) As will-o'-wisp, but regains 2d8 hit points.

Go Dark ❖ (concentrate) As will-o'-wisp.

Treasure: Although *Briar* and most of the gardener's gear was taken by the Pitaxian agents who murdered him years ago, they neglected to remain long enough to search this chamber further, as they were eager to return to Irovetti with *Briar*. A DC 30 Perception check reveals a secret door in the side of the cask closest to the cistern. Opening it reveals the cask to be a cozy, halfling-sized hideaway—it was here that the gardener spent much of his time. The cask contains a small bed laden with dusty furs, on which sits a *wand of widened fireball (5th)*, while nearby stands an incredibly beautiful and intricate water clock of colored glass, bronze, silver, and darkwood. This water clock is worth 250 gp alone for its workmanship, but it also serves as Evindra's prison—see *Briar*'s Guardian below.

The waters of the cistern, if used as an additional component in the construction of any alchemical fluid, poison, or magical liquid (such as a potion or elixir) have a wondrous effect, although using the waters doubles the time required to create the item. Consult the list below for the exact effects, depending on the fluid; a character can use these effects to generate additional mixtures if you wish. A single dose of the glowing waters is worth 20 gp. The pool itself contains enough water for 10 uses, but with *Briar* taken from the area, the cistern lacks the ability to generate more doses.

Alchemical Bombs: The bomb gains a +2 item bonus on damage done on a direct hit and a +1 item bonus on damage done by a splash.

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Alcohol: The alcohol becomes much more delicious and increases in value (typically resulting in alcohol worth twice as much as normal).

Antidote or Antiplague: The item bonus to Fortitude saving throws increases by +1.

Poison: The poison's save DC increases by +2.

Potion or Elixir: The potion or elixir's effects last for twice as long. In the case of items that heal wounds, the potion or elixir restores 50% more Hit Points.

BRIAR'S GUARDIAN TRIVIAL 14

The water clock hidden in area **A16** is not magical, but it does function as a prison for the nereid Evindra simply by containing her in the form of a water elemental mixed with a healthy dose of water from the magical cistern. In this state, Evindra cannot communicate and is effectively unconscious (although neither does she have a need to eat or drink). A PC who examines the water clock and succeeds at either a DC 31 Perception check or a DC 29 Crafting or Nature check notes something strange about the device—be it faint watery cries for help, an unusual shifting sensation when the clock is held, or another clue that something might be hidden inside of the device

If the water clock is destroyed or drained, Evindra returns to her true form, that of a breathtakingly beautiful woman with pale skin, pointed ears, dark hair, deep blue eyes, and webbed fingers and toes. She thanks the PCs profusely for rescuing her and just as quickly begs them for her shawl. If the PCs attack her, she fights back as best she can, but she hopes to befriend them in an attempt to gain their aid in reclaiming her shawl, using her natural and magical charms if necessary. See the Quest: Evindra's Shawl sidebar for details.

In combat, Evindra casts *summon elemental* to conjure a water elemental on the first round of combat, then uses her poison touch against the PCs. If this tactic proves unworkable, she assumes the form of a water elemental to attack physically. If reduced to 30 Hit Points or fewer, Evindra attempts to flee into the nearby pool to hide.

While Evindra knows much about Nyrissa and her plots for the Stolen Land, she keeps this information to herself until the PCs return her shawl. In the meantime, though, she'll agree to use her restorative magic on them as a token of her good will and trust in them, and may even promise to teach them one of the rituals she knows if this will further entice them into helping her in turn.

Evindra also tells the PCs that the powerful magical sword she once guarded here was probably taken by the same people who took her shawl, and that if the PCs can find her shawl, they'll certainly find the sword as well. She has no issues with the PCs claiming the sword as their own, explaining that it's far past time that *Briar* was once again carried by a hero rather than left forgotten in a pool, but she won't yet go into further detail why she hopes the PCs take up the sword as one of their weapons until after they prove themselves by aiding her in reclaiming her shawl.

If she thinks that telling them will help convince them to help, Evindra explains to them what *Briar's* basic magical functions are, although if the PCs want to know more of what she knows of the sword's history or potential, they'll need to first do her the favor she asks of them and retrieve her shawl from Pitax.

EVINDRA CREATURE 13

UNIQUE | CN | MEDIUM | AQUATIC | FEY | WATER

Variant female nereid (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 182)

Perception +24; low-light vision

Languages Aquan, Common, Sylvan

Skills Athletics +17 (+23 to swim), Deception +27, Diplomacy +27, First World Lore +25, Stealth +27

Str +0, **Dex** +8, **Con** +5, **Int** +4, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +8

AC 35; **Fort** +22, **Ref** +27, **Will** +24

HP 210; **Immunities** poison; **Weaknesses** cold iron 15

Watery Transparency (primal, transmutation, water) As nereid.

Speed 25 feet, swim 50 feet

Melee ❖ poisonous touch +27 (agile, finesse, magical), **Damage** 8d6 poison

Primal Innate Spells DC 33; **7th** *heal* (×3), *summon elemental* (water elementals only); **6th** *elemental form* (×3, water only), *restoration* (×3), *suggestion*; **5th** *control water*

Drowning Touch ❖❖ (conjuration, incapacitation, primal, water) As nereid, but DC 33 Fortitude save.

Manifest Shawl ❖❖❖ (conjuration, primal) As nereid. Evindra currently does not posses her shawl.

EVINDRA'S SHAWL

30 XP

The gardener stole Evindra's shawl many years ago and used this leverage to force her into the water clock. She's not sure where the shawl went but suspects that whoever killed the gardener and took the magic sword she had been entrusted to guard has it now.

Source: Evindra (area **A16**).

Completion: The PCs must recover the shawl from the dungeon below Irovetti's palace and return it to Evindra.

Reward: Evindra agrees to tell the PCs all she knows about *Briar*'s history, Nyrissa, and the danger the nymph poses to the Stolen Lands; she may even remain with the PCs as an ally if they wish. Evindra's revelations about *Briar* and Nyrissa are detailed on page 426 of Chapter 10.

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PART 4:

INFILTRATION

As the War of the River Kings progresses, King Irovetti's fear causes him to seclude himself in his palace. If Pitax is doing poorly in the war, his primary concern is retribution from the PCs; if his armies are doing well, he instead worries that public appearances will expose him to potential assassins. In either case, Irovetti is readying for a direct attack—but he isn't preparing for the PCs to stoke insurrection among his people.

Many of Pitax's citizens rankle and chafe at their king's rule, but on their own they lack the gumption, outrage, and bravery to stand up to him. With some careful work, canny PCs can turn Pitax's citizens against their king and weaken his hold on them, making the inevitable confrontation against him in his palace less dangerous.

THE CITY OF PITAX

For nearly 400 years, Pitax remained a relatively small and unassuming city. Though marred by strife with neighboring nations, and even suffering some scars from a brief but brutal civil war, Pitax always stood as a sanctuary of sorts at the edge of the Stolen Lands. With the arrival of just one man only six years ago, however, this legacy changed. As the bandit king Castruccio Irovetti took control of Pitax, the city began to mirror his dark and brutal personality, becoming a force to be reckoned with in the River Kingdoms and drawing the ire and envy of the lands surrounding it.

By far, the most startling change made to Pitax by the decree of Irovetti has been his ham-fisted attempt

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to focus upon the fine arts. Determined to make Pitax a center of genteel refinement and culture, Irovetti ordered the construction of the Red Crescent theater, which became the cornerstone of other revitalized parts of Pitax. The city grew, attracting many actors, musicians, and other artists, causing the city's coffers to swell with fresh gold. But by bringing in so many new souls, Pitax suddenly found a sinister, unsavory element becoming a part of its very core.

The presence of so many bards and storytellers from so many places has made the city a haven for secrets, rumors, tall tales, and occasionally even the truth. If one seeks information that might be little more than whispers and dust, Pitax might be the place to unearth clues. What sages don't know, Pitax often does. The only trick to finding rare secrets in Pitax—secrets that could possibly lead to treasures or dooms beyond imagination—is knowing where to look.

That, and perhaps living long enough to escape with these secrets.

PITAX — SETTLEMENT 10

CN CITY

Government King (overlord)

Population 5,781 (4,706 humans, 320 halflings, 260 gnomes, 200 half-elves, 100 elves, 60 goblins, 95 dwarves, 40 other)

Languages Common, Elven, Halfling, Gnome, Hallit

Religions Calistria, Desna

Threats criminals, political corruption, the PCs' kingdom

Performer's City Pitax prides itself on the diversity of its arts and entertainments, but at the same time has a legacy of artists and performers being unjustly persecuted for their work. Treat Pitax as a 14th-level settlement for determining the availability of jobs for Performance and art-themed Crafting or Lore attempts to Earn Income. If a PC critically fails at an attempt to Earn Income using these skills, they have angered someone enough that repercussions will occur—be it an arrest by Pitax Wardens or even an assassination attempt by an outraged former fan of their work.

Annamede Belavarah (CN female human bard 13) Famous comedian and agitator against Irovetti

Atlee Quinge (NG female human bard 7) Director of the Red Crescent Troupe

Castruccio Irovetti (CE male human bard 16) King of Pitax

Drey Yarness (CN male human cleric of Calistria 10) High priest of Calistria

Eliste Strocalle (NE female human rogue 8) Leader of the Strocalle Bandit House

Gasperre Liacenza (N male human aristocrat 5) Leader of the Liacenza Bandit House

Ghare Leotos (CG male human cleric of Desna 6) High priest of Desna

Jhofre Vascari (LN male human rogue 9) Leader of the Vascari Bandit House

Kharne Vareel (NE male gnome rogue 13) Ringleader of the Dealers of Pitax

Salvarri Cattanei (N male human bard 8) Leader of the Cattanei Bandit House

THE EIGHT FACTIONS

On the surface, Irovetti rules Pitax, but a deeper look into the city's political landscape reveals a more complex situation. Before Irovetti's arrival, eight factions held different degrees of influence over the city. Some of them supported Pitax's rulers while others opposed them, and this hasn't changed with the new rule, although the factions tread carefully in how they interact with Irovetti—he has already proven to some of them that he has the temperament and the power to break them if they cross him.

Each of these eight factions traditionally identifies itself with specific colors, symbols, and types of clothing. This information is presented in the Eight Factions table on page 368, while additional details are given below.

The Bandit Houses

Long ago, a group of bandits fleeing reprisal in Brevoy founded the safehold that would become Pitax. Their leader became the patriarch of the Cattanei family, esteemed residents who ruled over Pitax during the early centuries of its existence. Descendants of the other original bandits also formed three other influential families: the Liacenzas, the Vascaris, and the Strocalles. And while today these four families operate more as merchant cartels than criminals, tradition has kept their label as the Bandit Houses of Pitax. Today, three of the four Bandit Houses own and control their own warehouses, which serve as their means of conducting business. The fourth family, the Liacenzas, recently lost control of their Trade House to Irovetti, but for the time being, they retain enough influence in town to remain an important faction.

Dealers of Pitax

The main rival to the Bandit Houses is a loose coalition of despicable merchants, drug dealers, and criminals who seek to win fortune for themselves at the expense of Pitax's honest traders. Pitax's criminal underground wields formidable influence in the city, and with the arrival of Irovetti, their power—and ambition—grows daily. These criminals are referred to collectively as the Dealers of Pitax, and increasingly, a gnome man named Kharne Vereel serves as the one they look to for leadership. Kharne and his favored agents can be found at the Rose Tower (see area **B6**).

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THE EIGHT FACTIONS

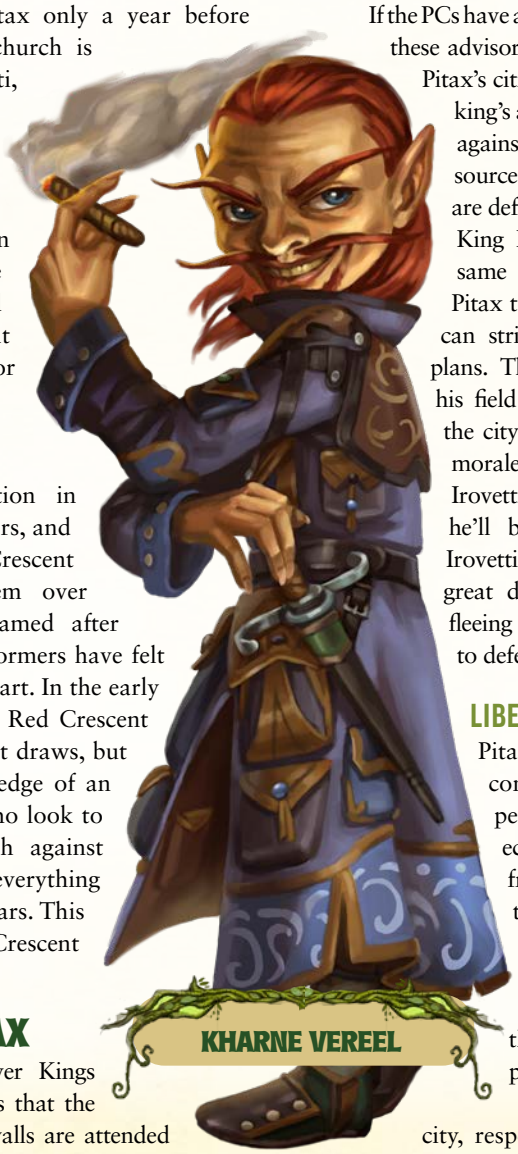
Faction	Type	Color	Symbol	Clothing
Calistrians	Faith	Black, yellow	three daggers	religious raiment
Cattanei Family	Bandit House	Green	coiled snake	black vest with green thread
Dealers of Pitax	Criminals	Gray	two X marks	long coat with hidden pouches
Desnans	Faith	Blue, white	butterfly	religious raiment
Liacenza Family	Bandit House	Dark red	fox's head	left glove with a dark red mark
Red Crescent Troupe	Entertainers	Red, black	crescent	gaudy, blue and purple outfits
Strocalle Family	Bandit House	Purple	cracked coin	long sash attached to belt
Vascari Family	Bandit House	Light blue	blue heron	blue tabard with large collar

Pitax's Churches

While Pitax itself isn't a particularly religious city, two churches in particular have widespread favor. The church of Calistria (see area **B13**) is the more powerful, as it represents the oldest religious tradition in the area. The church of Desna (see area **B8**) is relatively new, having arrived in Pitax only a year before Irovetti himself. Neither church is particularly fond of Irovetti, but each has their reasons for not taking a harder stance against him. One would perhaps expect a temple of Shelyn in a town purportedly devoted to the arts, but the city's general attitude ironically makes it an unwelcoming place for this faith.

The Red Crescent Troupe

The newest notable faction in Pitax are the actors, directors, and playwrights of the Red Crescent troupe. Irovetti won them over by financing a theater named after them, and as such the performers have felt indebted to him from the start. In the early years of Irovetti's rule, the Red Crescent was among the city's largest draws, but the troupe is now on the edge of an internal schism as those who look to rebel against Irovetti clash against those who fear losing everything they've built up over the years. This faction is based in the Red Crescent Theater (area **B17**).



KHARNE VEREEL

LIBERATING PITAX

Once the War of the River Kings begins, King Irovetti ensures that the war machines on the city walls are attended at all times and he orders his Pitax Wardens to regularly patrol the city streets. Civil unrest grows quickly, as factions and groups within Pitax that have long loathed being under Irovetti's rule grow restless and, in some cases, openly resistant. When the PCs come to Pitax, they find the city bristling with soldiers and ready for a battle or a siege.

If the PCs have allied with Pitaxian rebels such as Ilora, these advisors impress upon the PCs that most of Pitax's citizens are innocents caught up in their king's agenda, and they strongly recommend against attacking or besieging the city. These sources suggest that once Pitax's field armies are defeated and Avinash's forces are routed, King Irovetti's bravado will falter. At the same time, clandestine infiltrations into Pitax to destabilize his support from within can strike a devastating blow to Irovetti's plans. Through a combination of defeating his field armies and turning factions within the city against him, the PCs can break the morale of the Pitaxian army and force King Irovetti to retreat into his palace, whereupon he'll be cornered. These allies point to Irovetti's legendary stubbornness as another great disadvantage, for he won't consider fleeing "his" kingdom as long as the chance to defeat the PCs exists.

LIBERATION ACTIVITIES

Pitax is a nation united under a competent and canny leader. Irovetti's people may not love him, and his eccentricities regarding the arts frustrate and bewilder many, but they'd rather have him on their side than against them... at least until his bold and daring war of conquest threatens to bankrupt the kingdom and bring it from prosperity to ruin.

If the PCs wish to preserve the city, respect its citizens, and potentially set

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themselves up as saviors instead of proving that they're the warmongers Irovetti's propaganda portrays them as, they'll need to pursue more subtle tactics than throwing armies against the city walls. They can pursue this goal using Liberation activities. Doing so awards Liberation Points (or penalizes them in the case of failures). Liberation Points can also be gained or (more often) lost through other developments, as summarized in the Liberation Point Adjustments table on page 370.

Liberation activities play out in Exploration mode. Unless otherwise specified, a Liberation activity takes 3 hours to resolve, so during a typical day (which assumes the PCs spend 8 hours resting, 1 hour taking daily preparations, and 3 hours eating, relaxing, and potentially performing other exploration activities) a PC can attempt four Liberation activities.

The primary way in which the PCs earn Liberation Points is by discovering and pursuing opportunities keyed to specific locations in Pitax. A PC can certainly discover a location's liberation activities by stumbling on the location and asking the right questions, but it's perhaps more efficient for a PC to use the Seek Opportunity activity instead to learn about these specific opportunities.

Initial Liberation Points: If the PCs won the Rushlight Tournament, their fame precedes them and they begin with 6 Liberation Points. If they made second place, they start with 3 Liberation Points. Otherwise, they start with 1 Liberation Point. Add 2 Liberation points for each battle the PCs have won against any of Pitax's field armies, and subtract 2 for each such battle lost.

30+ Liberation Points: Once the PCs accumulate at least 30 Liberation Points, the atmosphere on Pitax's streets grows very decidedly anti-Irovetti. As long as the PCs' Liberation Point total remains at 30 or higher, no Warden patrols are encountered on the streets of Pitax, and the number of guards and defenses present at the palace is reduced as detailed in Part 5. Once Irovetti is defeated, it will be much easier for the PCs to bring Pitax into their kingdom if they have at least 30 Liberation Points (see the end of this chapter).

0 Liberation Points: Liberation Points can't be reduced below 0. As long as the PCs are at 0 Liberation Points, they suffer a –4 status penalty on all checks made to resolve Liberation activities. If something would normally cause Liberation Points to go below 0, the PCs are instead confronted by two Warden patrols (a Severe 14 encounter) or increase the status penalty to Liberation checks to –4 for the next 24 hours (GM's choice). If the PCs are at 0 Liberation Points in their quest to free Pitax when a Kingdom turn begins, enough volunteers join the Pitaxian army that a new Pitax Horde field army (page 353) encamps in a hex of the GM's choice along the border of the PCs' kingdom.

LAYING SIEGE TO PITAX

If the PCs wish to lay siege to Pitax, they must station at least four separate 13th-level or higher armies in the hex containing the city. The presence of these armies is enough to blockade the city from gaining supplies, but while this tactic can certainly reduce Irovetti's morale, it will also bring harm and suffering to the city's citizens and make them less able to help the PCs. Each week that Pitax remains under siege, all Liberation activities the PCs attempt in the city suffer a cumulative –1 circumstance penalty (maximum –4 after four weeks of siege).

An all-out attack on the city isn't a much better option. In this case, Irovetti draws upon all four of his war machine armies (see page 373) to defend the city. These siege engines start the battle fortified, but if the PCs' armies can take them down, they'll force the king to retreat to his palace, at a significant cost in damage to the city itself. Once the PCs attack Pitax, they cannot pursue Liberation activities within the city for one month, as its citizens are too fearful for their lives.

WARDEN PATROLS LOW 14

Trios of Pitax Wardens patrol the city streets, and they confront the PCs if they notice them. Generally, such a confrontation occurs only when the PCs fail or critically fail at certain Liberation activities, but at your option (such as if the PCs make an extremely public appearance), they are confronted by a Warden patrol that attacks them at once. If characters wish to escape the Warden patrol, you can have them attempt an Acrobatics, Athletics, Deception, or Stealth check against the Pitax Wardens' Reflex DC to see if they can get away, with a failure resulting in a fight. Once an encounter with a Warden patrol finishes, if the PCs don't use their next Exploration activity to Lie Low, they lose 1d4+2 Liberation Points as a result of increased patrols spreading fear through the populace.

PITAX WARDENS (3) CREATURE 12

See page 336

Perception +22

LIBERATION ACTIVITIES

Liberation activities can be taken at any point, and do not need to be "unlocked" by visiting a specific location in Pitax. When the PCs first begin to work at liberating the city, you should provide them with a list of all of these activities so they'll know what options are available for them to pursue. Liberation points may only be earned once per success or critical success, regardless of how many attempts are made.

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LIBERATION POINT ADJUSTMENTS

Each time the following events occurs, adjust the PCs' current Liberation Point (LP) total as indicated.

The PCs slay a Pitax civilian: –5 LP

One of Pitax's field armies is defeated: +2 LP

One of Pitax's field armies wins a battle: –2 LP

The PCs cause public destruction in Pitax: –1 to –5 LP (varies, with examples including –1 for minor vandalism or –5 for destroying a building)

The PCs do not Lie Low after an encounter with a Warden patrol: –1d4+2 LP

The PCs attack Pitax with an army: LP can no longer be gained for 1 month

CLANDESTINE ACTIVITY

EXPLORATION MOVE

You spend time pursuing urban activities in Pitax that don't directly impact the city's liberation. When you shop for items, gather information, craft, attempt to earn income, or take other Exploration or Downtime pursuits, you automatically attract the attention of a Warden patrol unless you make that activity clandestine. To do so, attempt a Deception, Society, or Stealth check to trick observers, appear as if you belong, or simply avoid notice.

Critical Success The activity takes no more time than normal, and you avoid attracting the attention of any Pitax Wardens.

Success The activity takes twice as long to finish, but you avoid attracting the attention of any Pitax Wardens.

Failure After spending half the time on the activity, you attract the attention of a Warden patrol. If you immediately halt your activity and do not complete it, you avoid a confrontation with the Pitax Wardens. If you don't stop your activity, this result becomes a Critical Failure.

Critical Failure As failure, but you cannot avoid the Pitax Wardens, and have an encounter with a Warden patrol.

GAIN FACTION FAVOR

CONCENTRATE EXPLORATION

You spend time speaking with the leaders of a faction you've made contact with, and you attempt to gain favor with them so that when the time comes to take control of Pitax, they can aid in spreading your influence and helping to get the citizens of Pitax on your side. When you seek to Gain Faction Favor, you can always do so by attempting a DC 34 Diplomacy check. You can also attempt a different DC 30 skill check or Lore check as noted in the location entry for that faction.

Critical Success The faction is impressed with you. Gain 2 LP, and you may use that faction's headquarters as a safe haven in Pitax—any Exploration or Downtime activities that don't require open travel in the city can be performed at this safe haven without needing to be a Clandestine Activity.

Success The faction agrees to support you. Gain 1 LP.

Failure You fail to gain favor with the faction, but you can try again the next day.

Critical Failure You insult or antagonize the faction. Lose 1 LP; you cannot attempt to gain favor again with this faction for 1 month.

LIE LOW

EXPLORATION

When Pitax Wardens grow too suspicious or up their patrols, all PCs can spend 3 hours deliberately avoiding confrontation, hiding, and keeping an eye out for when the coast is clear to continue exploration. If you aren't in a safe spot (such as a refuge provided by a faction, or a location the GM has decided is secluded enough) you must attempt a DC 30 Stealth check (you can Follow the Expert for this check). If you are in a safe spot, no roll is needed; you automatically achieve a Success result.

Success Things calm down on the streets enough that you can go back to pursuing Liberation activities.

Failure Things remain tense, but if you Lie Low again for your next action, you achieve a Success automatically even if you aren't in a safe spot.

Critical Failure You've been found or ratted out! All PCs have an encounter with a Warden patrol.

PURSUE OPPORTUNITY

CONCENTRATE EXPLORATION

Most locations in Pitax detail opportunities for the party to earn Liberation Points. The details of each varies according to the location, but the mechanics remain the same. Once you've discovered an opportunity, attempt a DC 32 check using the skill called for by that opportunity. You can continue to Pursue an Opportunity multiple times until you critically succeed at it, but only earn Liberation Points once the first time you succeed or critically succeed at this activity.

Critical Success Earn 2 Liberation Points and gain an additional minor boon or advantage as detailed in the location's Opportunity entry.

Success Earn 1 Liberation Point.

Critical Failure Lose 1 Liberation Point.

RESEARCH FACTION

CONCENTRATE EXPLORATION SECRET

Once you discover one of Pitax's factions, you can spend time gathering information and investigating that faction to learn more about it. To do so, attempt a DC 32 Society check. Unless you have a critical failure, you learn basic information about the faction, including the name of its leader, the location of its headquarters, and a bit about their goals.

Critical Success You learn what the faction's associated skill is, along with additional information that gives

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you a +2 circumstance bonus on checks made to Gain Favor with that Faction.

Success You learn what the faction's associated skill is.

Critical Failure As success, but the information you learn is false.

SEEK OPPORTUNITY

EXPLORATION | MOVE

You ask around town, eavesdrop on conversations, and keep an eye on the streets to search for opportunities to liberate Pitax. When you Seek Opportunity, choose a spot on the map of Pitax, then attempt a DC 34 Perception check or a DC 30 Society check as your character Seeks Opportunities nearby.

Critical Success You learn of the two closest opportunities to the position you chose. The GM reveals the location of these opportunities on the map; you must still travel to that location and investigate on site to determine what sort of opportunity exists. If no more opportunities exist in Pitax to discover, you learn that fact instead.

Success As critical success, but only the one closest opportunity.

Critical Failure You attract too much attention, and if your next activity within 1,500 feet of the spot you chose is anything other than Lie Low, that activity attracts a Warden patrol.

EXPLORING PITAX

A hundred years ago, Pitax endured a small but bloody civil war in which the northern part of the kingdom seceded and formed a small realm known as Corvenn. The violence between Pitax and Corvenn culminated in an incident known as the Deafening Flames, when rebels from Corvenn torched the southern wall of Pitax and razed the southern half of the city. Though Corvenn and Pitax eventually resolved their differences and merged back into a single River Kingdom, the damage was done. The southern half of Pitax lay in ruin for decades, just a pile of rubble and lingering ashes.

Recent additions to the entire city can be found in the form of statues, particularly gargoyles. Commissioned by Irovetti himself to mimic the historic pomp of aged southern cities, most of these statues are disgusting or crude works of monsters or human figures—sometimes both. Many of the gargoyles that sit ominously atop rooftops in Pitax—especially those closest to the palace where Irovetti resides—are works of genuine quality, but over the past few years, more sloppy and crude efforts have spread across Pitax like a disease.

The wharfside of **Troutmouth** is a strange mix of hardworking warehouse workers living with their families and freebooting sailors who drift in and out of the city with their ships. Though this often leads to loud and boisterous conflicts between the two groups in the wee hours of the morning, both the workers and the sailors share a grudging respect for one another. The two groups are unified by a shared loathing for the Bandit Houses, which they believe to be rich, selfish, and indifferent to their problems. Wooden warehouses standing amid smaller wooden buildings line the docks of Troutmouth. Of these smaller buildings, most are old and weatherworn, with even the newer buildings bearing obvious water damage from the Pitax River's occasional floods. Muddy roads crisscross their way through Troutmouth, but these slowly give way to cobblestone streets as they finally enter the Shattered Ward and the heart of Pitax.

Long the spiritual heart of Pitax, the **Shattered Ward** grew from the remnants of the bandit keep built during the city's earliest days. This is where most merchants and travelers conduct their business. Its streets are the busiest, its buildings the largest, and its shadows the most likely to hide secrets and dangers. Large buildings made of dark limestone, some several stories in height, rise throughout this area, surrounding the Common Square like stones ringing a campfire. A large wall known as the Inner Fortress, made from limestone of a lighter hue, runs along the southern border of the Shattered Ward.

Old and new gates alike lead from that wall into the **New Ruins**, the part of Pitax that was once overrun and destroyed during the city's bloody civil war a century earlier. New stone roads and small stone buildings, built from the remains of the great towers that once stood proudly over the city in earlier days, stand amid the genuine ruins in this partially rebuilt sector. When Irovetti ascended to power, he proceeded to take ownership of this area that had long lain fallow, and he began rebuilding it according to his own garish tastes. The Red Crescent Theater and the Academy of Grand Arts became the heart of the revitalized west end of Pitax. Though both were built ostensibly for the purpose of making Pitax a haven for fine art, Irovetti had a shrewder purpose in mind: attracting builders, artists, and merchants, and, by extension, more money. The New Ruins now presents a half-realized appearance, with the sculpted stone facades of buildings along the Inner Fortress turning to carved wood and eventually to plain timber near the edge of town. At its farthest reaches, public funding and interest waned, leaving several blocks of aging rubble and dangerous, burnt-out frames available for whatever squatters or dangerous creatures dare to claim them.

CITY WALLS

Pitax's stone city walls are strong and sturdy, oft repaired and enhanced—particularly over the past year as Irovetti has had increasing convictions that his city should be more fortified. The walls themselves offer few handholds—it's a

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DC 30 Athletics check to Climb them—but their primary purpose is to provide numerous points of fortification for a wide range of ballistae, catapults, and other siege engines. The king makes sure to keep these well-attended, ensuring that any attempt to take Pitax by force will pay dearly for the attempt.

PITAX WAR MACHINES (4) ARMY 14

CN SIEGE

Scouting +25

Description These siege weapons are positioned atop all of the city's watchtowers and afford a controlling view of all approaches.

AC 36; **Maneuver** +22; **Morale** +28

HP 8 (RT 4)

Ranged siege engine +29 (7 shots)

Tactics Efficient Ammunition, Explosive Shot, Toughened Soldiers (2)

PITAX LOCATIONS

Details on the most significant locations in the city of Pitax are presented on the following pages. Each location (other than Irovetti's palace itself) gives the PCs a chance to earn Liberation Points and other advantages when they Pursue Opportunity (page 370), or serves as the headquarters for one of the eight factions and includes information on how to Gain Faction Favor (page 370). Remember, regardless of the skill used to Pursue Opportunity or Gain Faction Favor, it's a DC 32 check.

B1. THE DEVIL'S TUSKS

Pitax makes its home along a tributary of the Sellen River known as the Pitax River, a place known for its treacherous rapids. Here, two small peninsulas jut out from the shore, forming a natural gateway and protective harbor. Those unfamiliar with navigating the narrow strait between the peninsulas—the Devil's Tusks, known more informally as the Tusks—quickly find their ships stuck on the jagged rocks lurking just beneath the water's surface. A pair of lighthouses, one on each of the Tusks, serve as beacons to guide ships safely into the harbor, but presently only the southern lighthouse functions as originally intended.

Pursue Opportunity: If the PCs seek out and contact the eastern lighthouse's attendant **Saufie Cintost** (CN female human lightkeeper 5), a stocky woman with an endlessly creative penchant for foul-mouthed but good-natured jokes, they can attempt a Diplomacy check to convince her to aid the rebellion by misleading enemy ships, flashing signals as needed, or observing harbor traffic. On a critical success, she'll give the PCs two *greater healing potions* to aid them in their fight against Irovetti.

B2. MOONDOCK

Once past the Tusks, ships sailing into Pitax find four smallish wooden docks along the city's shores. The docks are prominently flanked by warehouses owned by the major Trade Houses.

Only one average-sized ship is allowed to dock at each of the four piers at any given time, which often proves problematic during heavy trading seasons. Savvy merchants with ships headed to Pitax usually provide their captains with handsome bribes to pay the Trade Houses of the city to shorten their wait for docking time.

Pursue Opportunity: Several dockworkers do what they can to help smuggle those in danger out of the city, but their methods and tactics could use some improvement. The PCs can attempt a Stealth check to teach the dockworkers a few quick trade secrets on how to smuggle. On a critical success, a dockworker reveals that, less than a month ago, he peeked into a shipment that was to be delivered to Irovetti's palace and was surprised to see a crate full of clockwork parts and explosives. He later did some research and determined that these parts could be used to craft automatically-firing crossbows or debilitating bombs. Until the PCs came along, the worker hadn't met anyone he trusted to share this knowledge with. Armed with it, the PCs gain a +4 circumstance bonus on Perception and skill checks made to notice or disarm the clockwork crossbow or flash-bang traps in the palace (see page 381).

B3. RIVERSONG TRADE HOUSE

From this large warehouse, the Vascari family controls trade with the ships that come to Pitax. As a result, every sailor in Pitax owes at least a little allegiance to the Vascaris, since if word gets out that the crew of a ship has been disrespectful or treacherous against the Vascaris, that ship can find itself never getting scheduled time for official import, limiting their trade opportunities to illicit markets or smuggling operations.

The Vascaris follow the rule of **Jhofre Vascari** (LN male human rogue 9). At a young age, Jhofre departed the city; he then spent much of his life as an ordinary merchant captain, establishing contacts along the length of the Sellen River. Despite his lineage, the other Bandit Houses and most citizens view Jhofre as an outsider, so his influence is diminished.

Gain Faction Favor: The PCs can attempt to Gain Faction Favor with the Vascaris using Society or Mercantile Lore.

B4. IRON FOX ARMORY

The Liacenzas based their operations in this building for many years, but in the span of just a few weeks,

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the previous leaders, brothers Lothaire and Berengar, lost control of the Iron Fox Trade House to Irovetti in a series of bizarre incidents culminating in some very unfortunate games of chance. Two short weeks after that, the two brothers disappeared without a trace. Irovetti now uses his newly renamed Iron Fox Armory as a staging ground for the Pitax Wardens' patrols.

Pursue Opportunity: Traffic through the Iron Fox Armory is constant and brisk, but there are gaps every now and then where the building is mostly empty. During this time, the PCs can Pursue an Opportunity by attempting a trained Thievery check to sabotage armor and weapons stored here. On a critical success, the work is so effective that, from this point onward, all Pitax Wardens fought by the PCs during this chapter receive a –1 item penalty to their AC and attack rolls as their gear has been tampered with in ways that they never quite catch on to.



JHOFRE VASCARI

B5. THE DWARF'S CAVE

Near Moondock sits a short, squat building reminiscent of its stout owner, Shipmaster of the Yards **Joravin Pyathe** (N male dwarven fighter 8). Appointed to his position by the Liacenza brothers during their rule of Pitax, the shipmaster keeps close watch over the goods that make their way between the ships and city, ensuring that merchants coming into the city pay the appropriate tariffs for their goods. Though none of the Bandit Houses particularly like Pyathe, he acts as an arbiter for disputes between the various families, and his gruff but fair disposition means that he never shows favorites. Although Irovetti's tendency to implement arbitrary adjustments to shipping codes and taxes often makes Joravin an unwelcome sight on the docks, the dwarf proves adept at deflecting ire from himself to the city's lord.

Pursue Opportunity: The PCs can use Diplomacy to Pursue an Opportunity with Joravin to convince him to increase those "arbitrary adjustments" on anything associated with Irovetti or the Pitax Wardens while relaxing things going to the Bandit Houses slightly. On a critical success, word gets back to the Bandit Houses about the PC's influence—from this point on, reduce all of the DCs for Gaining Faction Favor by 2.

B6. THE ROSE TOWER

Raids by river pirates caused significant damage to this structure, rendering it inoperable. Seeing no immediate need to repair this lighthouse, the Trade Houses let it lie abandoned for years. In recent times, though, several allied groups of drug dealers and alchemists have taken over its ruins, using the lower levels as a laboratory to concoct their stupefying tinctures.

These are the so-called Dealers of Pitax, and their current leader, **Kharne Vareel** (NE male gnome rogue 13) sees nothing but opportunity in how the fear of war has frightened the citizens, for during such times, the Dealers' wares are in even greater demand. Irovetti isn't interested in disrupting the drug trade flourishing in his city, far preferring it to the active banditry of the past, but he does demand that the Dealers provide him with a share of their profits. Vareel has paid the king's cut regularly so far, seeing it as something of a "sin tax" that helps the Dealers gain more traction among the desperate of Pitax.

Gain Faction Favor: The PCs can attempt to Gain Faction Favor with the Dealers using Intimidation or Underworld Lore.

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B7. TOWER OF THE FALLEN

In recent years, with the rebuilding of the New Ruins, the people of Pitax lost much of the land that they once used as a graveyard. For a brief time previous to this, they had buried most of their dead on a small hill just outside the city, but then learned—much to their dismay— that the burials had begun to attract ghouls. With few options apart from inviting more ghoul attacks, clerics of Calistria expanded and converted the basement of one of the largest of the city's guard towers into a hallowed sepulcher, and since that time, many of the respected dead of Pitax have been laid to rest in the tower's several new sub-basements in vaults meant to keep things in as well as out.

Pursue Opportunity: The ghouls that infest this area are individually not matches for the PCs, but they are tenacious and numerous. The PCs can Pursue an Opportunity here by attempting a Religion check to cull some of the ghouls and create divine wards that prevent them from returning. On a critical success, the churches of Desna and Calistria alike take note. This reduces the DCs to Gain Faction Favor with both religions by 2, and also sees agents from both churches granting the PCs a few scrolls as thanks: a *scroll of restoration (4th)*, a *scroll of heal (4th)*, and a *scroll of raise dead*.

B8. THE TEMPLE OF DESNA

Mostly ignored by the sailors coming into port, the Temple of Desna nevertheless has a small but faithful congregation of worshippers. The old but venerable priest **Ghare Leotos** (CG male human cleric 6) leads the services for these faithful and is responsible for organizing many of the festivities on Desna's holy days for the city. Since Irovetti took over, the priests here have trodden lightly, taking care not to anger their fickle king. So far, the tactic is working, which has emboldened some of the clergy into slowly expanding their efforts to support and aid those in the city who are oppressed or have fallen on hard times.

Gain Faction Favor: The PCs can attempt to Gain Faction Favor with the Desnans using Religion or Desna Lore.

B9. SERPENT'S BREATH TRADE HOUSE

Xapiri Yasmina (LE female human sorcerer 10), a mysterious merchant from Cheliax, recently purchased controlling interest in the Serpent's Breath Trade House. While the Cattaneis themselves wanted no part of this deal, they were forced to accept it lest they succumb to complete financial ruin. Today, the Trade House functions primarily as a base of operations for Xapiri's studies into sorcery as she seeks proof of her theory that infernal influences on a person's blood make them more suited to leadership, and that hellspawn tieflings should be idolized and encouraged rather than vilified as examples of weakness by House Thrune. She has been using the Trade House's revenue to fund these investigations and experiments, with the needs of the Cattaneis often being set aside, marginalized, or entirely ignored. What Xapiri has told no one is that she didn't leave Cheliax voluntarily but was forced to flee when House Thrune caught wind of her research.

Though the Cattanei family had the greatest role in founding Pitax, its influence in the city diminished with each passing year. The actions of the traitor Ludov Cattanei a hundred years ago weakened their reputation, and the civil war that followed shortly thereafter nearly destroyed them. The Cattaneis, along with their Serpent's Breath Trade House, possess just a fraction of the wealth of the other Houses, yet they cling tenaciously to their legacy. **Salvarri Cattanei** (N male human bard 8) saw the influx of money from Xapiri's purchase as a chance to rebuild his family's reputation, but now he's coming to realize he may have sold more than the Trade House itself.

Gain Faction Favor: The PCs can attempt to Gain Faction Favor with the Cattaneis using Society or Mercantile Lore.

Pursue Opportunity: Xapiri has largely ignored the politics of the region, but after watching or observing her for a time, the PCs might notice that she seems nervous about something. The PCs can Pursue an Opportunity with a Perception check to realize she's fearful of Chelish agents finding her. A success or critical success at this check doesn't grant Liberation Points but does allow the PCs to attempt a DC 32 Deception check to convince Xapiri that there are Chelish agents in the region. On a success at this check, she decides to take a lower profile and to lean into the role of a trader, focusing her efforts more on bolstering the Cattanei fortunes for the short term. This grants the PCs 1 Liberation Point and a +2 circumstance bonus on checks to Gain Faction Favor with the Cattaneis. On a critical success at this Deception check, Xapiri instead abandons Pitax entirely, leaving the Trade House fully in control of the Cattaneis. This grants the PCs 2 Liberation Points and either gives them an automatic Critical Success at Gaining Faction Favor with the Cattaneis (if the PCs haven't attempted this yet) or earns them a reward of 250 pp from the grateful Bandit House (if they have already gained favor).

B10. DARKWIND TRADE HOUSE

The Darkwind Trade House is run by the Strocalle family and focuses on trade that comes and goes from the city via land routes. While this Trade House continues to do well (particularly during peak trade seasons when river trade is heavily moderated and controlled), the Strocalles have had to spend the majority of the income

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from these dealings to pay bribes, recruit protection, and otherwise fend off attempts by others who seek to horn in on their business.

No one in Pitax trusts the Strocalles. Their loyalties lie first with profit and second with members of their own house, with all others being a very distant third. Strocalle treachery weaves its way throughout the history of Pitax. Of all the families, the Strocalles maintain the closest ties with the city's criminal element. **Eliste Strocalle** (NE human female rogue 8) controls both the Darkwind Wind Trade House and the Strocalle family. Scheming and ambitious, her plotting proved instrumental in Irovetti's ascent to power. Her family's alliance with the city's ruler is stronger than many suspect, and she eventually plans—with Irovetti's help—to eliminate the other Trade Houses.



XAPIRI YASMINA

Gain Faction Favor: The PCs can attempt to Gain Faction Favor with the Strocalles using Society or Mercantile Lore, but due to their strong alliance with Irovetti, the DCs for checks to Gain Faction Favor with them are increased by 5 unless the PCs have already gained favor with the other three Bandit Houses, in which case peer pressure removes this DC increase.

B11. THE CROW'S FEATHER

This once sleepy inn doubles as the city's library, granting access to a hodgepodge collection of books to anyone with the coin to pay for a meal. The mead is watery and the bread is stale, but this matters little to its scholarly patrons. Though the Crow's Feather remained a little-known oddity to the citizens of Pitax for years, the recent influx of scholars and artists has transformed the small tavern into a bustling meeting place, constantly filled at all hours with would-be academics. A curmudgeonly fellow by the name of **Roald Celinnas** (LN male human wizard 8) owns the inn. Thought to be the great-grandson of a wizard from Brevoy, Celinnas publicly shows little interest in magic and claims to have found his vast collection of writings "in a box somewhere." He gladly lets those interested in the collection read through whatever they like, but only so long as they do so in the confines of the Crow's Feather while ordering from its overpriced menu. Although no part of the collection is for sale, Roald does accept trades—though his measure of what marks a book's worth is a mystery only he knows the answer to—and he seems to have an uncanny sense of who might be scheming to rob him.

Pursue Opportunity: The PCs can Pursue an Opportunity here by attempting an Arcana check to talk shop with Roald while simultaneously working to convince him to aid the PCs' liberation efforts. On a critical success, he agrees to let the PCs use the back rooms of the Crow's Feather as a place to hide out, giving the PCs a refuge in town. Additionally, he'll relate to the PCs that he's heard rumors that several of Irovetti's closest allies—and perhaps even his current consort—are monsters capable of changing shape. This information grants the PCs a +2 circumstance bonus to Perception checks when determining the effectiveness of any creature in the palace that uses magic to adopt a disguise.

B12. THE COMMON SQUARE

Most residents of the Shattered Ward congregate in the Common Square daily, particularly in the early hours

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of the morning and at high noon when the bells of Calistria's cathedral ring loudest. These are the times when the town criers of Pitax appear in the square, announcing the important news of the day and the events of days to come. Merchants and nobles gather in the square to meet and conduct their business, often sitting side by side on the wooden benches circling the giant Fountain of Sorrows, which commemorates those lost in the recent civil war.

The Common Square also draws crowds to its two other prominent features: the stocks and the yardarm (a mast-like structure from which multiple offenders can be hanged and displayed at once). Criminals in Pitax are typically punished with branding, maiming, whipping, or hanging. Irovetti's Wardens mete out all of these punishments in the square, in full view of all those who choose to bear witness. Many of Pitax's citizens eagerly turn out to watch, enough so that bread and cheese vendors make handsome profits selling food to the crowds on the days of hangings.

The Common Square has long been the favored place for **Annamede Belavarah** (CN female human bard 13) to hold court. If the PCs have established a good relationship with her over the course of the adventure—and assuming she survived the hunt in Chapter 5—she'll notice them here and offer her aid in helping to resist Irovetti. With Annamede's help, one PC every 3 hours automatically gains a +2 circumstance bonus from Annamede's assistance on any Liberation activity that relies on a Deception, Diplomacy, Intimidation, Performance, or Society check.

Pursue Opportunity: The PCs can Pursue an Opportunity here to encourage performance-based criticisms of the king and even direct protests with a Performance check. On a critical success, word of the scathing performances gets particularly under Irovetti's skin; as a result, he grows increasingly distracted by these reports and his own efforts to come up with rebuttals—he suffers a –2 penalty on Perception checks for the remainder of this chapter.

B13. CALISTRIA'S CATHEDRAL

This cathedral—a building converted from the last remnants of the original keep built by the Cattanei family and the other original settlers of Pitax—is where most of the citizens of Pitax worship. The cathedral's walls are worn and battered, but those who live in Pitax like it that way. The building stands as a symbol that no matter what happens, Pitax stands above the fray. Lending credence to this is **Drey Yarness** (CN male human cleric 10), a middle-aged priest and notorious bachelor who watches over the cathedral. Fit and possessing a sharp tongue, Yarness knows much about the city and what goes on within its walls; some say he knows far more than a simple clergyman has any right. As one of Irovetti's sharpest critics, Drey has drawn a fair number of admirers to his church—people who seek leadership from someone other than their current king more than those who are particularly interested in worshipping Calistria. For now, Irovetti's fear of potentially angering the goddess of revenge has kept him from publicly reacting to Drey's attitudes, but it's growing more and more difficult for the king to resist his urge to send his Wardens into the cathedral in an attempt to have its high priest replaced.

Gain Faction Favor: The PCs can attempt to Gain Faction Favor with the Calistrians using Religion or Calistria Lore.

B14. THE TURNING WHEEL

On windy days, the sharp smell of cheese fills the air of east Pitax. This odor emanates from a small, broken tower known as the Turning Wheel, a butcher and cheese shop famed for its foodstuffs. The Wheel serves all of Pitax from its lowliest sailors to its richest merchants, and it's one of the city's more popular attractions. **Ingras Quill** (CG female human cheesemaker 5), its ever-cheerful, middle-aged proprietress, greets all who visit the Wheel, and her ribald jokes attract as many patrons as the food itself. Her weekly shipments to the palace to deliver fresh wares to Irovetti have afforded her a fair amount of goodwill from the king, but what few (particularly Irovetti himself) ever see, however, is Ingras's loathing for the Pitax Wardens, who callously slaughtered her son for some arbitrary affront a few years ago. Ever since then, a secret room in the Turning Wheel's basement has served as a meeting place and safe house for any who would bring harm to the city's ruler or have need to keep watch on the palace nearby.

Pursue Opportunity: The PCs can Pursue an Opportunity here to encourage Ingras to step up her efforts to provide shelter to people persecuted by the Wardens by attempting a Diplomacy check. On a critical success, the PCs can use the Turning Wheel as a refuge, and Ingras shares with them one of her closest guarded secrets—a journal in which she's kept exacting notes on guard patrols (including her suspicions of likely places for secret doors that grant the guard patrols shortcuts) in the palace. This information grants the PCs a +2 item bonus on initiative checks made against Pitax Wardens in the palace and to Perception checks to notice secret doors there.

B15. THE PALACE

Once the sprawling manse of an eccentric wizard, this estate—known simply as "the palace"—presently serves as home and headquarters to Irovetti and his loyal followers. Like most things accomplished by Irovetti in Pitax, the

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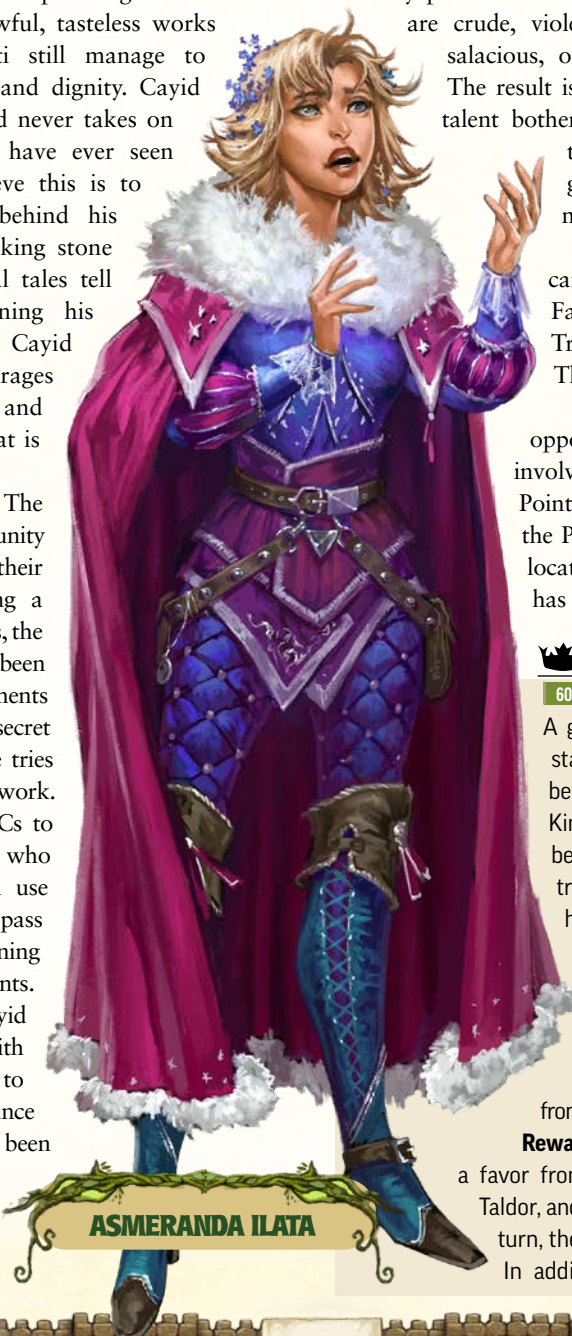
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bandit king's acquisition of the palace was both swift and sudden. Full details of Irovetti's stronghold can be found in Part 5.

B16. FACES OF STONE

Amid all of the artistic abominations to be found in Pitax, one shop, Faces of Stone, stands out as a ray of light and hope. The shop is run by sculptor **Cayid Caconna** (CN male human artisan 10), whose stone works—largely made from the limestone ruins of the fallen walls of Pitax—are genuinely exquisite, and nobles and merchants throughout the River Kingdoms commission work from him. He is responsible for the best of the gargoyle statues spreading across Pitax's rooftops, and even the awful, tasteless works commissioned by Irovetti still manage to retain vestiges of beauty and dignity. Cayid works mostly at night and never takes on apprentices; in fact, few have ever seen him at work. Most believe this is to guard the dark secret behind his remarkable knack for making stone appear almost alive—local tales tell of Cayid magically turning his artistic rivals into stone. Cayid himself humorously encourages such tales of foul magic and murder, as they flatter what is in actuality pure talent.

Pursue Opportunity: The PCs can Pursue an Opportunity here to impress Cayid with their own artistry by attempting a Crafting check. On a success, the PCs learn that Cayid has been including hidden compartments in his carvings as a sort of "secret signature" in case someone tries to claim ownership of his work. Learning this allows the PCs to spread word so that those who seek to resist Irovetti can use these compartments to pass notes or supplies, thus earning the PCs Liberation Points. On a critical success, Cayid reveals that when tasked with delivering some gargoyles to the palace, he had a chance to swipe a key that had been misplaced. He's not sure why he snatched it up—it was a spur of the moment urge—but he suspects that the PCs can make greater use of it. This key unlocks the door to the palace's service entrance at area **C10**.



ASMERANDA ILATA

B17. THE RED CRESCENT THEATER

Both a center for entertainment and a haven for learning, the Red Crescent Theater is where many a would-be actor seeks fame and fortune. A small group of actors directed by **Atlee Quinge** (NG female human bard 7) puts on elaborate productions every month at the behest of Irovetti. The king's mandate that the theater must "serve as an institute of learning" is partly a cover to recruit cheap performers; as a result, performances have suffered. Irovetti also insists the theater put on only productions that he likes, meaning that most are crude, violent, poorly written, tastelessly salacious, or a combination of all these. The result is that few actors with any true talent bother to work for the theater, and the shining promise it once held grows dimmer with each passing month.

Gain Faction Favor: The PCs can attempt to Gain Faction Favor with the Red Crescent Troupe using Performance or Theater Lore.

Pursue Opportunity: The opportunity presented here does not involve a check to earn Liberation Points; instead, Atlee approaches the PCs with the hope that they can locate one of the troupe's actors that has recently gone missing.

THE MISSING DIVA

60 XP

A group of actors worry that their star, singer Asmeranda Ilata, has been kidnapped by none other than King Irovetti, who seems to have become obsessed with her. The troupe suspects that she's being held somewhere in the palace, and their leader begs the PCs to find and rescue her.

Source: Atlee Quinge, leader of the Red Crescent.

Completion: Rescue Asmeranda from Irovetti's palace.

Reward: The Red Crescent calls in a favor from a wealthy patron in faraway Taldor, and at the start of the next Kingdom turn, the PCs receive a reward of 350 pp. In addition, Asmeranda offers to play

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any theater of the PCs' choice with her troupe, giving them the benefit of a Visiting Celebrity kingdom event.

B18. THE FALLING STAR

Owned by **Gasperre Liacenza** (N male human aristocrat 5), this ramshackle inn bustles with business both day and night. With most of the performers from the Red Crescent Theater and the students from the Academy of the Arts perpetually out of work, they have little to do but drink and smoke away their sorrows and look for any means of income possible. The rearmost haze-shrouded booths of the tavern are generally filled with the most hopeless causes, who have turned to narcotics instead of ale to dull their pain. The tavern also serves as a gathering place for those who conspire against Irovetti. Such patrons gather around tables, always keeping an eye on one another, trying to decide who works for whom, and what eyes and ears are within the structure's walls.

Until recently, the Liacenza family's Iron Fox Trade House was the city's most prosperous, giving them control over much of Pitax. Though the other Bandit Houses held influence over what happened in the city, the Liacenzas determined its fate. At least, they did until Castruccio Irovetti took control of their trade house and the family's two eldest leaders disappeared. Now, young Gasperre has assumed the mantle of leadership for his family, which still holds controlling interests in the famed vineyards of Sarain as well as most of the other orchards in the area, but Gasperre's youth and inexperience hamper his efforts to restore the family's honor.

Gain Faction Favor: The PCs can attempt to Gain Faction Favor with the Liacenzas using Society or Mercantile Lore.

B19. THE ACADEMY OF THE ARTS

Led by Headmistress **Atalia Gitaren** (NG female half-elf bard 12), this institution ostensibly exists to train the finest artists in all of the River Kingdoms and, according to Irovetti, all of Golarion. However, although no expense was spared to construct several new buildings for the academy, Irovetti proved notoriously cheap when it came to attracting skilled teachers of the various arts. Unable to tell the difference between good art and bad, and generally preferring bad anyway, Irovetti recruited a faculty of failed artists, has-beens, and never-weres, most deluded into believing themselves unrecognized geniuses rather than mere hacks. Bad teachers begat bad students, so combined with Irovetti's heavy-handed control over the art projects in Pitax, the academy bears a reputation for producing publicly funded affronts to good taste.

Fortunately, Headmistress Gitaren—who does have genuine talent and a wonderful singing voice—manages to rise above much of this. In the small hours of the morning, the few talented students and teachers attending the academy put their skills to work, creating marvelous works of art that remain, for the most part, unseen by the rest of Pitax. Atalia works for the day when she can exercise total control over the academy, but at the moment, her efforts are shackled by Irovetti's demands.



ATALIA GITAREN

Pursue Opportunity: Atalia is frustrated and outraged at her king's actions, but she worries that if she directly opposes King Irovetti that the backlash will catch her students in the crossfire. The PCs can Pursue this Opportunity to help spread the popularity of her students and faculty to show that, despite Irovetti's bad taste, the opportunity to create art still exists in Pitax. Doing so requires a Society check to spread the word. On a critical success, Atalia is so thankful that she gives the PCs one of her own treasures—a *moderate maestro's instrument*; adjust the exact type of this instrument to match one favored by a PC.

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PART 5:

THE KING'S PALACE

When the war begins, King Irovetti and his closest guards and allies remain barricaded in his palace. Any Pitaxian allies the PCs may have gained during the adventure, such as Ilora Nuski, can advise the PCs that the king has dug into his palace, and that an invasion of the large edifice would be the best way to break his hold over the nation

Even if the PCs defeat Pitax's field armies, push back those forces from their own kingdom, and work to undermine his influence in the city itself, Irovetti remains stubbornly within the walls of his home. While this might seem foolish to the PCs, Irovetti has surrounded himself with several powerful and dangerous allies, and he hopes that if the PCs do attempt to invade his palace that his bodyguard, generals, and other companions can help him cut the PCs down and turn their invasion into a powerful retort against their kingdom. Regardless of his motivation, at this point in the adventure, it will all come down to the PCs versus King Irovetti, and whoever is standing at the end of this chapter is the heritor of Pitax's destiny.

IROVETTI'S PALACE

Irovetti's palace is one of the oldest buildings in the city, built by an eccentric wizard who had a strange fascination with doors, twisting mazes, and architectural whimsies. The baffling structure fits Irovetti's needs well, and the tangle of halls and doors makes it an easy place to get lost in and an even easier place for its denizens to defend. The palace certainly

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earns its nickname—the "House of a Hundred Doors." In fact, the palace has well over a hundred doors, many of them secret.

Approaching the Palace: If the PCs haven't accumulated at least 30 Liberation Points, any approach to the Palace is potentially observed by the guards. Pitax Wardens are posted at the six watchtowers in the palace (see below), and during the day they'll automatically notice the PCs approaching and raise the alarm unless they disguise themselves or use magic to provide some sort of cover (but if the magic is obvious, such as a sudden fog bank rolling in, the Wardens still notice it and raise the alarm). At night, the PCs can attempt a DC 32 Stealth check to approach the Palace undetected. If the alarm is raised, patrols within the Palace quickly move to ballista chambers to fire upon the PCs (see area **C7** for details). If the PCs are at or above 30 Liberation Points, the guards have largely fled the Palace and the PCs can approach safely without needing to use Stealth.

Walls: Despite the expansive size of the house, the palace has only one floor above ground. Its roofline is a complex tangle of slopes, domes, and pitches that barely seems to match the underlying layout of rooms and halls. The external walls and roof are comprised of two 1-foot-thick stone walls sandwiching two 3-inch-thick iron walls, which themselves sandwich a thin layer of lead sheeting—all of which has been enhanced to resist magical effects that target the walls themselves. The walls attempt to counteract any spell that targets them as a result (7th level, counteract +22). The exterior walls (Hardness 18, HP 70 [BT 35]) can be Climbed with a DC 30 Athletics check. The interior walls (Hardness 14, HP 56 [BT 28]) are of similar construction but half the width.

Watchtowers: Most of the spiral stairs in the palace (with the notable exception of the flights found in areas **C15** and **C16**) lead up to small watchtowers on the palace roof above. As long as the PCs haven't reached 30 Liberation Points, these rooftop watchtowers are each occupied by a Pitax Warden ready to raise the alarm if they see anyone attempting to enter the palace from above. Each rooftop watchtower is accessed via a trapdoor that can be locked and bolted. Opening a trapdoor requires three DC 34 Thievery checks to Pick a Lock or a DC 36 Athletics check to Force Open—each door has its own unique key held by its accompanying guard. If the PCs have achieved 30 or more Liberation Points, the Wardens have abandoned their posts but left the doors locked.

PITAX WARDEN **CREATURE 12**

See page 336

Initiative Perception +22

Other Palace Features: Most hallways and chambers in the palace have 18-foot ceilings, but several areas have even higher ceilings; these variations are mentioned in the text. Light inside the palace is provided by *everburning torches* in the grand hall and by common oil lamps elsewhere. In addition, most rooms possess slit windows or slitted skylights. These windows, rarely more than 1 foot wide, are of leaded crystal in narrow diamond-shaped panes between 1-inch-thick leaded steel bars (Hardness 20, HP 50, [BT 25]). The fireplace chimneys in the Great Hall and kitchens are blocked by similar grates without the glass. Unless otherwise noted, secret doors in the palace can be discovered with a successful DC 30 Perception check.

Raised Alarms: Those infiltrating Irovetti's palace must be very careful if they wish to avoid a general alarm. Once the alarm is raised, word spreads throughout the palace rapidly, and the alarm stays raised for 24 hours. In addition to the various guards listed at key locations, there are six roving bands of guards, each consisting of four Pitax Wardens. If the alarm is raised, two of these groups mobilize and move to investigate the source of the alarm, arriving in the area after 2d6 rounds. In addition, as long as the alarm is raised, all of the palace's defenders and inhabitants gain a +2 circumstance bonus on Initiative checks.

If the PCs have achieved 30 Liberation Points, these six bands of guards have abandoned the palace, and a raised alarm only bolsters the Perception of those who remain behind in keyed areas.

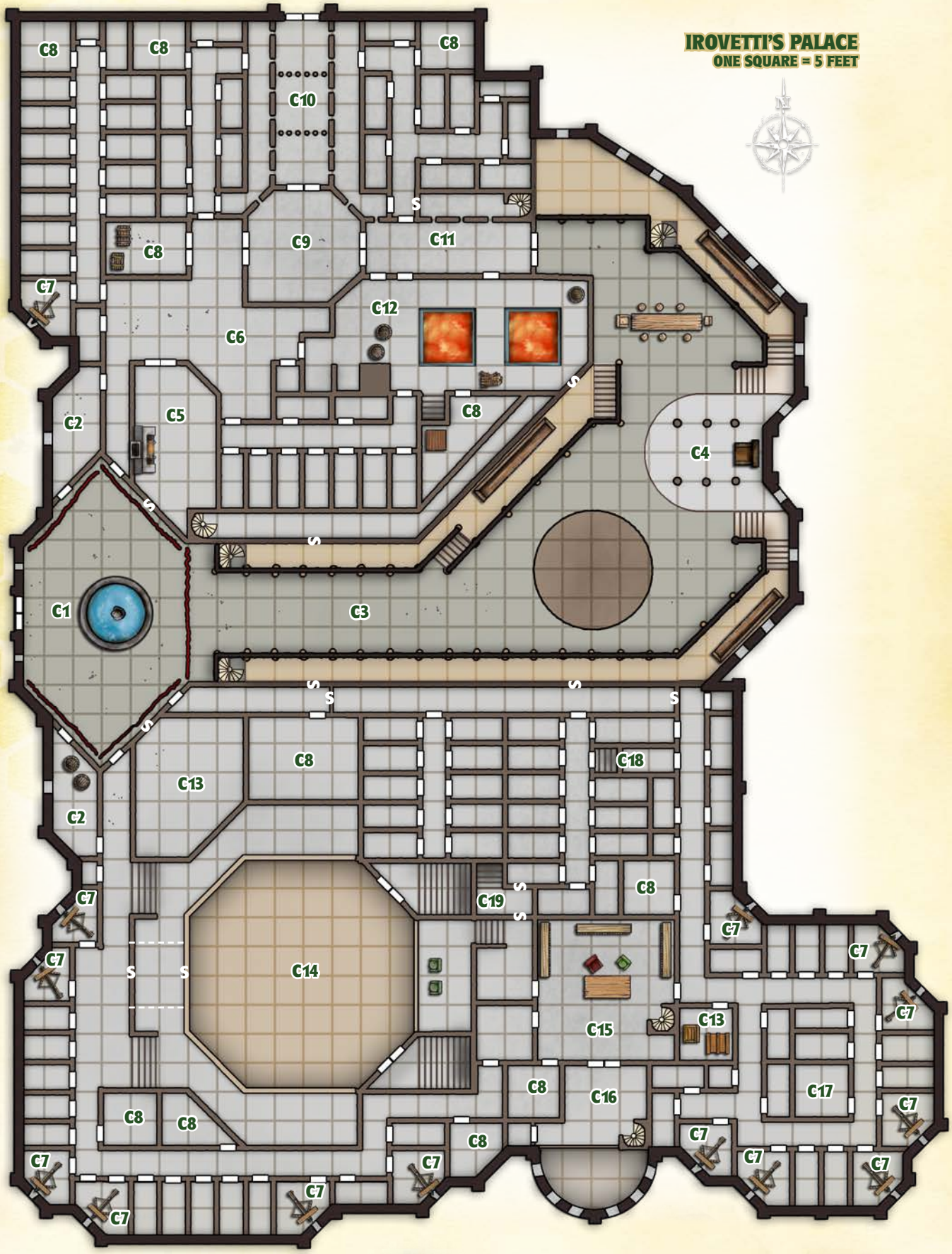
UNKEYED ROOMS

The majority of the rooms in Irovetti's palace aren't labeled on the map. These unkeyed rooms consist of two types: the 5-foot square rooms are privies containing a single toilet, and the 5-by-10-foot rooms are bedrooms for guards, servants, or guests (although Irovetti has currently dismissed all of his servants and his only guest—the weretiger Alasen—has her own larger room). Each of these unremarkable rooms contains a single bed, a nightstand, and a footlocker. The doors of these rooms can be latched from within but not locked. Unlatching a door from the other side requires a DC 25 Thievery check to Pick the Lock.

Some of these unkeyed rooms have been trapped by the guards in an attempt to slowly erode the resources of any intruders into the palace. Each time the PCs enter an unkeyed room, attempt a DC 8 flat check (or a DC 16 flat check if the PCs have achieved at least 30 Liberation Points). On a success, the room contains either a clockwork crossbow (treat as a scything blade snare that inflicts piercing damage) or a flash bang (treat as a stunning snare that raises the alarm if it's triggered), with an equal chance of either; see

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Pathfinder Core Rulebook 591 for stats for both. Keep track of the number of snares the PCs encounter—there are only a dozen of them in all in the Palace, so once the PCs reach this number of snares, no further snares will be encountered.

If your group doesn't like to map a maze of doors and traps in minute detail, you may wish to handwave much of the exploration of the mundane parts of the palace, having your players come up with a standard operating procedure for each door and only pulling them into the action when something out of the ordinary takes place. Exploration Mode can be used if the PCs aren't being attacked.

C1. GRAND ATRIUM MODERATE 15

The exterior iron doors to this room are kept locked and barred from the inside; Irovetti carries the only key. A character can attempt a DC 36 Thievery check to Pick the Lock, but the doors must still be Forced Open with a DC 32 Athletics check (DC 36 if the doors are still locked). In addition, a magical alarm bell on the door rings out if not disabled beforehand; spotting the alarm requires success at a DC 32 Perception check, after which a PC can attempt to Disable the Device with a DC 36 Thievery check.

This hexagonal chamber is dominated by a huge fountain containing a surreal idealized gold statue of King Irovetti, glowing richly in the light of torches along the walls and chandeliers dangling from the domed ceiling. The walls on every side are draped with enormous tapestries showing Irovetti triumphant in every field, from battle to art and from music to learning and erudition.

While the fountain and statue are real, the appearance that they're made of gold is provided by two separate *item facades* (3rd) placed by Irovetti. It's a DC 37 Perception check to notice the secret doors in this room (this DC drops to DC 35 if the PCs specifically check behind tapestries).

Creatures: Irovetti has a fondness for trolls and maintains their loyalty through payments of gold and regular use of *inveigle* rituals as necessary. While many of the trolls that work for him are typical specimens of their kind, those he retains as guards here in his palace are well-trained fighters capable of and eager for great violence. The troll guards focus attacks on foes who use fire or acid, working together to destroy those threats first, and then turn their attacks on the most heavily armored foes. They fight to the death.

If the troll guards use their Primordial Roar, the alarm is raised and all four Wardens from both guardrooms (area **C2**) join the fight on the next round.

TROLL GUARDS (2) CREATURE 15

RARE CE LARGE GIANT TROLL

Variant troll kings (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 315)
Perception +27; darkvision
Languages Common, Jotun
Skills Athletics +31, Intimidation +27
Str +8, **Dex** +4, **Con** +8, **Int** +0, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +4
Items *+1 striking battleaxes* (2), *+2 resilient full plate*

AC 35; **Fort** +29, **Ref** +23, **Will** +27
HP 340, regeneration 40 (deactivated by acid or fire); **Weaknesses** fire 15
Attack of Opportunity ↷
Vigorous Shake ↷ As troll king.

Speed 30 feet
Melee ❖ *battleaxe* +31 (reach 10 feet, sweep), **Damage** 4d8+16 slashing



TROLL GUARD

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AVINASH JURRG

Avinash Jurrg led the attack on the PCs' kingdom during Part 2 of this chapter. Kingmaker assumes that by the time the PCs infiltrate Irovetti's palace, Jurrg has returned to Pitax and will be encountered in area **C4**. If this isn't logical in your game (perhaps Jurrg's armies are still active in the PCs' kingdom, or they managed to track him down and kill him before he could return to the palace), replace him here with the weretiger Alasen from area **C17**, which would then be empty.

Melee ❖ jaws +30 (reach 10 feet), **Damage** 3d12+16 piercing
Rend ❖ battleaxe
Axe Critical Specialization The troll guard has access to axe critical specialization effects.
Forced Regeneration ❖ (concentrate) As troll king, but regenerates 20 HP.
Primordial Roar ❖ (auditory, emotion, fear, mental) As troll king, but DC 35 Will save.
Twin Chop ❖ **Frequency** once per round; **Effect** The troll guard lashes out at two foes with its axes. The troll guard attempts two battleaxe Strikes, each of which must target a different foe within reach. These attacks count toward the troll's multiple attack penalty, but the multiple attack penalty doesn't increase until after the troll makes both attacks.

C2. GUARDROOMS TRIVIAL 15

This chamber has a pair of chairs around a small table alongside a small brazier and a water barrel.

Creatures: In each of these two chambers, two Pitax Wardens keep themselves prepared to respond at a moment's notice. Individually, the guards here should be little threat to the PCs, but together (or joined with the trolls in area **C1**) they constitute a moderate threat.

These guards abandon their posts if the PCs achieve at least 30 Liberation Points.

PITAX WARDENS (2) CREATURE 12

See page 336
Initiative Perception +22

C3. GREAT HALL LOW 15

This high-vaulted hall is flanked on either side by a long colonnade supporting an ornately carved balcony. Staircases span from balcony to floor at irregular intervals around the room.

Note that the secret doors along the walls of this great hall are located under the balconies and provide access to the ground-level halls beyond.

Creatures: Each of the lavishly decorated balconies is patrolled by two Pitax Wardens who, unlike most other Wardens in the palace, do not abandon their post even if the PCs earn 30 Liberation points. The sturdily constructed balustrade gives them lesser cover against any attack that is not from above. They move to join a fight in area **C4**, but not one they hear elsewhere.

PITAX WARDENS (4) CREATURE 12

See page 336
Initiative Perception +22

C4. THE BURGUNDY THRONE VARIES 15

A regal throne carved of burgundy stone sits atop a broad dais of red-veined, white marble in this large throne hall. An impressive circular stage stands beneath a high dome to the southwest of the throne, and on the north side of the dais lies a banquet hall with a massive oak table. The eastern wall of the room features several towering stained-glass windows depicting King Irovetti in various regal and heroic poses.

Creatures: Two Pitax Wardens stand at attention at the base of the stairs to the north and south of the throne's dais. If the alarm is raised, the PCs also find King Irovetti, General Jurrg, and Villamor Koth awaiting them (an extreme 15 encounter). Otherwise, during the day, Irovetti is seated on his throne discussing defense tactics and reports with Jurrg (a severe 15 encounter); during the night, Irovetti and Jurrg are in their respective quarters and Koth is in area **C14** until midnight, when he retires to area **C5**.

If Irovetti is present, he doesn't immediately attack when the PCs arrive. Instead, he holds up a hand to halt the PCs' advance (and to halt any ongoing battle the PCs might have dragged with them), then he addresses them with a sneer and a challenge.

"So you have come for me at last, have you? I knew you would. Very well. No more games. No more tricks. No more decoys. Skill against skill, strength against strength, and we shall see who deserves to rule and who deserves to die."

Irovetti is impressed at the party's resilience, furious at his own failures, and unsurprised they have managed to reach his throne room. He's eager to vent his frustrations with a good, old-fashioned fight and orders his allies to step up to attack while he rises from his throne to join the battle. Irovetti is uninterested in diplomacy or explanations at this point, yet he isn't

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ready to throw his life away. If he takes more than 50 points of damage here, he orders his remaining allies to "handle this situation!" before fleeing via his *wand of dimension door* to his sanctuary at area **F1**.

Until then, Irovetti lets his allies enter melee while he hangs back and supports them with inspire courage or casts defensive spells like *mirror image*. If he's still in the fight after 3 rounds, his increased bravado leads him to enter melee wielding his rod of razors. If he can't retreat by casting *dimension door*, he casts *invisibility* and attempts a physical retreat. Regardless of his method, his guards continue the fight—he has informed them that he doesn't intend to stick around for the whole fight if things don't immediately go well, and they are not demoralized if he retreats.

General Jurrg prefers to fight in melee, taunting the PCs for any failures or defeats they or their kingdom may have suffered during his army's attacks. He starts the fight with *cone of cold*, then follows up with melee attacks, trusting Irovetti to aid him with support magic or *soothe* spells if he is wounded. As long as he is in the king's presence, he fights to the death, but if Irovetti has fled and Jurrg is reduced to fewer than 100 Hit Points, he casts *invisibility* and retreats, seeking out Irovetti to report to his king and stand by his side.

Villamor Koth prefers to focus his wrath on any PC that vied against him during the Rushlight Tournament. Technically Irovetti's bodyguard, Koth loses sight of this charge when he rages as the fight begins, drawing upon a fury he held back from during the tournament. He fights to the death, pursuing the PCs relentlessly even should he become fatigued.

KING CASTRUCCIO IROVETTI — CREATURE 16

See page 593

Initiative Perception +26

GENERAL AVINASH JURRG — CREATURE 14

UNIQUE | LE | LARGE | GIANT | ONI | SHAPECHANGER

Variant male onidoshi (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 188)

Perception +26; darkvision, low-light vision

Languages Common, Jotun

Skills Acrobatics +24, Arcana +26, Athletics +28, Deception +28, Intimidation +28, Nature +24, Society +24, Warfare Lore +26

Str +8, **Dex** +4, **Con** +6, **Int** +4, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +6

Items *+1 glamered resilient breastplate*, *+1 composite longbow* (20 arrows), *+2 striking greatsword*

AC 36; **Fort** +28, **Ref** +24, **Will** +24; +1 status on all saves vs. magic

HP 225, regeneration 15 (deactivated by acid or fire)

Attack of Opportunity ↷

Speed 30 feet, fly 30 feet

Melee ❖ greatsword +30 (versatile P), **Damage** 1d12+12 slashing

Ranged ❖ composite longbow +28 (deadly d10, propulsive, volley 30 ft.), **Damage** 1d8+4 piercing

Primal Innate Spells DC 36; **7th** *cone of cold*; **6th** *chilling darkness*; **4th** *gaseous form*, *invisibility*, *sleep*; **2nd** *darkness* (at will), *invisibility* (at will)



AVINASH JURRG

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Battlefield Command ❖ (auditory, enchantment, incapacitation, linguistic, mental, primal) **Frequency** once per round; **Effect** General Jurrg roars out a simple command during battle, using his supernatural power to force a foe within 30 feet to pursue a tactic in combat. The targeted creature must attempt a DC 34 Will save and is thereafter temporarily immune to new Battlefield Commands for 24 hours.

Critical Success The creature is unaffected.

Success The creature is stunned 1 as their mind rails against the command.

Failure The creature must spend 1 action at the start of their turn to perform a basic action commanded by the general, chosen from those listed on pages 470–471 of the *Pathfinder Core Rulebook*.

Critical Failure As failure, but the creature must spend all 3 actions to perform basic actions commanded by the general. At the end of their turn, they must save against Battlefield Command again to determine how the effect continues into their next turn, but each time this save is attempted the DC is reduced by 2.

Change Shape ❖ (concentrate, polymorph, primal, transmutation) As onidoshi.

VILLAMOR KOTH — CREATURE 15

See page 347

Initiative Perception +27

PITAX WARDENS (2) — CREATURE 12

See page 336

Initiative Perception +22

C5. VILLAMOR KOTH'S BEDROOM — TRIVIAL 15

This spacious chamber is well appointed, with furnishings in a colorful and unexpected style, a looming fireplace, and walls covered with maps and diagrams of fortifications under construction. A massive, wrought-iron bed dominates one corner of the room, its heavy posts supporting a canopy of chains, surmounted with massive manacles stained with crusty smears of blood.

Creature: This is the chamber of Villamor Koth. As Captain of the Guard and Irovetti's bodyguard, Koth doesn't spend much time in this room, but he can be found here relaxing or sleeping between midnight and dawn. At other hours, he's either sparring in area **C14**, or if the alarm is raised, at Irovetti's side in area **C4**. If the PCs have already confronted Irovetti and forced his retreat, Koth tries to join him in area **F1**.

VILLAMOR KOTH — CREATURE 15

See page 347

Initiative Perception +27

Treasure: A pair of tapestries, laced with gold and mithral thread, hang on the walls here. One depicts a pair of dragons mating in midflight, while another shows a silvery tree growing up toward a lacy golden sun—each are worth 150 gp but are 4 Bulk. A locked payroll chest, which a PC can attempt to open with a DC 36 Thievery check to Pick the Lock, sits under his bed. It contains 334 gp, 12 *moderate healing potions*, and three greater antidotes. The key to the chest is hidden in a secret panel in the bed's headboard (DC 36 Perception to discover).

C6. COMMON MESS HALL — LOW 15

This large chamber is scattered with well-worn but sturdy tables and chairs. Large bins by the walls hold refuse, soiled laundry, and dirty dishes.

Creatures: If the PCs enter this room without the alarm being raised, a group of Pitax Wardens is sharing a meal, unless the PCs have reached 30 Liberation Points, in which case this room is empty.

PITAX WARDENS (4) — CREATURE 12

See page 336

Initiative Perception +22

C7. BALLISTA CHAMBER

An iron and wood ballista sits in this chamber, loaded and aimed toward a long but narrow horizontal gap in the outer wall. A barrel near the ballista holds a dozen massive bolts.

Hazard: Each of these 14 rooms contains a ballista and a barrel of ten bolts for use in defending the palace. From the outside, the six-inch-wide ballista firing slits are obscured by illusory strips of stone created by *illusory object* (5th) that all of the palace's occupants have long ago disbelieved and can thus see through.

If the alarm is raised while the PCs approach the palace, guards within these chambers use the ballistae to fire upon them on sight; treat this as a hazard. Once the PCs get into the palace, the guards posted at these rooms abandon them to form back into their patrol groups. If the PCs have reached 30 Liberation Points, there are no guards to use these ballistae, so the PCs can come and go without fear of being fired upon.

BALLISTA DEFENSE — HAZARD 11

COMPLEX | MECHANICAL

Stealth DC +23 (master)

Description A ballista armed with a massive bolt fires on a creature approaching the Palace.

Disable DC 36 Thievery (master) to sabotage the ballista

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by reaching through the firing slit from outside (this DC is reduced by 10 if the PCs are in the room with the ballista), or DC 33 Intimidation to frighten off the Pitax Warden operating the ballista.

AC 31; **Fort** +24, **Ref** +18

Hardness 20; **HP** 80 (BT 40); **Immunities** critical hits, object immunities, precision damage

Ready and Load ↷ **Trigger** The alarm is raised while the PCs are approaching the Palace; **Effect** The guards ready and load the ballista. The ballista defense then rolls Initiative.

Routine (3 actions) The ballista takes 1 action to fire a ballista bolt and 2 actions to reload. After ten rounds, the ballista is out of ammunition and can no longer function.

Ranged ❖ ballista bolt +24 (range 300 feet), **Damage** 2d12+15 piercing

Reset (1 day) If the PCs haven't reached 30 Liberation Points, additional ammunition for a ballista can be secured in a day, but if the PCs have reached 30 Liberation Points, a ballista that runs out of ammo cannot be reset.

C8. STORAGE ROOM

This storage room contains linens, tools, firewood, and other miscellaneous supplies.

Each of these rooms tends to be quite cluttered; any Stealth check made to Hide in one of these rooms gains a +2 item bonus.

C9. GUARD POST TRIVIAL 15

The broad portals of the outer corridor open into an irregularly shaped room with doors to the west and east.

Creatures: A troll guard watches over this chamber. A lever against the northeast wall allows the troll guard to disable the portcullis trap in **C10**. If the troll hears the portcullises drop, it moves quickly into that area to attack potentially trapped PCs.

TROLL GUARD CREATURE 15

See page 383

Initiative Perception +27

C10. SERVICE ENTRANCE

Iron portals open into a wide passage leading within. The walls here angle inward, with arrow slits on either side.

The locked double door here can be unlocked using the key stolen by sculptor Cayid Caconna (see area **B16**) or the master key carried by King Irovetti.

Hazard: This passageway is normally used by servants to bring supplies to the kitchens and cellars. A pair of iron portcullises hidden in the ceiling above have been rigged to drop down and trap invaders. Servants normally signal the troll in **C9** to disable the trap when they have to deliver things. If this trap goes off, the troll in that area steps in to attack the PCs using his reach Strikes, which gain the benefit of lesser cover as a result of the portcullis bars. If the alarm is raised and the PCs have not reached 30 Liberation points, a group of four Pitax Wardens is stationed in each of the halls to the east and west; they fire arrows on PCs in this room as well.

TRAPPED PORTCULLIS HAZARD 11

MECHANICAL TRAP

Stealth DC 36 (master)

Description Two portcullises drop down to block progress through this area.

Disable DC 33 (master) to disable the trigger that causes the portcullises to drop

Portcullis AC 30; **Fort** +24, **Ref** +18

Portcullis Hardness 18; **HP** 72 (BT 36); **Immunities** critical hits, object immunities, precision damage

Drop from Ceiling ↷ **Trigger** A character enters a square between the two portcullises; **Effect** Both portcullises drop from the ceiling; attempting to lift one requires a DC 30 Athletics check to Force Open. When the portcullises drop, creatures in adjacent squares must attempt a DC 30 Reflex save.

Critical Success The creature is unharmed and can take a Step as a reaction to move to an adjacent square.

Success As critical success, but the creature takes a glancing blow from the falling portcullis for 2d12+15 bludgeoning damage.

Failure The creature is struck by the falling portcullis for 4d12+30 bludgeoning damage and is knocked prone in their square.

Critical Failure The creature is struck by the falling portcullis for 6d12+45 bludgeoning damage, is knocked prone, and is immobilized by the portcullis as it pins them to the ground until they can Escape or Force Open the portcullis (DC 30).

Reset The trap can be manually reset with a 10-minute Manipulate activity performed in the hallways to the east or west of this area, as long as neither portcullis is broken or destroyed.

C11. CROSSFIRE CORRIDOR LOW 15

A line of arrow slits adorns the northern wall of this corridor.

If the alarm is raised and the PCs haven't reached 30 Liberation Points, four Pitax Wardens are in the hallway just north of this area; they fire into this room through the arrow slits as soon as they notice the PCs.

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PITAX WARDENS (4) CREATURE 12

See page 336

Initiative Perception +22

C12. KITCHENS

This large chamber contains a pair of massive firepit-like ovens with plenty of work and preparation space all around them.

The kitchens, normally a scene of bustling activity, are currently empty—all of the help staff have been ordered to leave the palace, as Irovetti doesn't want to deal with the blowback from endangering his servants should he come out the winner in the war. The stairs in the south wall lead down to area **D1**.

C13. TROLL BARRACKS

This oversized chamber holds four enormous nests of rags and filthy hay.

The troll guards sleep in these nests in shifts, but at this time, all of the palace trolls are on duty.

C14. THE OCTAGON MODERATE 15

This domed chamber has a large, octagonal fighting pit. A ten-foot-wide balcony runs around the western part of the pit, while to the east a small royal box with large chairs provides an even better view of the central area. Massive wooden double doors in the pit presumably allow access from a lower level of the palace.

The floor of the eight-sided arena is 20 feet below the main level. The double doors in the pit's east wall lead to the prison (area **E2**) and the monster pens (areas **E4–E5**); both of these doors are normally kept locked with massive chains (DC 35 to Pick the Lock). A secret door in the pit's west wall opens into a 10-foot-square chamber under the balcony that leads to a second secret door (both of these secret doors require success on a DC 30 Perception check to notice), which in turn opens into the western hall—this entrance is used to access the fighting pit with ease from the main floor.

Creatures: The octagon is used for battles between condemned prisoners, magically controlled monsters, and whatever other entertainments Irovetti and his agents can think up, although no bouts have been scheduled since the king holed up in the palace. If the alarm isn't raised and it's between sunset and midnight, Villamor Koth is in the pit sparring with a troll guard; when the PCs arrive, the pair immediately attacks them, fighting to the death.

VILLAMOR KOTH CREATURE 15

See page 347

Initiative Perception +27

TROLL GUARD CREATURE 15

See page 383

Initiative Perception +27

C15. LIBRARY

This magnificent library has books by the thousands lining its walls, with moving ladders mounted on rails circling the chamber. Plush chairs and reading tables with stand-lamps dot the room.

The library contains much literature of questionable quality, lurid tales of adventure, ribald poetry and melodrama, and the like. Still, enough legitimate reference works can be found to grant a +2 item bonus to any Recall Knowledge checks made while Investigating the history, current events, or nobility of the River Kingdoms. The spiral staircase here leads down 20 feet to area **E3**.

C16. CONSERVATORY TRIVIAL 15

This richly appointed chamber contains an assortment of musical instruments, polished to a shine, highlighted by an elaborate pipe organ. Rich, burgundy velvet chairs are arrayed on a Qadiran carpet worked intricately in gold, orange, and yellow. A spiral staircase to the southeast leads up to what appears to be a solarium to the south.

This chamber is one of Irovetti's favorites in the palace, but he currently has little time to spend here.

Creatures: The solarium is raised 10 feet above the conservatory and features numerous large windows. It thus makes for an excellent watch post and is manned by two Pitax Wardens. If they see anyone approaching, they raise the alarm. If the PCs have reached 30 Liberation Points, though, the solarium is abandoned.

PITAX WARDENS (2) CREATURE 12

See page 336

Initiative Perception +22

Treasure: There are eight virtuoso musical instruments of various types here, each worth 50 gp. A search of the room and success on a DC 35 Perception check turns up a watercolor of a nude nymph tucked into the base of a drum. The painting—a poor depiction of Nyrissa—isn't very good, but it's certainly scandalous. The Qadiran carpet is worth 120 gp but is 6 Bulk.

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C17. ALASEN'S ROOM — TRIVIAL 15

This cozy room is furnished with a large bed, a writing desk, and a fireplace. Numerous books lie stacked on the desk.

Creature: Unless the PCs already confronted and defeated her elsewhere, the leader of the Catspaw Mercenaries is found here. This is Alasen, a weretiger and a bandit. She has been given this room to use as her personal quarters for as long as her service to Irovetti continues. Alasen is relaxing and reading a stack of violent war books she's borrowed from the library, but if the alarm is raised, she assumes her hybrid form and begins stalking the palace, looking for the PCs and waiting for them to enter combat with another defender before she sneaks in to attack. You can use Alasen as a recurring menace to attack the PCs as you wish in this case.

Alasen prefers to wait for the PCs to be engaged in battle with other palace defenders, so she can skulk into place and attack from invisibility with Pounce. She goes invisible again after attacking, then repositions for another attack. She does her best to avoid being caught in melee for more than a few rounds at a time. Alasen's loyalty to Irovetti collapses if she's reduced to fewer than 40 Hit Points, at which point she attempts to flee the palace and Pitax altogether.

ALASEN — CREATURE 14

UNIQUE | NE | LARGE | BEAST | HUMAN | HUMANOID | WERECREATURE

Female human weretiger (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 291)

Perception +26; low-light vision, scent (imprecise) 30 feet

Languages Common; tiger empathy

Skills Acrobatics +25, Athletics +28, Stealth +25, Thievery +25, Survival +21, Warfare Lore +20

Str +8, **Dex** +6, **Con** +5, **Int** +0, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +5

Items *+1 greater invisibility resilient leather armor*, *ring of fire resistance*, *ring of cold resistance*

Tiger Empathy (divination, primal) Alasen can communicate with felines.

AC 36; **Fort** +23, **Ref** +28, **Will** +26

HP 245; **Weaknesses** silver 10; **Resistances** cold 5, fire 5

Defensive Roll ◈ **Frequency** once per 10 minutes; **Trigger** A physical attack would reduce Alasen to 0 Hit Points. **Effect** Alasen drops into a roll to disperse the force of the blow and takes half damage from the attack.

Speed 25 feet

Melee ◆ jaws +28, **Damage** 3d6+16 piercing plus curse of the weretiger

Melee ◆ claw +28 (agile), **Damage** 3d4+16 slashing

Change Shape ◆ (concentrate, polymorph, primal, transmutation) Medium human with fist +26 for 2d6+16 bludgeoning, or tiger with Speed 30 feet and Wrestle (*Pathfinder Bestiary* page 53).

Curse of the Weretiger (curse, necromancy, primal) As weretiger, but DC 34 Fortitude save.

Critical Debilitating Strike ◈ **Trigger** Alasen's Strike hits a flat-footed creature and deals damage. **Effect** The target becomes enfeebled 1 or takes a –10-foot status penalty to its Speeds, as chosen by Alasen. On a critical hit, the target must also attempt a DC 34 Fortitude save.

Critical Success The target is unaffected.

Success The target is slowed 1 until the end of Alasen's next turn.

Failure The target is slowed 2 until the end of Alasen's next turn.

Critical Failure The target is paralyzed until the end of Alasen's next turn.

Mobility When Alasen takes a Stride action to move half her Speed or less, that movement does not trigger reactions.

Moon Frenzy (polymorph, primal, transmutation) As weretiger.

Pounce ◆ As weretiger.



ALASEN

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Rend ❖ claw
Sneak Attack Alasen deals 2d6 extra precision damage to flat footed creatures.

C18. ARMORY STAIRS

These stairs lead down to area **E1**.

C19. SECRET STAIRS

These stairs lead down to a hidden passageway that winds underground to a cavern deep below the palace, 50 feet below even the dungeon level, eventually reaching area **F1**.

D1. PANTRY CELLAR

Rows of crates, boxes, and barrels fill this room, leaving only a few narrow areas to walk through.

This chamber stores the palace's food supplies. The stairs lead up to area **C12** above. The door to the wine cellar is locked, but a PC can bypass it with a DC 35 Thievery check to Pick the Lock.

D2. WINE CELLAR

Barrels and crates fill the southern portion of this room, while three wine racks sit against the wall to the east.

Treasure: This chamber stores the palace's wine, ale, mead, and other spirits, including the collection Irovetti seized from the Liacenza family cellars. A half-hour of sifting through a lot of low-quality spirits turns up 14 bottles of fine wine worth 30 gp each, as well as five bottles of Whiterose chardonnay worth 100 gp each.

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CHAPTER 8
PART 1: THE RUSHLIGHT TREACHERY
PART 2: BEHIND ENEMY LINES
PART 3: THE GHOST OF WHITEROSE
PART 4: INFILTRATION
PART 5: THE KING'S PALACE

E1. ARMORY

Empty racks for weapons and armor decorate the walls here. A large, closed cabinet stands to the east, while a pair of barrels filled with bundles of arrows stands nearby.

Treasure: Most of the weapons normally stored here are already in use by the Pitax Wardens in the palace (or, if the PCs have attained at least 30 Liberation Points, were taken by the Wardens when they fled). However, the unlocked cabinet contains two suits of *+1 full plate*, six composite shortbows, two *+1 striking greatswords*, and six *moderate healing potions*. The barrels contain 500 arrows, 50 cold iron arrows, and 50 silver arrows.

E2. THE BLACK CELLS LOW 15

The western end of this chamber is lit by large braziers shedding light on several immaculate, pain-producing mechanisms. A large table mounted with winching racks sits in the middle of the room, while strappados, a manacled wheel, vats of brine and oil, and baskets of knives, saws, pokers, and pins lie along the walls. To the east is a large block of cells, several of which contain the ruined, mutilated corpses of prisoners.

When Irovetti took over the palace, he inherited these implements of pain. The torture devices sat idle for the first years of his reign, but as his paranoia grew, he began turning to them to extract confessions with increasing regularity. Yet he never quite developed a taste for torture, so he placed this foul duty in the more than eager hands of a singularly vile tormentor.

Although most of the prisoners in the cells are dead, you can place any missing individuals the PCs may be looking for (such as the missing diva, Asmeranda Ilata—see the quest on page 378) here as you see fit.

Creature: Several years ago, Pitax endured several months of terror as a serial killer stalked its streets. Although most folks believe that the "Riverfront Ripper" was killed when he accidentally attacked someone deadlier than himself, in fact, Irovetti and his guards captured the killer and gave him a job. Today, this sadistic gargoyle, a murderous fanatic named Gedovius, not only gets to live out his torture fantasies comfortably, but he also gets room, board, and even a pet.

The gargoyle has spent much of his time here torturing prisoners, but since Irovetti sealed the palace, there have been no new ones and he's running short on supply. If the PCs enter this room while the alarm isn't raised, they find Gedovius here polishing and calibrating his torture implements. He rolls Perception for initiative, and if he's reduced to fewer than 80 HP, he retreats to area **E4** to recruit his pet gogiteth's aid in finishing the fight.

If they reach this room while the alarm is raised, though, Gedovius has brought his pet gogiteth from area **E4** into this room, while the gargoyle himself uses his Statue ability to appear as a creepy statue in a corner, allowing him to roll Stealth for initiative.

If fighting alongside his pet, Gedovius moves to flank foes, and this becomes a Moderate 15 encounter. On his own, he attempts to Demoralize a target, which he can then sneak attack. Gedovius fights to the death.

GEDOVIUS CREATURE 16

UNIQUE | NE | MEDIUM | BEAST | EARTH

Variant male gargoyle (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 161)

Perception +28; darkvision



GEDOVIUS

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Languages Common, Terran, Undercommon
Skills Acrobatics +31, Athletics +28, Intimidation +26, Stealth +33, Torture Lore +28
Str +6, **Dex** +9, **Con** +5, **Int** +2, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +2
Items *+2 resilient leather armor*, key to area **E4**

AC 39; **Fort** +27, **Ref** +31, **Will** +28
HP 222; **Resistances** physical 15 (except adamantine)
Clawed Feet ↷ (attack) As gargoyle.

Speed 25 feet, fly 40 feet
Melee ❖ jaws +32, **Damage** 3d8+12 piercing
Melee ❖ claw +32 (agile), **Damage** 3d6+12 slashing
Dread Striker Any creature that has the frightened condition is also flat-footed against Gedovius's attacks.
Intimidating Prowess Gedovius ignores the penalty for not sharing a language when he attempts to Demoralize a target.
Sneak Attack Gedovius deals 3d6 extra precision damage to flat-footed creatures.
Statue ❖ (concentrate) Until the next time he acts, Gedovius appears to be a statue. He has an automatic result of 44 on Deception checks and DCs to pass as a statue.
Rip and Rend ❖ **Frequency** once per round; **Requirement** Gedovius's last action was a melee Strike that dealt sneak attack damage to a flat-footed target. **Effect** Gedovius deals 6d6 persistent bleed damage to the target.

E3. TORTURER'S DEN

This chamber is decorated with all manner of preserved hides, horns, heads, and bones of creatures malevolent and benign. A set of spiral stairs in the southwest corner leads upward, and an archway to the east opens into a roughly hewn chamber in which stands, of all things, a bed.

Gedovius doesn't spend much time in this room, which was originally intended for a much more human jailer to use.

The spiral stairs lead up to area **C15**.

E4. MONSTER PEN TRIVIAL 15

This chamber seems to be the den of some filthy monster, judging by the half-eaten cow carcasses and the enormous nest.

The door to the pen is kept locked. It can be opened with Gedovius's key or Irovetti's master key, or a DC 30 Thievery check can be attempted to Pick the Lock.

Creature: This chamber is the den of one of Irovetti's more dangerous pets, a gogiteth that he has left in the hands of Gedovius to care for. Gedovius enjoys conversations with the monster, even though the gogiteth doesn't have the patience for long discussions and only bothers since it knows food comes after. It prefers eating creatures that can cry for mercy, but it won't turn down livestock. It attacks anyone it doesn't recognize on sight, but if reduced to fewer than 50 HP it attempts to flee upward, squeezing through narrow hallways as it makes its way into the palace and, given time, out into Pitax.

ELITE GOGITETH CREATURE 13

Pathfinder Bestiary 6, 183
Initiative Perception +23

E5. FROZEN FURNACE MODERATE 15

This chamber widens out to the south into a bowl-shaped cavern, the walls of which are caked with thick sheets of ice and frost.

Irovetti spared no expense having this room magically enhanced to make a more comfortable den for his favorite pet. In this room, the temperature remains at a constant extreme cold (–40° F), which causes 2d6 cold damage to creatures every 10 minutes (*Pathfinder Core Rulebook* 517).

Creature: The denizen of this frozen chamber is a particularly deadly remorhaz that Irovetti encountered several years ago on an expedition to the Realm of the Mammoth Lords. He managed to *charm* and later *inveigle* the monster and got it all the way back to Pitax, leading it through the city amid great fanfare. The creature's name is Rezatha, and the king quite enjoys feeding prisoners and criminals to it in the Octagon (moving it in and out via *teleport*—the same way he got the monster in here in the first place). The creature remains *inveigled* to this day—if the PCs dispel the ritual, the remorhaz is smart enough to realize it has been oppressed and immediately wants to help the PCs kill Irovetti. Of course, the immense beast can't speak, and won't fit in most of the palace, but clever player characters should be able to come up with some way to take advantage of the monster's aid. If the ritual is not dispelled, Rezatha sees the PCs as enemies and attacks at once, fighting to the death.

REZATHA CREATURE 17

UNIQUE | N | HUGE | BEAST

Variant remorhaz (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 280)
Perception +28; darkvision, tremorsense (imprecise) 60 feet
Languages Jotun (can't speak any languages)
Skills Athletics +34, Stealth +29
Str +9, **Dex** +6, **Con** +9, **Int** –3, **Wis** +6, **Cha** –2

AC 39; **Fort** +32, **Ref** +27, **Will** +29
HP 330; **Immunities** cold, fire
Heat (aura, evocation, fire, primal) 5 feet. A creature that starts its turn in the aura takes 4d6 fire damage. Whenever Rezatha takes damage from an enemy, this damage increases to 6d6 until the start of its next turn. Any creature that hits Rezatha with an unarmed strike takes 6d6 fire damage, and a weapon that hits Rezatha takes 6d6 fire damage.

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Speed 35 feet
Melee ❖ jaws +34 (reach 15 feet), **Damage** 3d12+17 piercing plus Grab
Melee ❖ tail +34 (fire, reach 15 feet), **Damage** 3d6+17 bludgeoning plus 3d6 fire
Breath Weapon ❖❖ (evocation, fire, primal) Rezatha unleashes a gout of flame that deals 18d6 fire damage in a 30-foot cone (DC 38 basic Reflex save). It can't use Breath Weapon again for 1d4 rounds.
Swallow Whole ❖ Large, 2d10+8 bludgeoning damage plus 3d6 fire, Rupture 30
Thrash ❖❖ Rezatha Strikes once with its jaws and once with its tail, each targeting a different creature. Each attack counts toward its multiple attack penalty, but the multiple attack penalty doesn't increase until after all the attacks have been made.

F1. IROVETTI'S BEDROOM — SEVERE 15

This is a sumptuously appointed bedchamber with a polished tile floor and walls, a tinkling fountain, and dozens of sculptures, all lit by stained-glass lamps and sconces. An owlbearskin rug lies before a large bed in the corner of the room, while to the east, a thick purple curtain hangs from the ceiling. The sound of rippling water echoes from somewhere beyond the curtain.

This chamber is Irovetti's personal hideaway and bedroom, one of the most secure and secret chambers in the entire palace. Although this bedroom is separated from the cold, damp cave to the east by only a thick purple curtain, the temperature and humidity in this bedroom remain at comfortable levels.

The stairs behind the northwestern door lead to area **C18**, while the room beyond the northeastern door is a closet.

Creatures: During the day, or if the alarm has been raised, Irovetti is in area **C4**; otherwise, he's here spending time here with his naga consort Engelidis (who uses a combination of *humanoid form* and *illusory disguise* to change her appearance during these trysts) or catching what few hours of sleep he can. If he has retreated to this chamber after confronting the PCs in the throne hall, he and Engelidis do not leave this chamber until they receive an "all clear" from Villamor Koth, Jurrg, or another key NPC from above—and at your option, some of those NPCs could well be encountered here as well after fleeing the PCs.

In any case, once Irovetti is confronted here, he does his best to finish the PCs off. Yet he does not wish to die—if reduced to fewer than 40 Hit Points, he attempts to flee again using all of his remaining magic. If escape is impossible, he surrenders and begs for mercy. See Concluding the Chapter for ramifications of the PCs accepting King Irovetti's surrender or of his escape.

Engelidis herself takes a supportive role when fighting alongside King Irovetti and targets those foes who seem to be specifically causing her lover the most harm and trouble. If Irovetti isn't here, Engelidis is instead in her lagoon in area **F2**.

KING CASTRUCCIO IROVETTI — CREATURE 16

See page 593
Initiative Perception +26

ENGELIDIS — CREATURE 16

UNIQUE | CE | LARGE | ABERRATION

Variant female spirit naga (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 179)
Perception +28; darkvision
Languages Aklo, Common
Skills Acrobatics +30, Athletics +27, Deception +33, Intimidation +31, Occultism +29, Stealth +30
Str +5, **Dex** +6, **Con** +5, **Int** +5, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +9



ENGELIDIS

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Coven As spirit naga.

AC 40; **Fort** +25, **Ref** +30, **Will** +28

HP 290

Speed 25 feet, swim 15 feet

Melee ❖ fangs +29 (agile, finesse), **Damage** 5d8+13 piercing plus spirit naga venom

Arcane Spontaneous Spells DC 39, attack +26; **8th** (2 slots) *discern location*, *power word stun*; **7th** (4 slots) *mask of terror*, *power word blind*; **6th** (4 slots) *chain lightning*, *mislead*; **5th** (4 slots) *cone of cold*, *telekinetic haul*; **4th** (4 slots) *dimension door*, *fly*; **3rd** (4 slots) *clairaudience*, *illusory disguise*, *lightning bolt*; **2nd** (4 slots) *dispel magic*, *humanoid form*, *invisibility*, *misdirection*; **1st** (4 slots) *charm*, *mindlink*, *ray of enfeeblement*, *sanctuary*; **Cantrips (8th)** *detect magic*, *ghost sound*, *mage hand*, *message*, *telekinetic projectile*

Rituals DC 39; *inveigle*

Spirit Naga Venom (poison) As spirit naga but DC 37.

Treasure: This room is littered with minor objects d'art—tapestries, brocades, linens, statuary, decanters, goblets, and more. A thorough looting produces 850 gp in 6 Bulk of treasure, and a lurid tome that contains all the details for learning the ritual *inveigle*.

Perhaps even more compelling to the PCs, though, are the pages of notes Irovetti has been keeping on their own kingdom. A PC who takes a few hours sorting through these pages can put together the king's plans and goals as regards their kingdom, and you can use this resource to answer any lingering questions the players may have about Irovetti himself. Additionally, the notes can point the PCs toward any undiscovered points of interest in the Stolen Lands if you wish, as Irovetti's scouts have been exploring and reporting on the area for years.

Of particular interest among these notes are those found in a slim, red leather folio. These notes, written in Aklo, document numerous points of research into "places of power" hidden within the Stolen Lands. A PC who takes an hour to research these notes discovers that Irovetti has been sending scouts and explorers out to investigate areas within the region where he suspects potent magic might be recovered to aid him in his fight against the PCs' kingdom. You should tailor these locations to make it appear that Irovetti's growing increasingly frustrated as sites he explores end up either disappointing them or are places the PCs have already explored during the campaign, but one site in particular should catch the PCs' attention—the island of Candlemere.

Irovetti's notes on Candlemere focus on initial reports that cite old rumors of a great treasure or a great danger—or perhaps both—having been sealed into a vault below a magical seal placed centuries ago by the priesthood of Pharasma. The reports from his field agents speak of encountering large numbers of will-o'-wisps on Candlemere, of an oppressive magical aura, and of an intriguing spiral seal found in an underground chamber below. If the PCs already explored Candlemere earlier in the campaign, they may well recognize some of these, but the extent to which Irovetti has started to research the spiral seal (including his hopes that he might make contact with a powerful ally potentially trapped below the seal that he could recruit against the PCs' kingdom) should kindle curiosity about the site again. These notes can aid the PCs in researching the spiral seal, as detailed at the start of the next chapter.

One element that's mostly absent from this collection, though, is Irovetti's association with Nyrissa. He never mentions the nymph queen by name, and left only one brief, cryptic mention of *Briar* that the PCs should take note of, as the note is the only one that appears on the page: "The blade was hidden under Whiterose all this time—it's safe now, but I don't think I'll be telling her about it yet."

F2. ENGELIDIS'S LAGOON LOW 15

This placid pool glows from the many crystal lamps mounted above and below the water line. A gilded statue with Irovetti's face and an impossibly perfect body rises from the waves with arms extended, as though reaching out toward a lover. A large dry area seems to have once served as a treasury, but now all of the chests appear to be empty.

This 12-foot-deep pool is quite cold and contains a subtle underwater current noticeable with success on a DC 30 Survival check; those who notice it gain a +4 circumstance bonus to find either of the secret doors. Both of these incredibly well-hidden doors are underwater, and each can be found by succeeding at a DC 35 Perception check. The door leads to a 3-foot-wide submerged tunnel that winds for nearly a thousand feet before ending at a second secret door (also DC 35 to notice) that opens into the Pitax River. The secret door to the east leads to area **F3**.

Irovetti's treasury, once overflowing with wealth, has suffered greatly due to his war effort—he hopes that if he wins the war, looting the PCs' kingdom will replenish this wealth.

Creature: King Irovetti has had his share of consorts over his years as ruler, yet he has no interest in sharing the rule of Pitax with a queen. Whenever a consort grew too keenly interested in marriage, he always found a way to end the relationship. With Engelidis, Irovetti feels he's found the perfect partner: a creature content to serve as a guardian and (with the aid of magic) a lover. Engelidis is the only one who knows about the sword Irovetti keeps hidden in area **F3**, and she offers

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up its location as a bargaining chip to the PCs if she's too wounded to carry on a fight against them and she thinks it could help buy her freedom.

ENGELIDIS **CREATURE 16**

See page 393

Initiative Perception +25

F3. *BRIAR*'S GROTTO

This underwater cave is a wonder to behold. Masses of what appear to be white, rose-shaped crystals cover every inch of the walls, floor, and ceiling of this grotto. Something floats in the middle of the room, slowly turning in the water's currents: a long object wrapped in a white cloth.

Treasure: This secret cavern is where Irovetti has hidden the magic sword *Briar*. Wrapped in Evindra's shawl, the sword floats languidly in the water despite the fact that it should sink. The crystals on the wall are a side effect of the strange weapon's presence in the area for the past several years, and while beautiful, they crumble when touched.

Briar's long period of absence from the First World has left the sword a mere shadow of its former power, although even as a shadow, the weapon is still formidable. As Nyrissa begins to saturate the Stolen Lands with First World power, and as *Briar* is used to slay creatures from the First World, its powers quickly return and its cunning intelligence awakens. When *Briar* is first handled by a PC, that character will feel a sudden sensation of heart-sickening loneliness that quickly passes, replaced by the realization that the weapon they hold is potent indeed. *Briar*'s abilities appear on page 584 of Appendix 4, and its role to play as Nyrissa turns her attention to the Stolen Lands—as well as how the PCs can learn more about the weapon's history—is detailed in Part 1 of Chapter 10.

CONCLUDING THE CHAPTER

By the end of this adventure, the PCs have waged a war against an enemy and likely have recovered a powerful weapon. While it may seem that they face no further organized opposition to claiming the rest of the Stolen Lands, nothing could be further from the truth. They may have learned some disturbing hints about the nymph Nyrissa's interest in the region, and if they recover *Briar* and return Evindra's shawl, they soon gain a chilling insight into the true peril that faces them. Yet these revelations can wait, for the PCs have won a war, and other concerns are likely more pressing.

Whether the party has exacted its revenge upon Irovetti or he fled, the throne of Pitax stands empty and the city itself is now a Freehold. Until the PCs convince the citizens of Pitax that they are trustworthy leaders by accumulating at least 30 Liberation Points, the nation remains in turmoil and any attempt to expand into Pitax's territory foments unrest and fear.

Once the PCs have defeated Irovetti and achieved at least 30 Liberation Points, though, things rapidly change. At the start of the next Kingdom turn, they can begin claiming hexes once controlled by Pitax without fear of reprisals or protests from the nation's grateful citizens, and the Negotiation DC to secure a Pledge of Fealty from Pitax drops from DC 28 to DC 18.

Pitax has 1 Water border and 3 Land borders; all of the Land borders have Stone Walls. The city has the Paved Streets infrastructure, and occupies all nine blocks on its Urban Grid, with all 36 lots containing structures. These consist of 9 houses, an alchemy lab, a barracks, an illicit market, a cathedral, a graveyard, a guildhall, an inn, a palace, a popular tavern, a secure warehouse, a shrine, two specialized artisans, a theater, and a waterfront.

WHAT IF IROVETTI ESCAPES?

The PCs don't need to kill or capture Irovetti to defeat him, though his escape is unlikely. If he does manage to survive (either alone or with some of his allies), Irovetti still effectively abandons his role as king, and any of his remaining allies are quick to abandon the region or even beg for forgiveness from the PCs. In this case, you can either have Irovetti leave the region and never return or have him continue to plague the PCs from the wilderness as he attempts to recruit new allies. He might even find his way to Thousandbreaths and beg for aid from Nyrissa, in which case the nymph is likely to either imprison him in her domain or transform him into some sort of strange new monster to serve as a guardian. In the latter event, feel free to pick one of the monsters the PCs face in Chapter 10, and when that creature is slain, its body shrinks down to reveal it was Irovetti all along.

If the PCs capture Irovetti alive, interrogating him can help the PCs learn more about Nyrissa—this development is detailed at the start of Chapter 10. Whether or not a captured Irovetti can be redeemed is left to the GM to determine.

A CHANCE TO RELAX

With the defeat of King Irovetti, the PCs have earned a chance to relax. For the months following this triumph, give them all the time they wish to recover and rebuild their kingdom from the damage caused by the war, and allow them to continue exploring the Stolen Lands and expanding their kingdom at their own pace. Investigating the mysteries to be found under Candlemere at their leisure should provide a welcome respite from the intensity of a full-blown war. You'll want to give the players this breather, since when Nyrissa makes her move, the PCs' kingdom will face its most dangerous threat yet!

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CHAPTER 9

THEY LURK BELOW

BY RON LUNDEEN

PART 1: THRESHOLD OF DREAD..... 398

The PCs should be 16th level before they attempt to explore the contested level below Candlemere.

PART 2: THE DEATH OF FEAR..... 412

The PCs should be 16th level before they attempt to explore the Spiral of Yog-Sothoth. Note that the encounters in this chapter are particularly dangerous, and the PCs are likely to reach 17th level before completing this part. If you're using milestones for leveling up, consider letting the PCs level up to 17th level the first time they retreat to rest and recover during this chapter rather than waiting for them to defeat Foras at the end.

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PART 1:

THRESHOLD OF DREAD

As detailed in Part 7 of Chapter 2, a misanthropic cultist named Foras built a complex for his cult of Yog-Sothoth worshippers, the Thresholders, under the island of Candlemere. When the cult was confronted by worshippers of Pharasma eons ago, a desperate fight took place. With the aid of their own great hero Korog, Foras's younger brother, the Pharasmins achieved initial success quickly in their attempt to defeat the Thresholders. Foras hadn't shared his powers with everyone in the cult of Yog-Sothoth, so the unenlightened acolytes at the Thresholders' lowest ranks couldn't stand against the zealous onslaught of the furious Pharasmins. Soon, the entire tower of Candlemere was taken, and the Pharasmins used it as a base of operations while they turned their attentions to the chambers below.

In the basement, the Pharasmins' advance was thwarted, for they hadn't realized how powerful Foras's inner circle of mystics and disciples were. After several failed attempts to progress into the chambers deep below Candlemere's basement, Korog made the difficult choice to seal the cultists within rather than risk defeat at his older brother's hands. The Pharasmins made a desperate push with their bravest fighters—including Korog—along with several allied psychopomps. As the Pharasmins penetrated the upper dungeon level, those behind them sealed the entrance to the dungeons shut with a magical ward on a stone plug. The Thresholders weren't defeated, but they could menace the surface no longer.

But the Thresholders had ensured their immortality, and they could afford to simply wait out the Pharasmins

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that had established a beachhead in the upper dungeon. The Pharasmins trapped within the dungeon made a difficult (and, in their beliefs, blasphemous) choice to ensure their continued ability to hold the cultists at bay. Using forbidden lore gleaned from collections of tomes they'd seized in their final push, Korog convinced his fellow Pharasmins to undertake a ritual to end their lives and rise as eternal graveknights so they could stand between the Thresholders and the surface forever.

Korog knew he had to keep this secret from the psychopomps who had accompanied the Pharasmins—the grim and resolute monitors would consider embracing undeath to be treachery of the highest order. Korog therefore tricked the psychopomps into entering a stasis which has, by now, stretched into millennia.

The divisions between the dungeon chambers held by Korog and the Pharasmins and those held by the Thresholders are now well defined, and both are laden with traps and guardians. While this standoff has remained for thousands of years, the cultists have not been idle; they have continued their pursuit of esoteric rituals and are preparing to open a metaphysical portal to pull Yog-Sothoth into the Material Plane. This ritual isn't close to completion, and as such the PCs have plenty of time to learn how to enter the dungeon and dispatch its ageless denizens—but if Foras and his cultists aren't stopped, Yog-Sothoth's arrival will not only free the cult back into the world, but will bring horror to the entire River Kingdoms as well.

RETURNING TO CANDLEMERE

It's likely that the PCs have already explored the uppermost level below Candlemere. This basement's threats are geared toward a 4th-level party (see Part 7 of Chapter 2 for details), but the Spiral Seal of Pharasma in area **F6** of that level (page 147) is powerful enough to block access beyond to 4th-level characters. While the encounters in this chapter are aimed at 16th-level PCs, the timing at which the characters return to Candlemere to explore its secrets is left open. The dungeons below Candlemere are in large part optional in the grand scheme of Kingmaker's plot, so if the PCs manage to reach 18th level without exploring the dungeons presented here, they can proceed directly to Chapter 10.

Yet while the encounters in this chapter are largely apart from the campaign's primary plot, PCs who explore this dungeon and defeat the cult that dwells within will gain a significant advantage once they reach Nyrissa's stronghold at the end of the next chapter. Her fortress, the House at the Edge of Time, has a unique relationship with time itself, and if the PCs defeat Foras and master the strange rite that awaits them below Candlemere, their ability to endure the warped temporal effects within the House at the Edge of Time will increase significantly.

KINGDOM IN THE BACKGROUND

The PCs' adventures under Candlemere are focused entirely within two self-contained dungeon levels, so there is nothing new to track with their kingdom as this chapter's encounters play out.

RESEARCHING THE SPIRAL SEAL

The PCs can begin researching the Spiral Seal as soon as they discover it, but initial attempts to do so may well meet with frustrating dead ends as lore about the Seal is difficult to find. Once they recover King Irovetti's notes on the Spiral Seal, though, they'll gain a much-needed boost to their research. If the PCs don't discover these notes, and/or they don't seem interested in returning to Candlemere (perhaps even as a result of having forgotten about the mysterious chambers below the tower on the isle), you could reintroduce the topic by having them hear rumors of an increasing number of lights swirling in the air above the ruins (these are more will-o'-wisps being drawn to the region as the power of the cult's rituals grows deep below ground), or even be asked by a trusted NPC to investigate rumors of strange sounds or magical manifestations witnessed on the island lately.

In any event, the PCs can investigate the Spiral Seal using the Research rules as detailed on pages 154–155 of the *Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide*. If the PCs have access to Irovetti's notes, they gain a +4 item bonus on all research checks made to research the Spiral Seal.

SPIRAL SEAL RESEARCH — LIBRARY 16

OCCULT

Regional Libraries Investigations pursued at a library in the PCs' kingdom, or one in a neighboring city like Restov or Pitax; **Maximum RP** 5

Research Checks DC 33 Library Lore or Pharasma Lore, DC 37 Occultism, DC 35 Religion

2 Research Points The PCs find that the Spiral Seal was created several thousand years ago by worshippers of Pharasma, and that it was intended to both physically and dimensionally seal off whatever chambers existed below. Further, the PCs learn that when creating the seal, some of the Pharasmins had to be in those chambers, resulting in them being trapped within.

5 Research Points The PCs determine that it might be possible to break the Spiral Seal open with physical damage, or even to remove it with *dispel magic*, but that these attempts can cause some sort of magical backlash. Alternately, they can attempt to remove the seal using Occultism or Religion checks, as detailed in Breaking the Spiral Seal below.

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KOROG'S HERESIES

It's worth keeping in mind that the choice the ancient Pharasmins made to become eternal undead servants was prompted not by religious fervor but by a mix of ego, shame, and self-righteousness. Korog knew that the Spiral Seal would keep the cultists entombed, but rather than have faith in that magic or in the worshippers of Pharasma who remained on guard in the outer world, he ordered his followers to turn their backs on their beliefs to embrace undeath. As the PCs discover the undead Pharasmins and learn more about the nature of their decision, allow them to attempt a DC 30 Religion or DC 25 Pharasma Lore check to understand that Korog's choice to become undead was blasphemous. A PC who uses this information against the undead Pharasmins gains a +2 circumstance bonus on Intimidation checks to Demoralize the undead and to the DCs of any emotion-based effects used against the undead, at the GM's discretion.

BREAKING THE SPIRAL SEAL

The Spiral Seal itself isn't technically a hazard, since it doesn't trigger like a trap or have any ability to affect the PCs unless they botch an attempt to remove it, but the methods for breaking the Spiral Seal follow those for dealing with a trap closely enough that it is presented below in the hazard format. (Since it's not particularly hidden, and since it only reacts under certain circumstances, the Spiral Seal has no Stealth entry.)

Once the Spiral Seal is removed, the ten-foot-diameter section of stone onto which it was inscribed vanishes, revealing a hole in the ground that drops 100 feet down into area **A1** below. The walls of this shaft can be Climbed with a DC 30 check—the cultists used magical flight or *teleport* to make the trip.

SPIRAL SEAL HAZARD 16

UNIQUE MAGICAL

Description A spiral shape suggesting the curling religious symbol of Pharasma is carved into the stone floor.

Disable DC 37 Occultism (master) or DC 40 Religion (master) to unmake the Spiral Seal through occult ritual or prayer performed as a 10 minute activity with the Concentrate trait, or *dispel magic* (9th level, counteract DC 40) to counteract the Spiral Seal.

AC 39; **Fort** +30, **Ref** +25

Hardness 27; **HP** 106 (BT 53), recovery; **Immunities** critical hits, object immunities, precision damage

Backlash ↷ (abjuration, incapacitation, occult) **Trigger** A creature fails an attempt to disable the Spiral Seal or inflicts damage to it without successfully breaking it; **Effect** The magic stored within the Spiral Seal blasts outward in a concussive wave of power, surging in a spiraling vortex. All creatures within 60 feet of the Spiral Seal must attempt a DC 41 Fortitude save.

Critical Success The creature is unaffected.

Success The creature is knocked prone.

Failure The creature is knocked prone and is stupefied 1 for 24 hours.

Critical Failure The creature is knocked prone, is stupefied 3 for 24 hours, and increases their doomed value by 1.

Recovery ◈ **Frequency** once per round; **Trigger** The Spiral Seal is damaged but is above its Broken Threshold; **Effect** The Spiral Seal repairs itself, regaining 30 Hit Points.

Reward: Grant the PCs 60 XP for breaking the Spiral Seal.

DUNGEON FEATURES

While the Spiral Seal is in place, the entirety of the Candlemere dungeon is shrouded in a powerful magical aura that prevents almost all travel in and out of the dungeon by any means, especially via teleportation effects, but also including any attempt to tunnel physically out of the complex (the one exception involves entry via dreams, but even then only one way; see Part 2 for more information). Once the Spiral Seal is removed, these limitations vanish, but, apart from the stone disappearing and thus granting the PCs access to the chambers below, there are no physical or spiritual cues that anything has changed. Unless the occupants witness the PCs using previously impossible actions, it'll likely be months or even years before they discover that the Seal has been lifted, as centuries of waiting have lulled them into lassitude. Once they do notice, they may (at the GM's discretion) begin tentative explorations into the world beyond.

Both levels of the Candlemere dungeon are carved from natural stone. Smaller stones the size of bricks are cunningly fit together to smooth out the walls and floors, while the ceilings are bare stone; only a few indicated areas are natural caverns. The paper-thin gaps between these smaller stones emit a pale glow that suffuses the dungeon with light from the walls and floor. This light has no apparent source; if the bricks are pulled out to expose the natural stone, the glow ceases. Natural caverns are dark. Unless indicated otherwise, halls throughout the dungeon are 10 feet high, while chambers are 20 feet high. The doors are all made of heavy stone that grind closed when not held open, but none bear locks or bars.

If the PCs haven't disabled the Dread Aura that infuses Candlemere (see page 144 of Chapter 2 for details), those effects continue to persist down into these dungeons.

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THE CONTESTED LEVEL

The chambers of Candlemere's upper dungeon are the site of a centuries-long stalemate between the Thresholders and the Pharasmins who wish to keep the cultists imprisoned. There were once three passages connecting the areas controlled by the Pharasmins (areas **A1–A8**) and the cultists (areas **A9–A17**), but one of these passages has collapsed, one is defended by a banshee loyal to neither side, and the other bears a trap the Pharasmins put in place long ago.

A1. THE LANDINGS

Removing the Spiral Seal in area **F6** of Chapter 2 (page 147) reveals a circular shaft descending 100 feet to a stone landing in the shape of a crescent moon. Stairs from this landing lead down to another just like it, and stairs from that landing lead to area **A2**. The air in this area blows steadily upward and brings the scent of dust and rot, like some massive creature exhaling its fetid breath.

A2. HALL OF THE OATHKEEPERS MODERATE 16

This large hall has doors to the west, southwest, and south. Also to the west, a steep staircase ascends and curves out of sight. Several pillars, each carved to resemble a tentacle reaching from the floor to the ceiling, surround the room and give an ominous sense of being caged by a monstrous beast.

The door leading south opens on a hall wholly blocked by rubble from an ancient collapse that occurred during the initial invasion of the dungeon by the Pharasmins. Several days of work with the proper tools (or much more quickly at the GM's discretion with the right magic) could restore this hallway to area **A14**.

Creatures: Four of the Pharasmins who chose to abandon their faith in order to stand forever against the cult remain here as graveknights. The armor they wear bears Pharasma's religious symbol—a spiraling comet—but the symbol itself appears smeared with fresh blood that constantly wells up and drips to the floor only to have those spatters fade away. Success on a DC 10 Religion check is all that's needed to identify Pharasma's symbol, but a critical success reveals that the blood dripping from it indicates very specific blasphemies against Pharasma—the creatures that wear this armor no longer serve her.

The graveknights don't expect intruders to come down the stairs, as they believe the Spiral Seal is still in place. So long as the PCs haven't loudly announced their presence, these graveknights have a –2 penalty to their initiative rolls. Once they notice the PCs, they attack at once. They fight until destroyed, but don't pursue anyone who flees up the stairs.

KELLID GRAVEKNIGHTS (4) CREATURE 14

RARE NE MEDIUM UNDEAD

Variant graveknight (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 190)

Perception +27; darkvision

Languages Hallit

Skills Acrobatics +29, Athletics +32, Intimidation +30, Religion +27, Survival +27

Str +8, **Dex** +5, **Con** +4, **Int** +2, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +4

Items +1 *greater frost greater striking dagger, resilient splint mail*, *+2 greater frost warhammer*

AC 37; **Fort** +24, **Ref** +25, **Will** +27

HP 255, negative healing, rejuvenation; **Immunities** cold, death effects, disease, paralyzed, poison, precision, and unconscious

Sacrilegious Aura 30 feet. As graveknight, but +23 counteract modifier.

Attack of Opportunity ↷

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *warhammer* +30 (magical, shove), **Damage** 3d8+16 bludgeoning plus 1d6 cold

Melee ❖ *dagger* +28 (agile, finesse, versatile S), **Damage** 3d4+14 piercing plus 1d6 cold

Ranged ❖ dagger +27 (agile, finesse, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4+14 piercing plus 1d6 cold

Devastating Blast ❖❖ (arcane, cold, evocation) As graveknight, but 8d12 cold damage (DC 34 basic Reflex save)

Repulsing Blow ❖ (arcane, enchantment, incapacitation, mental) **Requirements** The graveknight's last action was a success with a Strike using a shove weapon. **Effect** The target struck by the shove weapon is knocked back 10 feet and must succeed at a DC 33 Will save or be unable to approach within 5 feet of the graveknight for 1 round. If the last action was a critical hit, the target automatically fails the Will save.

Graveknight's Curse As graveknight, but DC 34.

Weapon Master As graveknight.

Treasure: The pillars around the room, if Searched, have small niches that slide open when pressed. Most of these niches contain only dust, but success on a DC 30 Perception check reveals that one of them holds a *+3 greater striking kukri* stashed here long ago by a cultist.

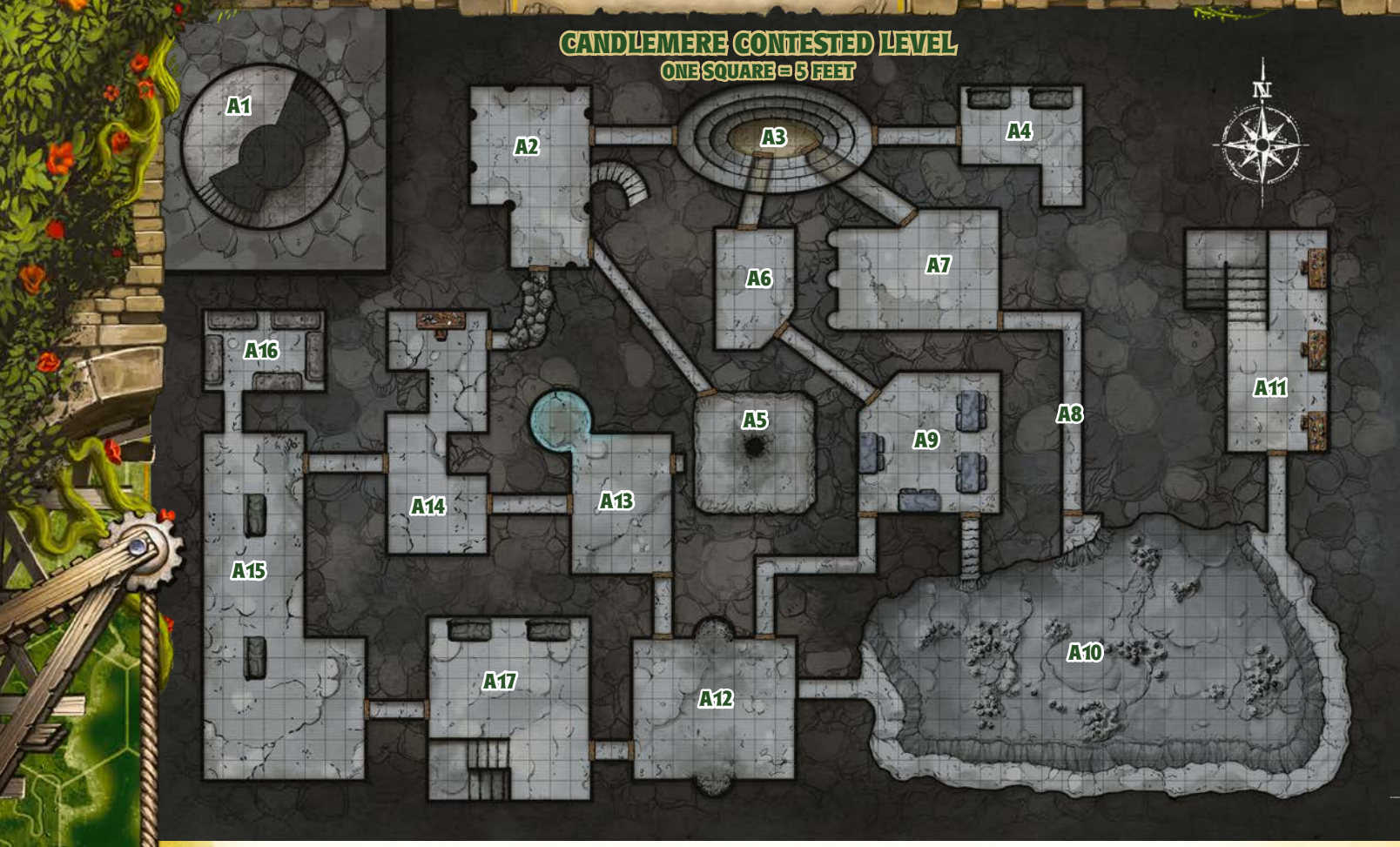
A3. AMPHITHEATER

This large, oblong room resembles an amphitheater. Three enormous ledges, each five feet wide and five feet high, descend in concentric ovals to a stony floor fifteen feet below. Two doors leave this room at the highest level—one at each end—and two more doors exit from the floor level.

The cultists sometimes used this room for meetings, or to force creatures to battle to the death on the floor below the ledges. The ledges were once connected by

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wooden stairs that long ago rotted and fell into dust, so ascending or descending now requires scrambling up and down blocks of stone (DC 20 Athletics check to Climb).

A4. SPEAKER'S CHAMBER MODERATE 16

This room has a few benches and a stone table along the north wall. An alcove to the south has a few rusted iron rings hanging from the ceiling. The rings bear tatters and scraps of a curtain that once concealed the alcove.

In important lectures or debates, the principal speaker used this room to prepare. The short hall to the amphitheater (area **A3**) allowed such speakers to compose themselves before making an appropriately dramatic entrance. There are a few metal writing tools on the stone desk, but no evidence of what would have been written here other than the words "He Knows the Gate" scratched on the desk in Aklo.

The once-curtained-off alcove was used for resting or meditation, but the current occupants haven't needed the privacy and tore down most of the curtain. The alcove contains a stack of metal folios carved with various disconnected pieces of occult lore written in a combination of Aklo and Necril. The books at the top walk through the steps required to transform a human warrior into a graveknight; it was these books that gave Korog the idea to use undeath to extend the Pharasmins' role as guardians indefinitely. In a fit of shame, Korog destroyed portions of these texts; while a DC 30 Religion check is enough to piece their original purpose together, the method itself cannot be learned from these fragments.

Creatures: Korog, the chief graveknight and younger brother of the Thresholders' leader, spends much of his time here. Once a powerfully built Kellid chieftain, he retains his imposing build even as a skeleton as a result of his armor. This full plate armor—a true rarity among the Kellids back in Korog's day—is black iron marked with rusted, bloody symbols of Pharasma. While the armor looks ancient and in poor condition, the supernatural effects of his presence as a graveknight keeps the armor functioning perfectly. Korog always preferred fighting to talking, which made him an impetuous chief, and he never got over the shock and shame of learning that his brother was the leader of the vile kidnappers and cultists hiding in Candlemere.

Korog sometimes checks in on the guards in area **A2**, but these patrols rarely take him long. He has two loyal guards with him at all times in the event the Thresholders

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try to breach the defenses. If they spot intruders, the graveknights draw their weapons and attack. Korog insists (in Hallit) that the trespassers depart if they value their lives, warning that their bumbling intrusion might unleash ageless evils and powerful cultists into the world again. These graveknights all fight until destroyed. If Korog's armor restores him, he does his best to ascertain the status of the Thresholders and return to his principal task of keeping them contained. Korog lacks the magic to restore the Spiral Seal, but he might work to physically block the passages out by collapsing the stone construction. These efforts will likely take him several weeks, but if the PCs depart Candlemere and return after a long period of time, they might have to bypass one of Korog's makeshift barriers.

KOROG CREATURE 16

UNIQUE | NE | MEDIUM | UNDEAD

Variant graveknight (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 190)

Perception +29; darkvision

Languages Hallit

Skills Acrobatics +29, Athletics +33, Intimidation +30, Religion +29, Survival +29

Str +8, **Dex** +5, **Con** +4, **Int** +2, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +4

Items *+2 resilient full plate, +2 greater shock maul*

AC 39; **Fort** +30, **Ref** +27, **Will** +27

HP 295, negative healing, rejuvenation; **Immunities** death effects, disease, electricity, paralyzed, poison, precision, and unconscious

Sacrilegious Aura 30 feet. As graveknight, but +26 counteract modifier.

Attack of Opportunity ↻

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *greater shock maul* +30 (magical, shove), **Damage** 3d12+17 bludgeoning plus 1d6 electricity

Designate Blood-Foe ❖ Korog declares one creature he can see within 30 feet to be his blood-foe whom he swears to defeat. He can have up to three blood-foes designated at a time; any additional blood-foe removes another blood-foe of Korog's choice. Korog treats the results of Perception checks made against blood-foes as improved by one degree, and he has a +2 circumstance bonus to AC against his blood-foes' attacks.

Devastating Blast ❖❖ (arcane, electricity, evocation) As graveknight, but 9d12 electricity damage (DC 37 basic Reflex save).

Graveknight's Curse As graveknight, but DC 37.

Korog's Command ❖ **Frequency** once per round; **Effect** Korog commands his allies to take an action. All allies who hear or see him are quickened 1 for 1 round and can use this extra action to Step, Stride, or make a Strike against one of Korog's blood-foes.

Weapon Master As graveknight.

KELLID GRAVEKNIGHTS (2) CREATURE 14

See page 401

Initiative Perception +27

Treasure: One larger fragment of the curtain is imbued with a minor preservative magic running through a silver thread sewn into the curtain. In the center of the fragment, the silver thread creates script that functions as a *scroll of heroism* (9th)—although the magic has been tainted. When this spell is cast, it functions normally, but once its duration ends, it leaves the target feeling like the magic has attracted something's attention. The feeling of paranoia resulting from this weird sensation leaves the creature stupefied 1.



KOROG

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A5. THE VOID PIT

The corners of this simple square room look partially melted, giving the stone chamber a soft, rounded look. A small hole in the floor leads down to darkness, its edges caked with ice and flickering faint light shining from somewhere within. The room's only door stands in the northeast wall.

The cultists once performed experiments and sacrifices requiring the void of deep space, so they created the Void Pit in this room to serve as a conduit for these rituals. Once the Spiral Seal was in place, the Void Pit became inert; this, plus the fact that it lies in an area held by the Pharasmins, has kept the cultists from attempting to retake the room.

Hazard: When the PCs remove the Spiral Seal, the Void Pit reactivates. The hole in the floor is a stone-lined well only 3 feet wide. The pit's walls are slick with ice and can be Climbed with a DC 35 Athletics check, but within it is supernaturally cold—a character takes 8d6 cold damage (DC 40 basic Fortitude save) at the start of any turn they begin in the pit. There's no bottom to the pit—after dropping ten feet, it opens into the black void of outer space, and anyone who looks down into it views the night sky below. A faintly shimmering magical barrier at the bottom keeps air from leaking out into space. This barrier also stops anything thrown or dropped into the pit from being pulled through, but determined creatures can push through the barrier—doing so feels like pushing through a layer of thick tar as the sheet spreads around the creature and closes immediately behind them.

The Void Pit is a potentially dangerous hazard, but it's also relatively safe as long as the PCs don't force their way through the barrier beyond. If it remains active, the Void Pit makes a great location to dispose of the gate icon (see area **B14**), or any other dangerous item the PCs might wish to dispose of, for once an object is pulled through here into the depths of space, it's lost for good, barring powerful magic to locate and retrieve it (a spell like *wish* would work).

VOID PIT — HAZARD 20

UNIQUE MAGICAL TRAP

Stealth DC 10 or *detect magic*

Description An ice-caked pit with no bottom looks out into the depths of space.

Disable DC 48 Thievery (legendary) to deactivate the pit's magical link to outer space or *dispel magic* (10th level, counteract DC 44)

Beyond the Barrier ↻ Trigger A creature within the pit takes three consecutive Interact actions to push their way through the barrier in the pit; **Effect** The creature is pulled through the portal into the depths of space. It can attempt to Grab an Edge with a DC 42 Reflex save, otherwise it discovers the portal is one-way—no return route to Golarion exists. The creature takes 10d6 bludgeoning damage (DC 42 basic Fortitude save) at the start of each turn and begins to suffocate. Without powerful magic like *plane shift* or *wish*, even a creature that can survive the depths of space will be lost forever—as the Void Pit deposits them in the unimaginably vast gulf between galaxies in which sound cannot exist, where they cannot cast spells with verbal components.

Reset The Void Pit resets instantly.

A6. HALL OF THE RELINQUISHED — MODERATE 16

This angled room has several wall carvings depicting a variety of people in unpleasant situations: folks being crushed under stones, prisoners locked behind spiked iron grates, kneeling people weeping beside dead trees, and so on. The carvings aren't uniform and appear to have been made over many years by many different hands.

The cultists made the carvings here, each designed to depict something they left behind in their old lives to dedicate themselves wholly to Yog-Sothoth. Each cultist was required to add something to this room upon becoming one of the Thresholders. As most cultists were—and remain—mean-spirited people, the carvings here are an inventory of petty jealousies, perceived wrongs, and persecution complexes.

Creatures: A cunning and powerful elven mercenary named Kyetriel joined the Pharasmins in their push to stop the Thresholders. Kyetriel met her end here when the cultists sprung a magical trap to



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damage her soul and poison her flesh. Kyetriel died, but the trap and her feelings of betrayal and agony anchored her soul here. Kyetriel rose as a powerful banshee, and she torments anyone who enters this room. The cultists know to stay out of the room for fear of Kyetriel's dread keening, and the Pharasmins consider Kyetriel to be a useful deterrent to prevent the cultists from coming this way.

Kyetriel attacks any living creatures that enter this room, opening with her Wail and then relying on her melee Strikes. Although she's normally bound to this room and can't leave it, if she affects an opponent with her Terrifying Touch, she can enter any room that character enters so long as it remains frightened. This means Kyetriel can follow PCs she injures, perhaps all the way to the surface to escape Candlemere at last.

KYETRIEL CREATURE 18

Elite banshee (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 6, 34)
Initiative Perception +34

Treasure: Kyetriel's corpse remains in this room, desiccated and still wearing the equipment she used in life, including a suit of *+1 resilient elven chain*, a *+2 keen striking elven curve blade*, and a *greater cloak of elvenkind*.

A7. ALCOVES OF THE WATCHERS MODERATE 16

Three alcoves, each holding a humanoid form wrapped tightly in spiderwebs, stand on the east wall of this room. Deep grooves and scratches in the walls and floor hint at a vicious fight here a long time ago.

Creatures: A trio of morrigna psychopomps accompanied the Pharasmins into the dungeon to aid in creating the Spiral Seal, only to be betrayed by Korog after he discovered the techniques to become a graveknight. Knowing the morrignas wouldn't approve of his blasphemous plan, he tricked them into entering a sort of torpor in this room, cocooned by spiderwebs yet prepared to break free at a moment's notice to intercept intruders. He then forbade his followers from ever disturbing them.

The three morrignas—Hastania, Oreshki, and Vatinitel—have remained in their torpor for so long that they've lost track of time, but as soon as anyone enters this room, they emerge from their wrappings at once. The morrignas assume the PCs are cultists if none of them obviously appear to be followers of Pharasma, and they neither ask for nor offer any mercy as they attack on sight.

If the PCs include an obvious follower of Pharasma, or manage to convince the psychopomps they're servants of Pharasma or opponents of the cult via a DC 39 Deception or Diplomacy check or a DC 34 Pharasma Lore or Religion check to stay the psychopomp's attack (this is an action with the Auditory, Concentrate, and Linguistic traits), the morrignas are more circumspect. They ask what brings the PCs to the site of an important barrier between the forces of Yog-Sothoth and devotees of Pharasma. They only allow the PCs to pass if they demonstrate, as a group, that they are persuasive and respectful. Doing so requires a PC to Request safe passage with a DC 39 Diplomacy check. If at least one PC succeeds at this check and no PC critically fails it, the morrignas let them come and go from this room as they please—otherwise they stand firm in their roles as guardians. They won't attack the PCs unless they attempt to force their way forward to area **A8**. If the PCs approached from that area, any attempt to convince the psychopomps that they're not cultists suffers a –2 circumstance penalty.

The morrignas consider any mention of Pharasmin graveknights to be a trick; they assume the Kellids that accompanied them here are long dead and wouldn't stoop to a blasphemy like undeath. Success at a DC 37 Diplomacy check is necessary to convince them of the truth; in this case, the morrignas investigate in person and either fight against the graveknights or instruct the PCs on how to dispose of their armor to prevent the graveknights from reforming. If the PCs can't convince the morrignas that they're telling the truth, the psychopomps assume the accusations of undeath are a blasphemous ruse and attack out of indignation.

MORRIGNA PSYCHOPOMPS (3) CREATURE 15

Pathfinder Bestiary 271
Initiative Perception +28

XP Award: If the PCs convince the morrignas to let them pass or recruit their aid against the undead Pharasmins, award the PCs XP as though they had defeated the morrignas in combat.

A8. TRAPPED HALL MODERATE 16

This long, L-shaped hall is lined with carvings that depict large globes as delicate as soap bubbles at varying heights, as though floating down the hall on a nonexistent breeze.

These images are not nearly as fanciful as they appear. They depict Yog-Sothoth in one of the forms it assumes in the mortal world: a collection of incandescent spheres. The cultists instilled an enchantment here to cause some of the orbs to glimmer with malevolent magical light whenever anyone walked down the hall, but the Pharasmins recognized this latent magical energy

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UNSEEN SIGHT

The ritual Foras led his cultists on allowed them to turn aside time and halt aging, but it required more than the sacrifice of an individual's given name—it required the sacrifice of sight itself. The removal of the eyes symbolized a Thresholder's abandonment of all they had seen before, and with the ritual's completion they gain something greater than mere vision: they gain the Unseen Sight. This is a precise sense that mimics darkvision yet functions even if the eye sockets themselves are covered. More importantly, the unseen sight allows a Thresholder to see the truth of the world, granting them the ability to see things as they actually are as if they were under the effects of *true seeing*, provided they are located within a region under the influence of Yog-Sothoth. Currently in the Stolen Lands, this is limited to the island of Candlemere and the dungeons within it; beyond this area, the Thresholder cultists are blind. Of course, if their plan to draw Yog-Sothoth into the region succeeds, the region in which the unseen sight functions will increase dramatically...

and reworked it into a deadly trap designed to catch unsuspecting cultists. The cultists haven't been back this way, so the trap still remains.

Hazard: Anyone walking past the midpoint of this hallway sees five of the orbs shimmer with color, quickly flickering through a wide range of unsettling and strangely nauseating hues. A soon as a second creature passes this midpoint, blasts of force launch from the orbs.

ORB BLAST TRAP HAZARD 18

UNIQUE COMPLEX MAGICAL TRAP

Stealth +35 (master) to realize that the glimmering orbs signal a dangerous trap.

Description Five globes shoot bolts of force up and down the hall when a second creature reaches its midpoint.

Disable Thievery DC 48 (master) to deactivate the trap entirely before it triggers, Thievery DC 45 (expert) to deactivate one of the glimmering orbs after the trap rolls initiative, or *dispel magic* (9th level; counteract DC 41) to deactivate the trap entirely.

Orb AC 42; **Fort** +27, **Ref** +33

Orb Hardness 30; **Orb HP** 40 (BT 20); **Immunities** critical hits, object immunities, precision damage; **Resistances** slashing 15

Slam Doors ↷ (arcane, evocation) **Trigger** A second creature crosses a magical sensor at the midpoint of the hall. **Effect** The doors at either end of the hall slam shut and lock in place while the trap is active (the doors open automatically if the trap is disabled or destroyed). The doors (Hardness 14, HP 56 [28 BT]) can be Forced Open with a DC 40 Athletics check, or via a DC 35 Thievery check to Pick the Lock. The trap rolls initiative.

Routine (5 actions) Five energized orbs each take one action to make a force bolt attack against a different target in the hallway (a single target cannot be fired at more than once per round by the trap). The trap doesn't take multiple attack penalties. Each orb that is disabled or destroyed reduces the trap's actions by 1.

Ranged force bolt +35 (can target any creature in area **A8**), **Damage** 4d10+18 force damage

Reset The trap deactivates 1 round after it has no creatures to target and resets automatically after 1 minute.

A9. SCRIPTORIUM

Several niches line the walls of this room. A few angled stone slabs near the walls have the appearance of writing desks. Between two doors leading south, the wall is a large slate board bearing several esoteric diagrams in chalk. Another door leads to the northeast.

Foras believed that copying and recopying abstruse texts and astronomical observations was the best way to drill fundamental occult concepts into new cult members, and this scriptorium was used for this purpose. The numerous copies tediously created here would have been immensely valuable to scholars across Avistan, but the cult never promulgated them and instead stored them in the cubbies here before starting their drudgery again. Unfortunately, these works have mostly been reduced to dust except for the final work: the *Helix Theorem* ritual presented on the slate board. This huge diagram shows certain cosmological conjunctions that trace an immense spiral in the heavens. A PC who succeeds at a DC 35 Occultism or DC 25 Religion check not only identifies this spiral as the symbol of Yog-Sothoth, but also notes that it curves in an opposite way from the spiral comet religious symbol of Pharasma. The *Helix Theorem*, presented in the symbols and notes in Aklo accompanying the diagram, describes closing a symbolic gate nine times along the spiral, from the center of the spiral outward. Although the *Helix Theorem* is described here, it isn't presented with sufficient detail for the PCs to actually perform the ritual. This is the PCs' first clue about how to permanently end the threat posed by Candlemere's lowest level.

Treasure: A cubby contains the only other items of value that haven't degraded, including a well-preserved *scroll of summon entity (8th)* on a thin sheet of brass, a stone tablet carved with runes and markings that function as a *scroll of weird*, and a mysterious looking tome that crumbles away if touched—this dust functions as a single dose of king's sleep poison.

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A10. MUTTERING CAVERN MODERATE 16

This enormous natural cavern is lit by phosphorescent fungus. Several stalagmites, some as high as fifteen feet, sprout from the cavern floor, each mirrored above by a companion stalactite. As a result, the cavern has the unsettling appearance of a half-closed mouth filled with needle-sharp teeth. Twenty feet above the floor, a wide ledge rings the cavern, although much of the ledge along the north side of the cavern has crumbled away. Four doors lead out from this ledge, although only the easternmost and westernmost are still connected by the ledge ringing the cavern to the south—the two other doors open onto rough platforms that no longer connect to the ledge.

The walls of this cavern can be Climbed with a DC 25 Athletics check. It's a 20-foot drop from the ledge to the cave floor below, and another 30 feet up to the ceiling from the ledge. The doors from areas **A8** and **A9** open onto isolated ledges, leaving nowhere to go but down to the cavern floor. The ledge connecting areas **A11** and **A12** is slick but relatively safe, although it's well within reach of the creature inhabiting the cavern.

Creature: The cultists discovered this natural cavern while building their lair, along with its horrific occupant—a shoggoth. By sealing the numerous narrow fissures through which the shoggoth entered this chamber from the Darklands below, centuries before even the Thresholders arrived in the area, they trapped the monster within. The cultists once kept it sated with offerings of prisoners when they needed to navigate this room, but when the Spiral Seal descended, the shoggoth went into an eons-long hibernation. Now that the seal is broken, the shoggoth has wakened, hungry and eager. Its cacophonous cries of "tekeli-li, tekeli-li!" echo through the cave as soon as the PCs enter. It fights until destroyed and pursues PCs relentlessly, its amorphous body allowing it to move through five-foot-wide spaces as difficult terrain. A brave or desperate party can potentially use the shoggoth as a weapon against other creatures in the dungeon, as it does not discriminate between targets that could serve as potential nourishment.

SHOGGOTH CREATURE 18

Pathfinder Bestiary 293

Initiative Perception +34

Treasure: The cultists sheared off the top of a stalagmite growing near the ledge by the entrance to area **A11**. They keep a small box containing twisted scraps of cloth on this pedestal; these improvised earplugs provide a +1 item bonus to saves against auditory effects, such as the shoggoth's Maddening Cacophony. Beneath the well-used earplugs is a vial containing a greater bravo's brew.

A11. LABORATORY MODERATE 16

The north end of this long room is bisected by a thin wall. On the west side of it, a series of tables bear a dizzying collection of laboratory equipment made of metal and crystal. On the east, a staircase descends steeply to a landing and bends out of sight.

The cultists constructed this laboratory to perform experiments on base chemicals to unlock insights into the building blocks of reality. Their successes in this endeavor were few, and as a result of their propensity for occasional explosive errors, Foras insisted this lab remain far from the principal chambers controlled by the Thresholders.

The stairs descend 100 feet to area **B1**.

Creatures: Two Thresholders work here. Having shed their former Hallit identities for the mystic names of Illocor and Kromori, these two hermeticists seek a method by which they can break matter into its fundamental components to study how reality itself is built and might be subverted to serve Yog-Sothoth's will. They haven't been able to capture living creatures from the surface in so long that they're desperate for new flesh and attack the PCs immediately in the hopes of capturing them and testing some of their more painful theories. Neither wants to admit defeat in front of the other and they both fight bravely; however, as soon as one of the pair falls, the other flees through area **A10** to join the cultists in the echo laboratory (area **A12**) and warn them of intruders.

THRESHOLDER HERMETICISTS (2) CREATURE 16

RARE | CE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Human occult researchers

Perception +29, unseen sight

Languages Aklo, Hallit

Skills Acrobatics +29, Crafting +31, Intimidation +25, Medicine +27, Occultism +31, Stealth +27, Survival +27, Yog-Sothoth Lore +31

Str +2, **Dex** +5, **Con** +3, **Int** +5, **Wis** +3, **Cha** +1

Items expanded alchemist's tools, major antidote, *+2 greater striking dagger*, religious symbol of Yog-Sothoth, *+2 resilient studded leather armor*

Infused Items A Thresholder Hermeticist carries the following infused items, which last for 24 hours or until the next time the Thresholder Hermeticist makes their daily preparations: infused greater acid flasks (14), infused major eagle-eye elixirs (2), infused major elixirs of life (3), infused greater mistform elixirs (2).

AC 39, concealed; **Fort** +28, **Ref** +30, **Will** +26; juggernaut

HP 290; **Resistances** mental 15

Juggernaut When the Thresholder Hermeticist rolls a success on a Fortitude save, they get a critical success instead.

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Outside of Time The Thresholder Hermeticist exists outside of time; they don't age, don't need food or drink to survive, and can't be quickened or slowed unless they choose to be.

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *dagger* +31 (agile, finesse, magical, versatile S), **Damage** 3d4+8 piercing plus cruel anatomist

Ranged ❖ greater acid flask +31 (range increment 30 feet, splash 10 feet), **Damage** 1 acid damage plus 3d6 persistent acid damage and 3 acid splash damage

Bomber When throwing an alchemical bomb with the splash trait, the Thresholder Hermeticist can deal splash damage to only their primary target instead of the usual splash area.



THRESHOLDER HERMETICIST

Cruel Anatomist The Thresholder Hermeticist deals an additional 2d8 bleed damage with melee Strikes. A creature who bleeds for 2 rounds from this becomes enfeebled 1 for as long as it continues bleeding.

Quick Bomber ❖ The Thresholder Hermeticist Interacts to draw an alchemical bomb, then Strikes with it.

Treasure: Anyone trained or better in Crafting realizes that the materials on the lab tables to the north of the room are all well-used. Despite this general lack of materials, however, the setup functions as expanded alchemist's tools and includes a *greater salamander elixir* and a dose of hemlock poison.

A12. ECHO LABORATORY — MODERATE 16

This large, square room has hemispherical alcoves in the north and south walls. The stone around these, as well as the ground between them, is scored with tiny grooves and ripples.

The alcoves in this room are very carefully engineered to reflect sound and bounce it between them repeatedly. Sonic damage created in this room inflicts an additional 1 sonic damage per die rolled as the amplifications empower it.

Creatures: A pair of Thresholders—a contemplative mystic named Balarom and a thickset disciple named Berinthus—work in this room not to amplify noise, but to dampen it. These cultists are attempting to mimic the soundless void of deep space, in the hopes that utter silence can help draw Yog-Sothoth's attention. When the PCs arrive, the mystic has already cast a 4th-level *silence* spell onto the disciple to aid their experimentation, and the disciple uses this to her advantage to rush at any spellcasters. Both of these cultists fight to the death.

THRESHOLDER MYSTIC — CREATURE 17

RARE | CE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Human cleric of Yog-Sothoth

Perception +31; unseen sight

Languages Aklo, Hallit

Skills Acrobatics +28, Deception +30, Intimidation +32, Medicine +31, Occultism +30, Religion +33, Yog-Sothoth Lore +32

Str +0, **Dex** +4, **Con** +1, **Int** +2, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +5

Items *+2 greater striking spell storing dagger* (contains *blindness*), *+2 resilient leather armor*, religious symbol of Yog-Sothoth

AC 41; **Fort** +27, **Ref** +29, **Will** +33; resolve

HP 315; **Resistances** mental 15

Resolve When the mystic rolls a success on a Will save, they get a critical success instead.

Outside of Time As Thresholder Hermeticist.

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Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *dagger* +31 (agile, finesse, magical, versatile S), **Damage** 3d4+6 piercing

Divine Prepared Spells DC 39, attack +30; **9th** *harm* (×6) *overwhelming presence*, *telepathic demand*, **8th** *dispel magic*, *spirit blast*, *heal*; **7th** *divine decree*, *crisis of faith*, *eclipse burst*; **6th** *blade barrier*, *heal*, *true seeing*; **5th** *prying eye*, *sending*, *tongues*; **4th** *air walk*, *discern lies*, *silence*; **3rd** *blindness*, *dream message*, *locate*; **2nd** *darkness*, *deafness*, *silence*; **1st** *bless*, *command*, *sanctuary*; **Cantrips (9th)** *daze*, *disrupt undead*, *forbidding ward*, *guidance*, *message*

Cleric Domain Spells 2 Focus Points, DC 38; **9th** *delay consequence**, *stasis** (**Pathfinder Lost Omens Gods & Magic* 118)

Divine Font *harm*

Reminder of Doom ❖ (auditory, concentrate, emotion, linguistic, mental) The mystic reminds their allies of the punishments awaiting those who fail Yog-Sothoth. The mystic and their allies within 60 feet gain a +2 status bonus to attack rolls and damage rolls until the end of the mystic's next turn.

Steady Spellcasting If a reaction would disrupt the Thresholder Mystic's spellcasting action, they attempt a DC 15 flat check; on a success, the action isn't disrupted.

THRESHOLDER DISCIPLE CREATURE 14

RARE | CE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Human cultist

Perception +26; unseen sight

Languages Aklo, Hallit

Skills Acrobatics +27, Athletics +28, Intimidation +26 (+28 to Demoralize), Religion +25, Stealth +25, Yog-Sothoth Lore +24

Str +5, **Dex** +5, **Con** +2, **Int** +0, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +2

Items major elixir of life, *+2 striking handwraps of mighty blows*, religious symbol of Yog-Sothoth, robes, shuriken (10)

AC 36; **Fort** +23, **Ref** +28, **Will** +25; evasion

HP 255; **Resistances** mental 10

Evasion When the disciple rolls a success on a Reflex save, they get a critical success instead.

Guarded Movement The disciple gains a +4 circumstance bonus to AC against reactions triggered by their movement.

Outside of Time As Thresholder Hermeticist (page 407).

Speed 40 feet

Melee ❖ fist +29 (agile, magical), **Damage** 2d6+11 bludgeoning plus 3d6 mental

Melee ❖ lurker claw +29 (forceful, magical, parry), **Damage** 2d12+11 slashing plus 3d6 mental

Ranged ❖ shuriken +28 (agile, thrown 20 feet, reload 0), **Damage** 1d4+11 piercing plus 3d6 mental

Flurry of Blows ❖ (flourish) **Frequency** Once per turn; **Effect** The disciple makes two unarmed Strikes. If both hit the same creature, combine their damages for the purposes of resistances and weaknesses. The disciple's multiple attack penalty applies normally to these Strikes.

Lurker Stance ❖ (stance) The disciple takes the stance of the Lurker at the Threshold, full of menace and danger. The disciple can make lurker claw unarmed attacks. These deal 1d12 slashing damage; are in the brawling group; and have the parry, forceful, and unarmed traits. While in this stance, if the disciple succeeds or critically succeeds at a



THRESHOLDER MYSTIC

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check to Demoralize a target, the target must succeed at a DC 34 Will saving throw or be stupefied 1 (stupefied 3 on a critical failure) for 1 minute.

Ominous Mien ❖ **Requirement** The disciple is in Lurker Stance; **Effect** The disciple gains a +2 circumstance bonus to Intimidation checks and their Demoralize attempts don't take a penalty for not speaking the target's language and don't cause the target to become temporarily immune. These effects last until the end of the disciple's next turn.

Temporal Strikes The disciple's Strikes force the creature hit to endure a deluge of unfamiliar memories from a combination of past lives and parallel existences, causing an additional 3d6 mental damage with a successful hit.

Treasure: One of the chimes on the rack is a critical component of the experiments here; it is a hollow metal *wand of widening sound burst (7th level)*.

A13. STAR SPHERE

An archway in the northeast corner of this room opens into a fifteen-foot-diameter spherical hollow. The interior of the sphere glows with tiny points of light that almost look like a representation of a stellar map or constellation chart. Doors lead out to the east, west, and south.

The sphere is a celestial globe showing the position of the stars in relation to the surface of Golarion as pinpricks of magical light. As the Thresholders didn't want to rely on astronomical observations made from the Candlemere tower, they installed this globe as a reference point. When they were cut off from the surface, the Thresholders initially relied extensively on this globe, but after long centuries they've all memorized this information and don't need to check on it much any longer. This room is therefore frequently empty except when cultists are traveling between areas.

The door to the west opens upon a shallow alcove, the far wall of which bears a large, purple glyph that resembles several interlocking bubbles. This glyph can be used to trigger a one-way passage into area **A5**. When the proper combination of bubbles on the runes are pressed (which requires success on a DC 35 Occultism or DC 37 Arcana check to determine), the stone of the wall shifts to the consistency of thick mud for 1 minute, allowing a creature to push through the wall into area **A5** as if moving through difficult terrain. Creatures cannot pass through it in the opposite direction.

The cultists assume that the Pharasmins are in control of the Void Pit in area **A5**, but if they learn otherwise, they might use this route to expand their influence into the northern parts of the dungeon.

Hazard: Anyone who touches the glyph in any way other than by using the proper combination triggers a trap that encases the target in a timeless eternity.

FROZEN MOMENT TRAP — HAZARD 17

Pathfinder Core Rulebook 525
Stealth DC 40 (master)

A14. THE BENDING WAY — MODERATE 16

This hall makes several tight turns, obscuring most of it from view behind walls decorated with spiral symbols. The north end of the hall contains a few tables loaded with loose stone and a variety of bowls, jars, and measuring scales.

This long room was once used for meditation, to show cultists that a twisting way to truth is sometimes the only way to find it. When the Pharasmins attacked and destroyed the shortest passage to the entry hall (area **A2**), the Thresholders were more easily confined to the southern half of the dungeon. The cultists realize there is a potential tactical advantage to gain from reopening this passage, but they also understand that keeping the rubble as-is affords perhaps an even greater protection from their enemies. As such, progress toward restoring the passageway has never gone much farther than argument-laced discussions.

Creatures: The hermeticist and disciples working here are quick to attack any intruders. They communicate with each other in eerie whispers as they fight, out of habit. These foes fight to the death.

THRESHOLDER HERMETICIST — CREATURE 16

See page 407
Initiative Perception +29

THRESHOLDER DISCIPLES (2) — CREATURE 14

See page 409
Initiative Perception +26

Treasure: The hermeticist's worktable contains expanded alchemist's tools and a major serene mutagen.

A15. HALL OF ABERRANT REFLECTIONS

Steel mirrors line the east wall of this long hall, extending from floor to ceiling. A corridor leads north, and two doors exit to the west. Two stone benches stand in the room, positioned so that anyone sitting upon them can face their reflections. Neither the benches nor the doors are reflected in the mirrors opposite them.

Each of the mirrors here are magically warped, like subtle fun house mirrors. Instead of reflected creatures seeming distended or compressed, however,

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they appear slightly alien: wider eyes with fang-filled mouths, elongated heads that pulse with dark veins, or hateful sneers below dead-white eyes. To keep anyone meditating on these magical images from being distracted, the mirrors are enchanted so the doors across from them don't appear in the reflections—they just appear to be blank walls instead. The same is true for any unattended objects in the room, like the benches; they aren't reflected in the mirrors at all. These minor magical properties can be discovered with a DC 30 check to Identify Magic.

Any significant noise in this room brings the disciples resting in area **A16** to investigate.

A16. UPPER BUNK ROOM MODERATE 16

Ten stone slabs each large enough to hold a reclining human line the walls of this room, stacked in pairs like bunk beds. A tattered leather mat lies upon each.

The cultists sleep in this room from time to time, although most hermeticists and mystics are too involved in their current projects to come back here to sleep.

Creatures: A total of four Thresholder Disciples are in this room at any time, taking their turn to doze or simply meditate. These disciples switch out for those in other areas of the dungeon from time to time, although they have long ago lost any sense of a normal day-night cycle and rest for any period between a few hours and a few weeks. If alerted to danger, these disciples are quick to spring into action. They pursue foes throughout the dungeon, offer no quarter, and fight until slain.

THRESHOLDER DISCIPLES (4) CREATURE 14

See page 409

Initiative Perception +26

A17. VISITOR LOUNGE

This large room has a vaulted ceiling that rises thirty feet high. The arched ceiling resembles a wide-open sky, complete with ominous gray storm clouds and subdued sunlight that shines fitfully down to the floor below in softly shifting beams. Several low stone benches with curved backs provide comfortable and intimate seating. A narrow staircase leads down to the south.

On the rare occasions when the cultists hosted visitors, they wanted to ensure their guests' comfort so that they could more easily sway or deceive them. This room's ceiling had an illusion placed to accurately reflect the sky above Candlemere, but it long ago froze in the current view of a pending rainstorm. Anyone watching the ceiling sees it shudder and loop after a few minutes to repeat the same movements over and over.

The door to the west leads to a short hall with a glyph much like that in area **A13**. This controls a one-way door leading to area **A12**, but unlike the door in area **A13**, the cultists still use it quite often.

The stairs here descend 100 feet to area **B3**.

Hazard: As with the trap in area **A13**, misusing the glyph controlling the one-way door triggers a trap to freeze the target in time. However, since this trap has been used so often over the millennia, it's slightly easier to identify the correct orbs to push. The trap's Stealth DC is therefore slightly lower.

FROZEN MOMENT TRAP HAZARD 17

Pathfinder Core Rulebook 525
Stealth DC 38 (master)



THRESHOLDER DISCIPLE

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PART 2:

THE DEPTH OF FEAR

The deepest levels below Candlemere present a harrowing challenge for a high-level party. While the events that play out in this long-sealed dungeon have very little direct impact on the story of Kingmaker, the potent treasures awaiting discovery within the Spiral will certainly aid the PCs in defending their realm from Nyrissa in the next chapter.

THE SPIRAL OF YOG-SOTHOTH

Candlemere's lowest dungeon consists of several rooms built around an enormous spiral engineered by Foras to catch and focus Yog-Sothoth's gaze, and it is where the Thresholders focus their most important efforts to draw Yog-Sothoth into the Material Plane. In the center of the spiral is a ritual chamber where the cult leader, Foras, works tirelessly at his rituals.

But Foras and his cultists aren't alone in their endeavor. In the months before the clash with the Pharasmins, Foras reached out to the windswept plateau of Leng, for allies. A group of powerful denizens of Leng answered by sending a delegation of inhuman envoys to aid them, only to become trapped in the dungeon when the Spiral Seal cut off dimensional travel. In that time, the denizens have managed to breach the Spiral Seal only a few times to conjure potent agents from the depths of time itself, but even these powerful hounds of Tindalos found themselves unable to exit the dungeon as long as the Spiral Seal remained.

Fortunately for the cultists, the denizens of Leng are inhumanly patient, and they have been content to

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merely wait out the Spiral Seal. They've taken over the eastern rooms in the lower dungeon, and the cultists are happy to let them have those rooms while they continue to pursue their own goals.

THE HELIX THEOREM

Although the PCs can prevent the Thresholders from finishing their patient endeavor in engineering Yog-Sothoth's arrival on Golarion by simply killing them all and destroying their work, the very structure of the Spiral of Yog-Sothoth will continue to draw the Outer God's gaze as long as it remains. Merely knocking over a few walls or blocking a few passages can't undo the mystical effect the Spiral has imbued the region with; it has existed for so long that its shape is burned into the fabric of reality and the risk of catching Yog-Sothoth's attention will remain until someone takes specific action to reverse this condition. A PC who has explored the Spiral and succeeds at a DC 35 Occultism or DC 33 Yog-Sothoth Lore check realizes the metaphysical danger the lower dungeon poses.

To render the Spiral of Yog-Sothoth entirely harmless, the PCs must discover and perform a mystic rite called the *Helix Theorem*. The PCs can first learn about this ritual by examining the slate board in area **A9**, with further information awaiting discovery in area **B13**. In brief, the ritual requires closing a miniature gate icon nine times: once each in areas **B14**, **B13**, **B12**, **B10**, **B8**, **B4**, **B3**, **B2**, and **B1**, in that order. Each time the gate is closed as part of the correct sequence, the icon itself glows with a soothing pale blue light until it is opened again (likely to perform the next closing). If the gate is closed out of sequence, the pale blue light flashes brightly before extinguishing, and the process must be started from the beginning.

The tiny gate must be a specially prepared icon representing the cosmic seal that serves as a boundary between Yog-Sothoth and the Material Plane. The miniature gate in area **B14** works well for this purpose, although the PCs can prepare their own icon with success on a DC 38 Crafting check. Each time the gate is shut in one of these rooms, the PC performing the ritual must succeed at a DC 36 Occultism check. Other PCs can Aid this check as usual by intoning chants or simply helping to carry the gate. If any of these Occultism checks is failed, the PCs must start again in area **B14**. At the conclusion of the ritual, the miniature gate must be placed—still closed—in the alcove in area **B1** at the very end of the spiral. When the *Helix Theorem* is successfully performed, the rooms in the lower dungeon twist and flex, shifting through the earth until they all exist along a straight line, rather than a curving spiral. This movement is unnerving but harmless to those in the rooms. The rooms thereafter can't capture Yog-Sothoth's attention or open the way for Yog-Sothoth to enter the Material Plane.

While this certainly prevents a potential disaster from destroying the PCs' kingdom, performing the *Helix Theorem* here has an unanticipated side effect that the PCs won't realize until some time later—by performing this rite, they inadvertently bolster their own presence in the flow of time. Any PC who was present below Candlemere when the *Helix Theorem* is performed gain additional protections once they reach Nyrissa's House at the Edge of Time (page 456).

If the PCs don't realize the danger posed by the Spiral or fail to perform the *Helix Theorem*, the long-term effects are up to the GM. Eventually, the Spiral draws other prospective cultists into the chambers; these cultists arrive singly or in small groups but quickly join together to continue the work the Thresholders began. These new cultists might be more powerful or more numerous than those the PCs previously destroyed. The spiral may even draw Yog-Sothoth's dire gaze, causing spheres of eldritch power to erupt in the region and then begin to pull this part of the Material Plane out of phase with the rest of reality, exacerbating the dangers of the blooms that afflict the PCs' kingdom at the start of Sound of a Thousand Screams.

Reward: If the PCs successfully complete the *Helix Theorem* ritual, award them 120 XP.

B1. WASHING STATION

A long trough of clear water lies along the length of the western wall of this room. A narrow, curved alcove extends a few feet into the north wall before ending at a star-shaped symbol. A hall opposite it curves away to the southeast. Stairs ascend steeply to the east.

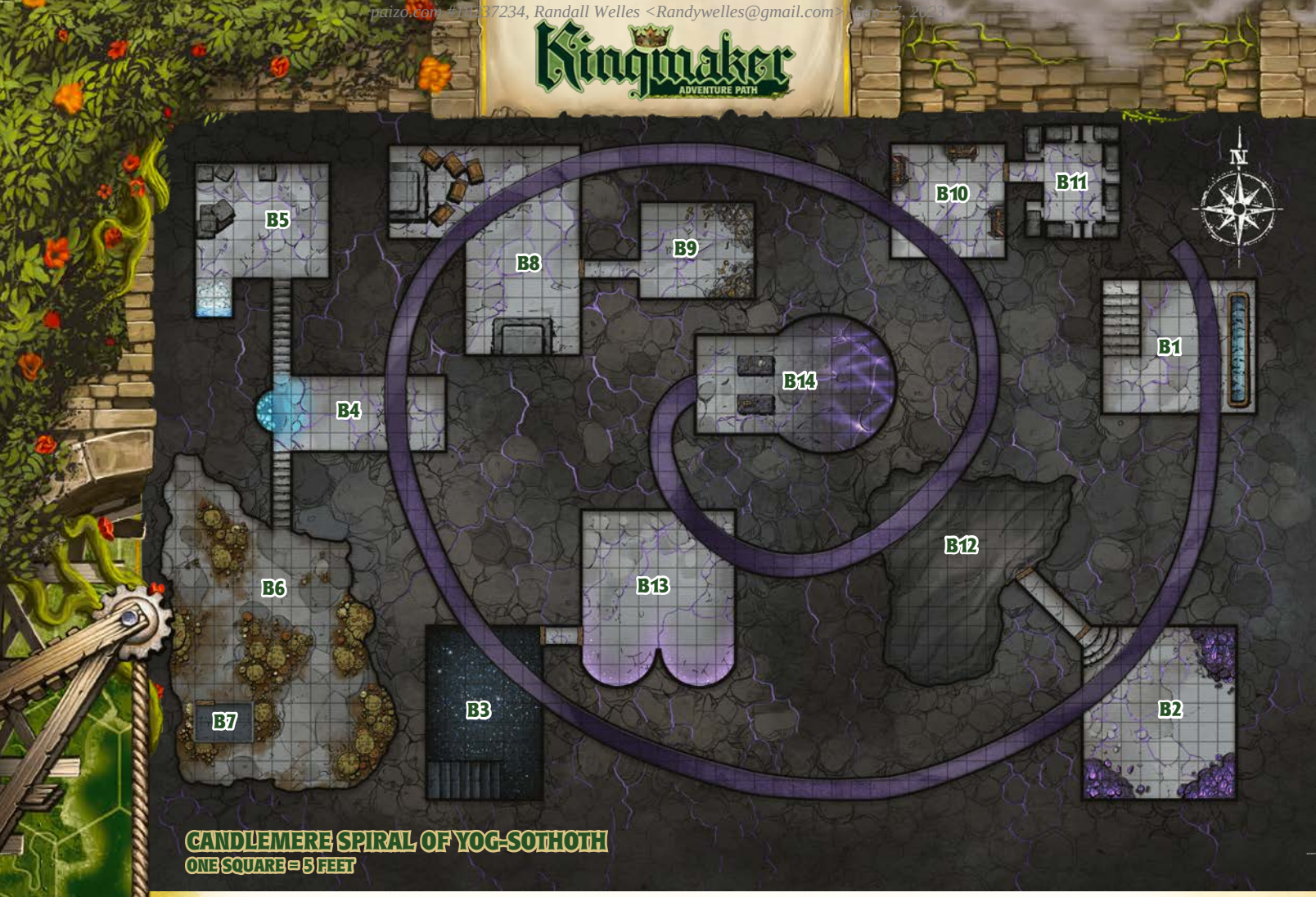
This chamber is the first of many shrines the cultists regularly use to venerate Yog-Sothoth. Here, at the beginning of the journey along the spiral, the cultists wash their garments and their bodies in icy cold water that is continually cleaned and chilled by a minor magical effect. Cleanliness isn't particularly important to Yog-Sothoth—who has little care about flesh at all, whether dirty or clean—but the cultists use the cold water scrub to focus their minds on the upcoming portions of the ritual.

The stairs lead up to area **A11**.

Success on a DC 35 Religion check is enough to note that the star-shaped symbol on the alcove wall symbolizes the Outer God Azathoth, seething chaos at the "center of reality." This symbol serves as the starting point of the ritual spiral that curves throughout this lower level, as the cultists seek to replicate and expand upon this terrifying event.

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CANDLEMERE SPIRAL OF YOG-SOTHOTH
ONE SQUARE = 5 FEET

B2. CHAMBER OF THE WORM SEVERE 16

This enormous room contains heaps of glittering stones, each the size of a fist, all haphazardly piled along the west and south walls. A narrow, curved track on the floor leads from the curved hall to the north into the curved hall to the east. In the northeast corner of the room, a terrace-like set of tall stairs leads up to a narrow stone door.

Creature: This room serves as the home for an eldritch envoy from the Darklands—a neothelid named Niodrhast. Before the Spiral Seal, Niodrhast came and went via teleportation, and served the Thresholders as a sort of supply route for strange components or other needs. The neothelid went into hibernation soon after the Spiral Seal locked it in place; it wakens from its torpor slowly now that the seal has been broken. It attacks any intruders into this realm at once, but if the PCs are forced to retreat and return, they'll find Niodrhast has vacated the area, having returned to Denebrum to catch up on the centuries it missed.

NIODRHAST CREATURE 19

UNIQUE CE GARGANTUAN ABERRATION

Variant neothelid (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 181)

Perception +33; greater darkvision, thoughtsense 100 feet.
Languages Aklo, Alghollthu, Undercommon; telepathy 100 feet
Skills Acrobatics +35, Athletics +37, Deception +38, Diplomacy +36, Intimidation+ 38, Occultism +38
Str +10, **Dex** +6, **Con** +8, **Int** +9, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +9
Thoughtsense (divination, mental, occult) As neothelid.

AC 43; Fort +35, **Ref** +31, **Will** +33; +1 status to all saves vs. magic
HP 445; **Immunities** acid; **Weaknesses** cold iron 20; **Resistances** mental 20
Dimensional Wormhole ↻ (conjuration, occult, teleportation) As neothelid.

Speed 30 feet, fly 50 feet
Melee ❖ jaws +37 (reach 15 feet), **Damage** 4d12+18 piercing plus Improved Grab
Melee ❖ rasping tongue +37 (agile, fatal d10, reach 25 feet), **Damage** 4d8+18 slashing
Occult Innate Spells DC 41, attack +33; **9th** *phantasmal calamity*, *summon entity*; **8th** *charm*, *suggestion*; **7th** *teleport*; **6th** *scrying* (×3), *suggestion* (at will); **5th** *mind probe* (at will), *telekinetic haul* (at will); **Cantrips (9th)** *daze*, *detect magic*, *mage hand*, *telekinetic projectile*
Rituals DC 41; *geas*, *inveigle*
Breath Weapon ❖❖ (acid, evocation, occult) As neothelid, but 20d6 acid damage and DC 41 basic Reflex save.

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Instant Suggestion ↻ As neothelid.
Lashing Tongues ❖❖ As neothelid.
Swallow Whole ❖ Large, 2d12 bludgeoning plus 3d12 acid, Rupture 31

Treasure: One of the quartz gems on the floor has a *dispelling sliver talisman* lodged within it. This treasure is well concealed among the heaps of valueless quartz, however, and a PC who Searches the piles must succeed at a DC 36 Perception check to locate it.

B3. RUNE-SCRIBED ROOM

The walls, floors, and ceiling of this room are inscribed with thousands of tiny runes, each glittering with a pale, cold light like that of a distant star. A staircase ascends to the southeast, and a door stands in the northwest corner. A curved hall exits to the west and another exits to the north. By the runes worn away between those two halls, it's clear that a significant amount of foot traffic has come and gone between them.

The runes here aren't magical except for their glow, but they represent thousands of different components of the eldritch worship of Yog-Sothoth. Each rune represents a deeper concept that requires decades of study to understand. The cultists pass into this room as part of their ritual journey along the spiral, choosing a single different rune to stare at and meditate upon each time they come through here.

The door to the northeast leads to a short hallway culminating in a door to area **B13**, a room with a similar meditative purpose. Cutting from one of these rooms to the other can be disruptive to meditations, so just inside the hallway near each door, a small metal bell has been rigged to ring when the opposite door is opened, alerting occupants that someone is coming through the hallway. The mechanism that triggers the bells can be spotted before a door is opened with success on a DC 35 Perception check, after which it's an easy DC 25 Thievery check to Disable the bell.

The staircase leads up to area **A17**.

B4. COLD PRAISE SEVERE 16

This long room has two curving hallways exiting from the north and south walls of its western end and two steep stairways descending from the north and south walls of its eastern end. At the east end of the room, a rounded alcove shows ever-shifting shapes in a vibrant blue color.

The shapes in the east alcove are words in Aklo, constantly shifting and changing to form praises to Yog-Sothoth and aphorisms about the Outer God's eventual return when the stars are right and the cosmic gate is opened. Anyone who enters this room must read aloud from the script or face a debilitating magical trap. The visitors from Leng who occupy areas **B5**–**B6** to the east don't bother on the occasions they pass through here since they're immune to cold.

Hazard: Any creature who spends more than 1 round in this room and doesn't read aloud one of the phrases in Aklo writhing above the alcove causes the trap to trigger.

PRAISE OF YOG-SOTHOTH HAZARD 19

COMPLEX | MAGICAL | TRAP

Stealth +37 (legendary) to recognize the symbols as a magical trap
Description Magical letters reveal phrases in Aklo that, if not properly spoken aloud, inflict numbing cold.
Disable DC 47 Occultism (master) or DC 49 Religion (master) three times in a row to successfully speak aloud the esoteric phrases as they appear (this causes the trap to deactivate for 1 hour, although the phrases continue to appear during this time), or *dispel magic* (9th level, counteract DC 38).
Reactive Charge ↻ (arcane, evocation) **Trigger** A creature spends more than 1 round in the room without speaking aloud the phrases appearing in the alcove. **Effect** The creature takes 12d6 cold damage (DC 41 basic Fortitude save, plus immobilized for 1 minute on a critical failure). The trap then rolls initiative.
Routine (1 action) The trap fills the entirety of area **B4** with additional blasts of cold. All creatures in area **B4** take 12d6 cold damage (DC 41 basic Fortitude save, plus immobilized for 1 minute on a critical failure).
Reset The trap deactivates 1 round after it has no target creatures and resets after 1 minute.

B5. THE HOWLING ROOM SEVERE 16

The noise of howling wind is obvious to any hearing creature from the stairs leading down into this chamber.

A few stone biers are the only furnishings in this room. An alcove to the southeast emits a constant howl of wind that blows around the room. The wind isn't particularly strong, but gouges on the walls indicate that it must have been blowing ceaselessly for many years. A staircase ascending from the south wall is the room's only exit.

The alcove emits a constant howling wind that is magically contained to this room. The wind originates from hundreds of tiny holes at the rear of the alcove, but its source is a distant nameless world where ceaseless storms howl. The cultists sometimes meditated in this room, listening for insights into creation from the ceaseless wind.

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The wind imposes a –2 circumstance penalty on auditory Perception checks and on attack rolls for ranged physical attacks, such as arrows. Unprotected flames in the room are instantly blown out. The room is difficult terrain for creatures that are Flying.

Creatures: As the Leng envoys found this room reminded them of their windswept home, Foras graciously allowed them to use it as their private chamber. One envoy is currently here while the other is being interviewed by cultists in area **B8**.

That single Leng envoy and a mastiff of Tindalos are enjoying the blowing wind. They realize that anyone they don't recognize must be an enemy of the cult, and they hope to curry favor with Foras by eliminating them quickly. The Leng envoy fights to the death, but the mastiff of Tindalos, recognizing that the Spiral Seal is no more since the PCs obviously made it inside, flees via Angled Entry if reduced to fewer than 30 HP.



LENG ENVOY

LENG ENVOY CREATURE 18

RARE | CE | MEDIUM | ABERRATION | DREAM

Variant denizen of Leng (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 70)

Perception +31; darkvision

Languages Aklo; *tongues*

Skills Acrobatics +32, Athletics +29, Deception +35, Intimidation +32, Occultism +35, Sailing Lore +38, Stealth +32, Thievery +30

Str +5, **Dex** +6, **Con** +5, **Int** +9, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +6

Items *+2 greater striking keen kukri*, Leng rubies worth 300 gp (4), pipes

AC 42; **Fort** +27, **Ref** +30, **Will** +33

HP 240, planar fast healing 15; **Immunities** cold; **Resistances** critical hits 20, precision 20

No Breath The Leng envoy doesn't need to breathe.

Planar Fast Healing As denizen of Leng.

Speed 30 feet

Melee ❖ *kukri* +34 (agile, finesse, magical, trip), **Damage** 3d6+13 slashing plus 3d6 persistent bleed

Melee ❖ jaws +32 (agile, finesse), **Damage** 3d10+13 piercing plus debilitating bite

Occult Innate Spells DC 40, attack +34; **9th** *unfathomable song*, *phantom pain*; **8th** *suggestion*, *uncontrollable dance*; **5th** *locate*, *mind probe*; **7th** *warp mind*; **4th** *outcast's curse*; **3rd** *hypnotic pattern*, *levitate*; **2nd** *mirror image*; **Cantrips (9th)** *chill touch*, *detect magic*, *mage hand*, *message*, *read aura*; **Constant (9th)** *tongues*

Leng Ruby (enchantment, occult) As denizen of Leng, but can target a creature with *mind reading*, *outcast's curse*, *phantom pain*, or *warp mind*.

Debilitating Bite (curse, occult) As denizen of Leng, but DC 40 Fortitude save.

Play the Pipes ❖❖❖ (auditory, primal) **Frequency** once per day; **Requirements** The Leng envoy is holding a musical instrument; **Effect** The envoy plays a melody on its instrument to cast *uncontrollable dance*, *unfathomable song*, or *warp mind* without expending the spell slot and using his music in place of providing the spell's component actions. The spell gains the auditory trait and targets all creatures in a 60-foot emanation instead of its usual targets. A creature that succeeds at its Will save against any spell is then temporarily immune from all spells played from the envoy's pipes for 1 minute. Aberrations are immune to this music.

MASTIFF OF TINDALOS CREATURE 15

RARE | NE | MEDIUM | ABERRATION | EVIL | TIME

Variant hound of Tindalos (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 146)

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Perception +29, greater darkvision
Languages Aklo
Skills Acrobatics +31, Athletics +27, Occultism +31, Stealth +31, Survival +27 (+29 to Track)
Str +6, Dex +8, Con +4, Int +8, Wis +6, Cha +4

AC 37; **Fort** +23, **Ref** +29, **Will** +27
HP 210; **Immunities** controlled, emotion; **Immunities** cold; **Resistances** mental 15, poison 15, physical 15
Otherworldly Mind ↷ (mental) As hound of Tindalos, but 8d6 mental damage and DC 33 Will save.
Ripping Gaze (aura, evocation, occult, visual) 30 feet. As hound of Tindalos, but 8d6 slashing damage and DC 33 Fortitude save.
Vulnerable to Curved Space As hound of Tindalos.

Speed 30 feet, fly 30 feet
Melee ❖ jaws +29, **Damage** 3d12+14 piercing
Melee ❖ claws +29 (agile), **Damage** 3d10+14 slashing
Occult Innate Spells DC 32, attack +29; **8th** *discern location*; **7th** *dimension door* (at will), *dimensional anchor*, *haste*; **6th** *invisibility* (self only), *locate*, *slow*
Angled Entry ❖ (conjuration, occult, teleportation) As hound of Tindalos, but it casts a 7th-level *dimension door*.

B6. GARDEN SEVERE 16

This enormous natural cavern is nearly a hundred feet long and sixty feet wide. It is overgrown with a profusion of fungi and strange ferns that grow to an immense size despite the lack of natural light. The floor of the chamber is unpleasantly spongy and gives off a putrid smell. A small stone shed stands at the south end of the cavern, nearly overgrown with vegetation.

The cultists discovered this enormous cavern while constructing the lower dungeon and use it to grow fungi, herbs, and insects the hermeticists use in their experiments. Otherwise, the cultists leave the area alone—they don't need to eat and therefore don't require sustenance themselves.

Creatures: The Leng envoys asked for this room for their mastiffs, and Foras was glad to provide it to the otherworldly visitors. The mastiffs eagerly attack any intruders, fighting to the death.

MASTIFFS OF TINDALOS (4) CREATURE 15

See page 416
Initiative Perception +29

B7. OVERGROWN SHED

This small stone shed was already part of this cavern when the cultists constructed the Candlemere dungeons millennia ago. Even then, it was already impossibly old, its stone riddled with the vegetation that grew up around it and its stone corners crumbled and rounded with age. The stone door leading into the shed sits slightly off its rusted pivot pin and requires a DC 36 Athletics check to Force Open.

Hazard: The interior of the shed is dark and featureless. It is also totally devoid of any plant life that grows with such profusion outside of it—a side effect of the fact that the shed's interior is infused with destructive emotional energy, for this location in the spiral has become a sort of supernatural sump for the excess of awfulness shed over the past thousands of years by the trapped, ageless cultists.

PARANOIA WELL HAZARD 19

MAGICAL TRAP

Stealth DC 47 (legendary)
Description Sudden invasive emotions of fear, paranoia, and anger well up in the mind, causing companions to take on sinister casts to their no-longer familiar features.
Disable Intimidate DC 47 (legendary) to shout down the


MASTIFF OF TINDALOS

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emotional energies and exert mental dominance over them, or Thievery DC 44 (master) to cause the trap's energies to discharge harmlessly

Reveal the Enemy ↻ (curse, fear, emotion, enchantment, mental, occult) **Trigger** A Small or larger creature ends its turn inside of area **B7**; **Effect** The trap releases its built-up emotional energy in a silent blast of power. All creatures in area **B7** or within 20 feet of the shed's exterior walls must attempt a DC 41 Will save (creatures within the shed take a –2 circumstance penalty to this save).

Critical Success The creature is unaffected.

Success For 1 hour, the creature treats no other creatures as allies and can't take concentrate actions that don't have the rage trait.

Failure As success, but the effect is permanent.

Critical Failure As failure, but the creature must attack any creature it detects, preferring to attack former friends or allies when possible.

Treasure: Even a cursory examination of the shed's interior reveals a small pile of rags and scraps, as if a destitute person left their tattered clothes in the corner before vanishing. Among these mysterious rags is a *dread blindfold*.

B8. LECTURE ROOM SEVERE 16

This L-shaped room has the curved hallway arcing through its center. A raised platform stands at each end of the room, and a few heavy stone stools are clustered around the platform to the east. A door stands in the west wall.

This is the primary meeting place for the Thresholders, and it's where Foras gathers them together to make pronouncements, issue changes in the devotion rituals, or publicly punish wrongdoers.

Creatures: The current occupants are a Leng envoy and two disciples named Brulen and Ferandir. The disciples have been tasked with finding out more from the Leng envoy about how to open wide the cosmic gate to let Yog-Sothoth through. The disciples worry that because the envoy is just so much smarter and more devout than they are, their relative ignorance will lead to punishment. Brulen and Ferandir each keep trying to show that they understand more of what the envoy is saying than the other, when in fact neither has any idea. They find the whole interview particularly frustrating, and the envoy, who enjoys tormenting the disciples with their ignorance, has no intention of letting the interview end anytime soon.

If this group becomes aware of intruders, the envoy simply sits back and opines in Aklo, "Now you can show me what you know." Happy to be doing something they're good at, the disciples rush into combat. The envoy hangs back, supporting the disciples with its spells if it seems like it won't put itself in any danger by doing so.

The envoy ceases hostilities if the disciples are defeated, offering to answer any questions the PCs have. Instead of providing detailed answers, however, it provides only basic facts that it assumes the PCs already know, such as the tenets of the cult and the powers that different types of cultists can bring to bear. The envoy freely admits that aiding the cultists in bringing Yog-Sothoth through the mystical gate to rend this world suits its own purposes, although the envoys themselves aren't particularly devoted to Yog-Sothoth. The envoy might let slip some information that fills in gaps in the PCs' knowledge, such as that Foras is the leader of the cult, that he works at the center of the spiral, or even that a rite called the *Helix Theorem* can turn Yog-Sothoth's attention away from Candlemere. During the course of the interrogation, the envoy gives up its strangely flawless Leng rubies, surrendering them as spoils of war or even hinting that they hold magical power. If the envoy can convince the PCs to demand the rubies instead of merely accepting them, all the better. The envoy then tries to use *mind probe* on a PC with one of the rubies and learn more about them. Ultimately, the envoy plans to betray the PCs, but if it can do so when they've let their guard down, that works just as well. Once it springs this trap, the envoy fights until destroyed.

LENG ENVOY CREATURE 18

See page 416

Initiative Perception +31

THRESHOLDER DISCIPLES (2) CREATURE 14

See page 409

Initiative Perception +26

B9. STORAGE ROOM

This room contains supplies the cultists either haven't gotten around to fixing or only use for special occasions. They include stone chairs, broken alchemical equipment, moldy leather, and dull weapons. A single skeleton is hidden behind some of the furniture here; this cultist irritated the others so badly that, in defiance of Foras's orders, they killed him and stashed his body here.

B10. MORTIFICATION ROOM

Racks around this room contain scourges, wide-bladed knives, and sickles. All are crusted with blood, which pools on the floor beneath them. A door leads west, and a curving hall cuts through this room from east to south.

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The cultists engage in ritual mortification of the flesh as they travel through this room in their devotional journey. This isn't a requirement of Yog-Sothoth but a requirement of Foras himself: the sadistic cult leader likes to think of his cultists regularly flaying themselves out of dedication to his twisted leadership alone. To encourage compliance with a step that the cultists all know isn't doctrinally required, Foras placed a magical alarm in this room. Whenever any creature enters this room and hasn't inflicted at least 1 Hit Point of damage on itself with a melee weapon (whether one of the weapons here or a weapon brought into this room) within 1 minute, chimes ring in areas **B11** and **B14**. These chimes also ring if a creature leaves the room without injury before 1 minute has elapsed, preventing anyone from simply hurrying through this room without performing the requisite self-mortification.

If the chimes ring, the cultists in area **B11** realize that someone hasn't performed the appropriate ritual step and they eagerly pile out of the room to capture the shirker. Once they realize the alarm was due to an intruder rather than to someone failing to fulfill the ritual obligation, they attack. Foras hears the chime in area **B14**, but he has faith that his cultists will catch the wrongdoer on his behalf, so he doesn't respond personally.

Success on a DC 36 Perception check is enough to notice the subtle magical energies infusing this room that comprise the alarm, and any spell that pinpoints magical auras reveals the alarm automatically. Once it's revealed, it can be Disabled with a DC 35 Thievery (legendary) check or by casting *dispel magic* (9th level, counteract DC 36).

Treasure: The daggers, scourges, and sickles in this room don't have any particular value, with the exception of a high-grade orichalcum sickle engraved with prayers to Yog-Sothoth.

B11. LOWER BUNK ROOM SEVERE 16

Sleeping niches are carved into the walls of this room at varying levels. A thin mist fills this room.

This bunk room is similar to area **A16**, but this room has niches carved into the walls rather than slabs protruding from them. The same type of worn leather pallet lies in each niche.

Creatures: A stern hermeticist named Surebna and four disciples are currently resting here, although they are quick to leap into action upon any sign of trouble. This room is too small for all these combatants to effectively fight at once, so the disciples work to push foes into area **B10** where they have more room to move around. The four disciples fight to the death, but Surebna has a bit more self-preservation: he retreats to area **B12** if reduced to fewer than 40 Hit Points, hoping to rouse the guardians there against intruders.

THRESHOLDER HERMETICIST CREATURE 16

See page 407
Initiative Perception +29

THRESHOLDER DISCIPLES (4) CREATURE 14

See page 409
Initiative Perception +26

B12. BLACK SAND CAVERN SEVERE 16

The door leading into this room from area **B2** is covered with a large drift of rubble; opening it from that side requires a successful DC 36 Athletics check to Force it Open.

This natural cavern is heaped with drifts of rubble and gravel. A track through the rubble connects a curved hallway entering the room from the north to another curved hallway entering from the east.

This natural cavern was here when Foras and the Thresholders made the spiral, and they used the chamber as a place to dump a lot of the loose stone from building the spiral itself, filling in much of what was once a larger pit to the south.

Creatures: A trio of alien entities–quelaunts—has dwelt in this cavern since long before the Thresholders arrived. The quelaunts initially attacked the Thresholders, but they broke off hostilities as they recognized certain familiar qualities in the cult's leader. Since then, the three quelaunts have remained here feeding on the ambient emotions of the place. They find the frustrations, hopes, and disappointments of creatures who do not age to be quite delicious, but they won't skip the opportunity to feed on more traditional emotions the PCs may bring with them. The quelaunts fight to the death.

ELITE QUELAUNTS (3) CREATURE 16

Pathfinder Bestiary 6, 273
Initiative Perception +31

B13. ACOLYTE ALCOVES SEVERE 16

This room is brightly lit, and its light is evident from down the curved hall leading to it.

Two large, rounded alcoves stand next to each other at the south end of this room. Both blaze with light emanating from several unnerving pinpoints that shift and move

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around. Just visible in the glare from the alcoves is a door leading east. The curving hall cuts through the northwest corner of this chamber.

This chamber provides a vision of the stars closest to Yog-Sothoth's gate. By carefully interpreting the psychic emanations from the Outer God, the cultists believe that they have managed to reconstruct the stellar location of the cosmic gate barring it from the Material Plane. Here, the cultists must meditate upon the lights to find esoteric patterns that might aid in opening the gate further. Staring directly into the light is painful after a long period of time for those who still have eyes, but the cultists feel no such pain now that they've moved on to the benefits of unseen sight.

Creatures: Two mystics named Tolas and Noliskur are currently here. They each have a lightweight brass tablet and a stylus to record observations they make as they work backward through the *Helix Theorem*, calculating how to reverse the theorem to strengthen, rather than weaken, Yog-Sothoth's gaze into Candlemere.

If the mystics have reason to expect anyone intruding on their mediations, they prepare to chastise whomever arrives. If they identify the PCs as intruders from the surface, the mystics do their best to dispatch them as quickly as possible.

THRESHOLDER MYSTICS (2) CREATURE 17

See page 408

Initiative Perception +31

Treasure: The brass tablets the mystics carry provide a great deal of specific detail about the *Helix Theorem*. Although it's clear from their notes that the cultists were trying to discover a way to reverse the theorem, it's useful for the PCs to see the detailed ritual notes about unshackling Yog-Sothoth's attention from Candlemere. By reviewing the mystics' tablets, the PCs can learn all the necessary steps for performing the *Helix Theorem* ritual (page 413).

B14. RITUAL CHAMBER SEVERE 17

The large chamber has two parts. The narrower room to the east is square and has a few tables and workbenches around it. The spherical room to the west is studded with pinprick lights like distant stars. Chalk lines connect many of these stars together in constellations that defy ordinary geometry. Dividing the two halves of this room is an archway etched with eldritch symbols that glow with a cold light and emit a low moan, like wind blowing past the threshold of a partially opened door.

This two-part chamber is where the cult leader Foras has worked so tirelessly to bring Yog-Sothoth into the Material Plane to lay waste to it. Foras believes that, in doing so, he alone will be the chosen and only survivor that the terrible Yog-Sothoth will spare. The workbenches all contain various occult devices, small models, and slate boards containing astrological calculations. The chalk marks in the spherical area at the heart of the spiral are also his, but they are creations of his own wicked mind and don't follow any usual astronomical logic. It's impossible to tell from these materials how close Foras is to success, but the cold wind blowing from the rune indicates that Yog-Sothoth's presence is indeed near.

Creatures: Foras is here, accompanied by four disciples who take measurements, transcribe notes, and otherwise assist Foras in his abstruse labor.

When confronted with intruders, Foras's first action is to cast *time stop*, then he moves into an advantageous tactical position behind his disciples to cast *scintillating pattern*, *unfathomable song*, or other useful spells to impede the PCs. When time starts again, he Sustains these Spells or casts others to keep the PCs off balance. He doesn't mind catching his disciples in the area of his spells if it means hindering the PCs as well. As he fights, Foras shrieks about how his efforts to call Yog-Sothoth cannot be stopped and that the cosmic gate will soon open wide. Foras and his disciples fight to the death; if he's reduced to fewer than 20 hit points and no disciples yet live, Foras destroys his *staff of power* to unleash a blast of energy.

FORAS CREATURE 19

See page 595

Initiative Perception +33

THRESHOLDER DISCIPLES (4) CREATURE 14

See page 409

Initiative Perception +26

Treasure: One of the items on the worktable is a very realistic miniature gate with symbols like those found in this room. No larger than a human hand, the gate has a stone door that swings open and closed. This icon is worth 10 gp for its craftsmanship, but the PCs are likely to find it particularly useful if they've learned about the *Helix Theorem*. The other materials on the worktable are mostly valueless tinkerings, despite the many long years that went into their creation. However, a vial containing a major cognitive mutagen lies amid the jumble.

CONCLUDING THE CHAPTER

After the PCs have defeated Foras and the cultists, their plan to open the gate to attract Yog-Sothoth no longer

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threatens the region. Any Leng envoys who still live decide to retreat to Leng for the time being, although they're certain to spend their time in that distant plane advancing plots that spell ill for Golarion. If the PCs retain any of their strange rubies, they might become the focus of these plots.

The chambers below Candlemere remain, and the passage of time swiftly expunges any lingering influence the cult may have once had in the region. Any of the undead Pharasmins who were bound to the upper halls of the dungeon finally collapse to dust, their souls moving on for judgment. If in your campaign, one of the PCs or a significant NPC is a worshipper of Pharasma, you could use this development as an opportunity for the party to perform an absolution for these ancient worshipers of Pharasma—a *consecrate* ritual or the like will certainly suffice for this. To the Lady of Graves herself, the passage of time is largely irrelevant, and while these doomed Pharasmins abandoned their lives, souls, and faith in order to stand against the cult, the amount of time their souls remained in stasis in their undead shells did not concern her—judgment comes to all in time. But this doesn't mean she won't appreciate the PCs' actions in defeating Foras and his cult

As such, even if the PCs don't perform absolution rites for the graveknights, the Lady of Graves makes sure to reward the PCs for their acts. She grants a moderate boon to every character as soon as the cult is defeated, granting them greater mastery over the energies of life and death. To the characters, this boon manifests as a potent dream the next time they sleep, wherein they see themselves standing before Pharasma's throne not as souls but as living creatures. With a mercurial smile, Pharasma traces the spiral of her symbol on the PCs' brow with her fingertip, and when that character wakes they gain the full benefits of her divine intercession.

Pharasma's moderate boon causes a character's Strikes to deal 1 positive damage to undead. Any of the character's spells that deal positive damage to undead gain a +1 status bonus to damage per spell level, and spells that heal the living gain a +1 status bonus to the Hit Points restored per level. In addition, these PCs will find that as they age, they remain fit and hale and healthy—old age will hold no decline for them. These particular benefits are unlikely to be realized in most Kingmaker campaigns, of course, but mentioning this to the PCs when they finish the Adventure Path can be an additional emotional reward for a job well done. Of course, when the heroes' time comes, they still pass on to the River of Souls—Pharasma's boon does not offer immortality, only a slight reprieve of the aches and pains along the way.

On the other hand, if the PCs didn't complete the *Helix Theorem*, they might face further dangers from the ominous spiral beneath the Stolen Lands, and in time, another cult may arrive to take advantage of the site's eldritch nature. The eyes of Yog-Sothoth are many, and cultists of the Lurker at the Threshold continually strive to open the gate for their dread god. If the PCs aren't quite high enough level to withstand the dangers that they'll face as Kingmaker's endgame begins in the next chapter, consider having them face additional perils as Yog-Sothoth's influence spreads throughout their kingdom, be it in the form of additional dangerous Kingdom events or in the shape of new adventures of your own design.



QUELAUNT

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CHAPTER 10

SOUND OF A THOUSAND SCREAMS

BY RICHARD PETT

PART 1: A MONTH OF DESTRUCTION 424
The PCs should be 17th level when this month of destruction begins.

PART 2: A THOUSAND BREATHS 442
The PCs should be 18th level before they enter Thousandbreaths.

PART 3: HOUSE AT THE EDGE OF TIME 456
The PCs should be 19th level before they enter the House at the Edge of Time.

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PART 1:

A MONTH OF DESTRUCTION

It has been said that to look into the future and to see one's fate is the surest way to meet it. Such worries have bothered Nyrissa, who has long feared that heroes would come to her home and defeat her with a sword forged from her own fractured spirit. Though she has hoped this vision was but a nightmare, it was not until the Age of Lost Omens brought an end to the tyranny of prophecy that she began to hope that her future was not writ in stone.

Yet she is taking no chances. In order to fully deny this vision, she hopes to reclaim *Briar*, mend her own shattered spirit, and remove from existence the very weapon so long ago foretold to herald her death. Yet in taking these steps, she may have empowered the very heroes that could be her undoing.

THE CALM BEFORE

The timing of when this chapter begins is left to you to decide. If the PCs' kingdom hasn't yet grown to span all four regions of the Stolen Lands, you'll want to run a few more years of kingdom growth until their kingdom covers a wide enough area that when Nyrissa starts her assault, the PCs will be compelled to oppose her. Give them time to explore Candlemere, finish up lingering wilderness encounters, and pursue a few loose ends.

Nyrissa's intrusion into the Stolen Lands can be thought of as a levee breaking. At first, the appalling weight of the First World strains at this levee like the weight of a mighty river straining to flood the adjacent kingdom. Early bloom events occur at

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a trickle as the First World seeps slowly into the region. These trickles quickly become full-fledged breaches as the blooms pour forth, and as these breaches grow, the danger grows as well, eventually culminating in the arrival of a deadly predator from the First World—the jabberwock.

You can use the following two quests to get the PCs started on preparing for Nyrissa's attack on the Stolen Lands. The Houten Legacy in particular should be presented to the PCs, since obtaining a copy of *Zuddiger's Picnic* before they enter Thousandbreaths can help to foreshadow Part 2 of this chapter.

KINGDOM IN THE BACKGROUND

When this chapter begins, the PCs' kingdom has grown to encompass the majority of the Stolen Lands. Pitax has been welcomed into the nation, and the people of the kingdom are finally able to relax after the trauma of war recedes. Of course, a new threat is about to strike, but since the kingdom building part of the campaign has more or less concluded, you can simply run this chapter as-is without having to catch the players up on their kingdom's growth.

THE HOUTEN LEGACY

30 XP

Belinda Houten wants to leave a legacy; a resplendent theater dedicated to her family name. She possesses a book that a fortune-teller told her the leaders of the Stolen Lands would someday need to fulfill their destiny, but she won't part with it until she has her buildings.

Source: Aristocrat Belinda Houten, who can live in any settlement with a Noble Villa.

Completion: Build a Theater and four Monuments in Belinda's honor.

Reward: Belinda is as good as her word and presents the PCs with a mint-condition copy of *Zuddiger's Picnic* worth 5,000 gp. This book's contents are presented as handouts on pages 624–627; the book's last page presents a map of Thousandbreaths (share the map on page 444 with the PCs at this time).

A HEROIC CHALLENGE

30 XP

Hailing from Pitax and long having a reputation as the city's boldest and most successful dragonslayer, Aurex Thewsen is also an abrasive braggart. He recognizes the PCs as heroes but dares them to prove their mettle as dragonslayers and cement their legitimacy as true rulers of the Stolen Lands. Aurex himself has slain several noteworthy dragons in the River Kingdoms, but the legendary black dragon Ilthuliak eluded him. Defeating her would suffice, if the PCs were clever enough to find her and brave enough to confront her.

Source: Aurex Thewsen, Pitax's greatest dragonslayer!

Completion: Slay Ilthuliak and bring back her head.

Reward: The PCs become famed dragonslayers, their names known throughout the land. The kingdom's maximum Fame or Infamy (as appropriate) increases by 1, and Ilthuliak's remains can be used to build a Monument in a settlement without needing to expend any resources. Aurex agrees to build a Tavern in Pitax and work there as a bartender for one year, telling every patron the story of that the PCs are the greatest dragonslayers in the Stolen Lands.



BELINDA HOUTEN

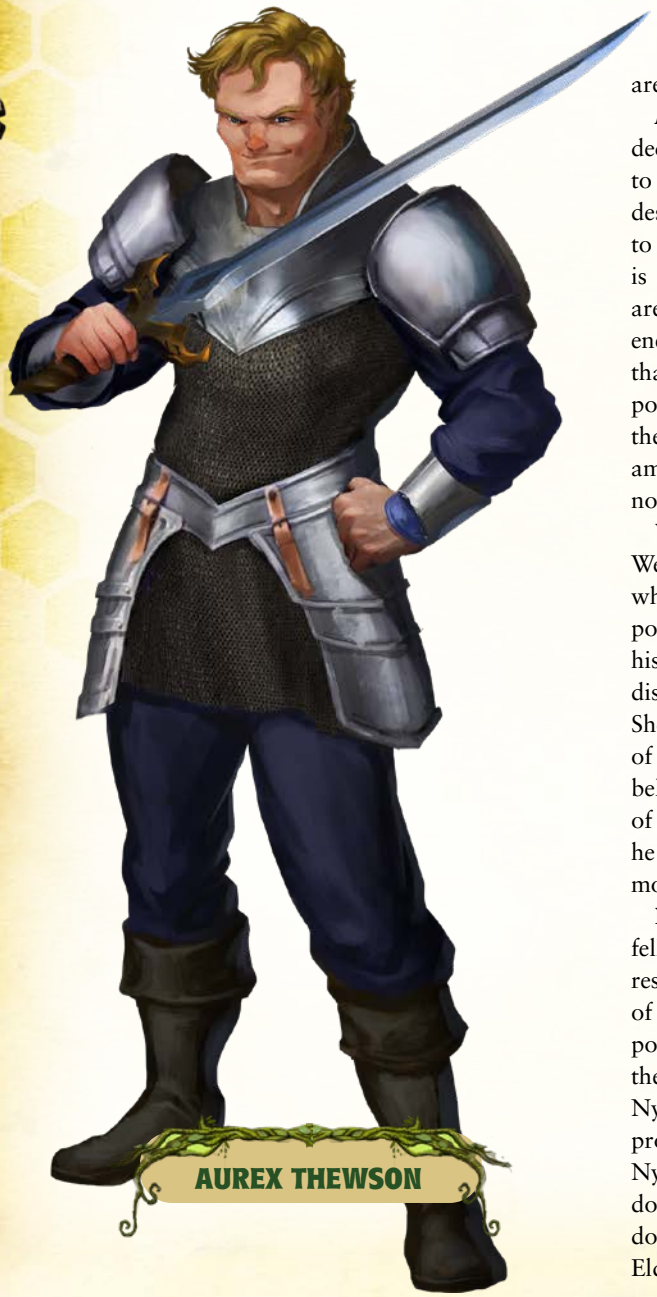
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AWAKENING *BRIAR*

If the PCs haven't recovered *Briar*, you should give them a chance to do so by letting them further explore Irovetti's palace, perhaps at the advice of an NPC ally if the PCs don't seem eager to continue exploring the location. When the PCs recover the sword, it's a *+3 greater striking cold iron bastard sword*—but as this chapter progresses, *Briar* becomes much more powerful, not only becoming a potent weapon against its source, Nyrissa, but also serving a critical role against the Lantern King himself in Chapter 11.

The process of awakening *Briar* and its accumulating powers are detailed on page 585.



AUREX THEWSON

EVINDRA'S WARNING

The following assumes the PCs have earned Evindra's thanks and aid, but you can provide this information via any other supernatural NPC with whom the PCs may have forged a strong relationship.

Evindra warns the PCs as this chapter begins that powerful forces from the First World are likely to be drawn to the Stolen Lands soon, for she'd been charged with keeping *Briar* hidden by a mysterious agent of the Eldest named Weren, who told her it was important to keep *Briar* from the agents of the nymph queen Nyrissa. She blames herself for allowing the weapon to fall into Irovetti's hands, and even though this didn't result in the sword's return to Nyrissa, the close call shames and distresses Evindra for some time. Evindra responds as follows to topics that the PCs are likely to ask about.

***Briar*:** Evindra began her watch over *Briar* seven decades ago. Weren told her the sword was valuable to an "upstart nymph" named Nyrissa—that Nyrissa desired the blade, and that the Eldest did not want her to have it. Evindra can explain to the PCs what *Briar* is currently capable of, and that more of its powers are likely to awaken the more it's exposed to the raw energies of the First World or is used to slay denizens of that realm. While Evindra doesn't know all of *Briar*'s potential powers, she does know that, fully awakened, the sword is both intelligent and a *vorpal sword*, among other things. Once capable of speech, Evindra notes, *Briar* itself may be able to tell them more.

Weren: Evindra doesn't know much more about Weren. She doesn't believe that's his full name and, while he appeared to be an attractive fey man with pointed ears, orange eyes, and long fingers, the way his form shimmered a bit leads her to believe he had disguised his true form when he delivered *Briar* to her. She says that he was very persuasive in convincing her of how important it was to keep the sword hidden. She believed him when he said he served the direct interests of the Eldest, but the more the PCs suggest that maybe he tricked her or even used magic to compel her, the more suspicious she grows about "Weren."

Nyrissa: Evindra relates the legend of how Nyrissa fell in love with one of the Eldest and then how her resulting rise in power led her to proclaim herself one of the rulers of the First World. The other Eldest reacted poorly, first sending the jabberwock against her and then trying to rip her domain out from under her, but Nyrissa defeated the jabberwock and used a thousand promises of fey fealty to ward her domain. But when Nyrissa's lover was exiled, she was punished. Evindra doesn't know the details of that punishment, but she does know that Nyrissa still holds a grudge against the Eldest and suspects *Briar* has something to do with it.

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Evindra knows that Nyrissa's domain is called Thousandbreaths, and that it lies close to the Material Plane in the similarly named Thousand Voices, or Forest of Breath. She knows too that Nyrissa has long had an interest in the Stolen Lands, and that many of the region's fey know of her and fear her; there are even rumors that the nymph queen walks the Stolen Lands now and then, visiting cruelties on those who annoy her and strange rewards upon those who please her. These rumors make Evindra suspect that there may be some physical connection between the Stolen Lands and the First World—and logic would dictate that a likely place for such a connection to exist would be the depths of the forest of Thousand Voices.

THE BLOOMS BEGIN

In previous chapters, the PCs could afford to take months or even years off during the course of play. If there are still parts of the Stolen Lands the PCs wish to explore, consider delaying this chapter until that itch for exploration is scratched, because once Nyrissa's blooms begin to manifest, they come fast and furious. This is by design—the assault on the kingdom is meant to be swift, so the PCs should not have a lot of time to rebuild resources and recover between blooms.

The events in Part 1 take place over the course of a single month, with only a few days passing between each new manifestation of a bloom. Since a Kingdom turn lasts a month, this means that no kingdom management or development can occur during Part 1 once the blooms begin.

Assuming the PCs defeat all of the blooms and survive this month of destruction with their kingdom intact, the adventure and campaign can immediately return to a more laconic pace if you desire. After the month of destruction, if the PCs have not yet fully explored Thousandbreaths or defeated Nyrissa, they'll be rewarded for enduring that month by being able to tackle Parts Two and Three of this adventure at a pace of their own choosing—although if they take too long, you should feel free to have Nyrissa start a second or even a third round of blooms.

All of the events detailed in this part start with a date listed as "Day 1," "Day 14," "Day 27," and so on. It's convenient if you set Day 1 on the first day of the month, but it's not required. If you start the month on a day other than the first, though, you should delay the next Kingdom turn, having it play out at the end of this part.

When a PC encounters a bloom, success on a DC 36 Nature or DC 34 First World Lore check to Recall Knowledge confirms that the incident is caused by a planar breach between the Material Plane and the First World, although the breach is not large or stable enough to allow creatures to cross between the planes. Learning the same information about a bloom the PCs have not personally visited is possible, but the DC is increased by 10.

BLOOM EFFECTS ON THE KINGDOM

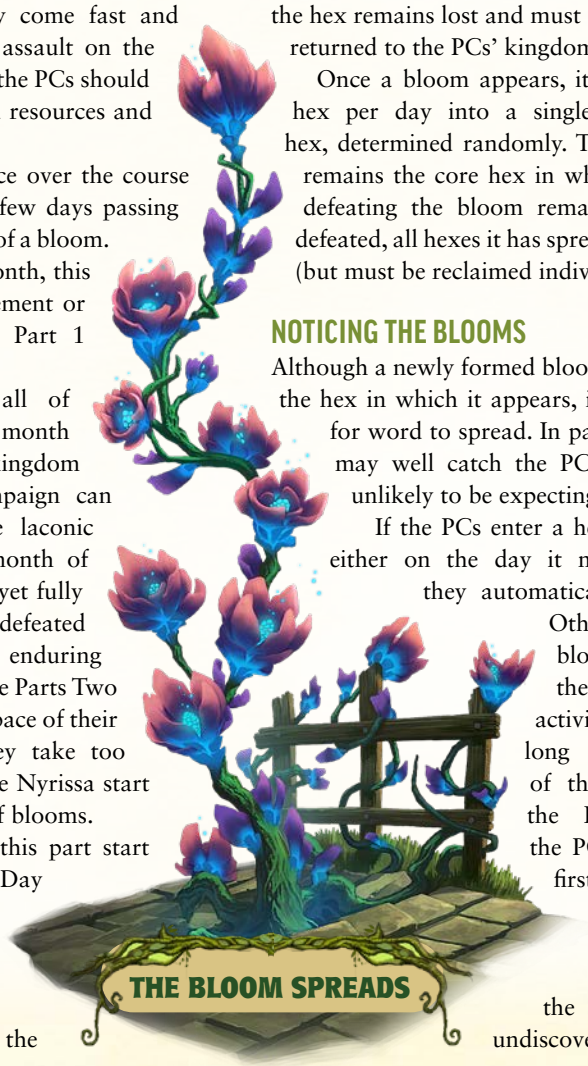
When a bloom manifests, it does so in a single hex somewhere in the Stolen Lands. Most blooms are assigned a type of hex that it can appear in—the exact hex in which the bloom appears is left to you to determine, although the hex containing the PCs' capital should never be chosen. Once a bloom manifests, that hex is lost from the PCs' kingdom (see page 534 for the repercussions of losing a hex). If a bloom is defeated, the hex remains lost and must be reclaimed before it is returned to the PCs' kingdom.

Once a bloom appears, it spreads at a rate of 1 hex per day into a single adjacent, unbloomed hex, determined randomly. The original hex always remains the core hex in which the mechanism for defeating the bloom remains. When a bloom is defeated, all hexes it has spread into revert to normal (but must be reclaimed individually).

NOTICING THE BLOOMS

Although a newly formed bloom is obvious to those in the hex in which it appears, it sometimes takes time for word to spread. In particular, the first bloom may well catch the PCs off guard as they're unlikely to be expecting such an event.

If the PCs enter a hex containing a bloom, either on the day it manifests or thereafter, they automatically notice the bloom. Otherwise, each time a bloom manifests, use the secret Notice Bloom activity to determine how long it takes before news of the new bloom reaches the PCs' attention. Once the PCs have learned of the first bloom, they can use the Bloom Watch downtime activity to actively search the Stolen Lands for undiscovered blooms.



THE BLOOM SPREADS

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NOTICE BLOOM ↷

SECRET

Trigger A bloom manifests in the Stolen Lands.

When a bloom manifests, its effects are not subtle. Nonetheless, it can take some time for witnesses to report the bloom to the PCs. When a bloom begins, roll a secret kingdom skill check to determine how long it takes before the PCs learn about it.

If the bloom manifests in an unclaimed hex, roll a DC 35 Exploration check.

If the bloom manifests in a claimed hex, roll a DC 30 Defense check; if the hex contains a settlement, the result is automatically improved by one degree of success.

If the bloom manifests in the kingdom's capital, or in a hex that's currently occupied by a PC, the check is automatically a critical success.

Critical Success The PCs automatically learn about the bloom the same day it manifests.

Success The PCs automatically learn about the bloom 1d4 days after it manifests.

Failure The PCs automatically learn about the bloom 2d4 days after it manifests.

Critical Failure The PCs won't automatically learn about the bloom; they must discover it via the Bloom Watch activity or by entering the bloom's hex.

BLOOM WATCH

CONCENTRATION DOWNTIME

You spend the day working with agents in your nation examining field reports, speaking with scouts, listening to rumors, interviewing allies, or researching with divination magic to try to pinpoint the locations of undiscovered blooms. Attempt a DC 40 Defense or Survival check, a DC 36 Intrigue (expert) or Perception (expert) check, or a DC 32 Magic (master) or Nature (master) check.

Critical Success Choose a hex on the map of the Stolen Lands. You discover the two closest undiscovered blooms to that hex. If there are no undiscovered blooms currently active, your research notes a growing magical energy in the hex where the next bloom will manifest. This doesn't indicate when that bloom will occur, but it does allow the PCs to prepare to handle that bloom when it occurs (for example, if a PC is present in that hex when the bloom manifests, they automatically know it's happening).

Success Choose a hex on the map of the Stolen Lands. You discover the two closest undiscovered blooms to that hex. If there are no undiscovered blooms currently active, you gain a +2 circumstance bonus on the next Notice Bloom reaction.

Failure If there are undiscovered blooms in claimed hexes, you discover the closest one to your location.

Critical Failure You fail to determine the location of any undiscovered blooms.

DEFEATING BLOOMS

As blooms manifest, the PCs can defeat them. The method of defeating each bloom is different. Once a bloom is defeated, the PCs can harvest special trophies that allow them to enter and navigate Thousandbreaths with increasing ease; they'll need at least three different types of bloom trophy before they can even open the portal to Thousandbreaths at the start of Chapter Two.

When the PCs defeat a bloom, the strange energies and First World power are released in a dramatic way. The energy suffusing the area rises up from the surrounding terrain in a vortex of green light and a high-pitched keening not unlike the sound of a mortally wounded rabbit or deer. This energy is eerie and disturbing, but ultimately harmless, and it disperses quickly. The majority of the energy returns to Thousandbreaths, though a number of objects at each bloom site are infused with a small bit of power turning them into bloom trophies—items that are magically linked to a specific area of Thousandbreaths. Each bloom encounter lists the type of object that becomes its bloom trophy along with its linked area. A dead creature that becomes a bloom trophy does not decay, cannot be transformed into an undead, and won't be eaten by scavengers (such as maggots) for 100 days.

Bloom trophies radiate strong conjuration and transmutation magic. A successful DC 35 check to Identify Magic allows a PC to note that the item has become infused with the bloom's energies and now holds within it a magical link between the object and the First World. A character carrying a bloom trophy receives a +1 status bonus on attack rolls, weapon damage rolls, skill checks, saving throws, and ability checks while in the trophy's linked area in Thousandbreaths.

BLOOM GROWTH

While the exact nature of each bloom varies, all of them—save for the Whirling Lake (below) and Nights of Dread (page 432)—cause vegetation in their hexes to grow rampant and uncontrolled. These hexes are treated as difficult terrain as a result, and the DC of Survival checks attempted in them is increased by 5.

DAY 1: THE WHIRLING LAKE SEVERE 17

The first bloom is not a bloom of vegetation but a bloom of churning water. Unlike land-based blooms, which manifest as sudden tangles of overgrowth, this bloom manifests as a whirlpool of black water in one of the Stolen Lands' lakes.

Location: This bloom can appear in any lake in the Stolen Lands. Its effects can spread only through water—it cannot spread into hexes that don't contain water connected to the source bloom via a lake or river.

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Bloom: The whirlpool is 500 feet across at the surface and reaches all the way down to the bottom of the lake where it leaves a 50-foot-diameter area of the lake bed exposed to the air. Any creature that enters the whirlpool must attempt a DC 38 Reflex save; on a failure, their turn immediately ends, they take 8d6 bludgeoning damage (and accidentally ingest some of the water on a critical failure—see below), and they're swept up by the vortex. While a creature is swept up, they rotate around the vortex and are essentially Grabbed by the current. A creature can attempt a DC 38 Athletics check to Escape by swimming free of the current. Each time a creature ends its turn in the vortex, it must attempt a new DC 38 Reflex save to avoid damage and being swept up.

Eerie, silent black swans congregate in the waters surrounding the whirlpool; as they're drawn into the vortex, they fly up into the air and settle down back in the water some distance away only to slowly drift back into the whirlpool. The swans are ill-tempered but otherwise normal. Attempts to communicate with them via *speak with animals* or similar magic reveals that they fear the whirlpool because it's loud and scary; they don't have memories of their life in the similar lake in Thousandbreaths (area **B**). The swans are immune to the disease brought by the churning waters.

Anyone who drinks the water in this hex or any hex that the bloom has spread to is exposed to a 14th-level strain of blinding sickness (see the elder elemental tsunami below).

Creatures: A group of four extremely powerful elemental tsunamis swim and froth in the region surrounding the vortex. The elementals can move through the vortex with ease, ignoring its effects just as they ignore the swans and any animals of that size or smaller. They quickly move to attack larger creatures that approach, using Stealth for initiative as they split off from the whirlpool in their own vortex shapes and assume their natural forms: immense swanlike shapes of dark water.

If all four elementals are slain or banished from the Material Plane, the central vortex immediately collapses in on itself as the bloom vanishes. The resulting geyser of water calms quickly, and all the black swans die and bob to the surface.

ELDER ELEMENTAL TSUNAMIS (4) CREATURE 14

N HUGE AQUATIC ELEMENTAL WATER

Variant elemental tsunami (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 153)

Perception +25; darkvision

Language Aquan

Skills Athletics +28, Stealth +28

Str +8, **Dex** +8, **Con** +8, **Int** +0, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +0

Water-Bound As elemental tsunami.

AC 36; **Fort** +26, **Ref** +28, **Will** +23

HP 260; **Immunities** bleed, disease paralyzed, poison, sleep; **Resistances** fire 10

Vortex (aura, water) 50 feet. As elemental tsunami.

Speed 35 feet, swim 100 feet

Melee ❖ wave +30 (reach 20 feet), **Damage** 3d12+16 bludgeoning plus Push or Pull 10 feet and blinding sickness

Blinding Sickness (disease) A creature that takes damage from an elder elemental tsunami's wave Strike or Surge is exposed to blinding sickness. **Saving Throw** DC 34 Fortitude; **Stage 1** carrier with no ill effects; **Stage 2** enfeebled 1 (1 day); **Stage 3** enfeebled 2 (1 day); **Stage 4** enfeebled 2 and permanently blinded (1 day); **Stage 5** enfeebled 4 (1 day); **Stage 6** unconscious (1 day); **Stage 7** death

Drench ❖ (abjuration, primal, water) As elemental tsunami.

Surge ❖❖ As elemental tsunami, but 6d12+8 bludgeoning damage (DC 34 basic Fortitude save). A creature that takes damage is exposed to blinding sickness.

Bloom Trophies: Black swan carcasses, linked to the Lake of Midnight Swans (area **B**).

DAY 3: FEY WARNING

Once the blooms begin, it is not only the PCs and the ordinary citizens of their kingdom that start to feel the deadly sting of Nyrissa's wrath. The Stolen Lands have a vast population of fey, and many of them sense the disruption of the veil between the First World and the Material Plane when the first bloom begins. By this point in the campaign, the PCs have likely shown themselves to be reliable friends of fey who are in trouble, so these individuals may appeal to the PCs to help them just as their own citizens would. This may come in the form of fey they've known for a long time like Melianse and Tiressia asking what they make of troublesome signs in the natural world, or it may come from a fey they have not previously met who has strange tales of dangers unseen that foreshadows troubles to come, like Limm Ticklewing, who can seek out the PCs for aid.

THE PIXIE'S SISTERS

RARE 30 XP

Limm Ticklewing is worried for her six sisters, as a few weeks ago they were all captured by a "nasty wizard made of worms!" He and a "scary witch" put Limm's sisters into a magical cage and gave it to a "big mean troll" before Limm was able to escape and hide. As she escaped, Limm stole a bag of shiny gems and stashed them in a safe place; if the PCs can rescue her sisters, she'll give them one gem for each rescue.

Source: Limm Ticklewing, worried pixie.

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LIMM TICKLEWING

Completion: Rescue Limm's sisters from the Misbegotten Troll (page 435) and return them to her at a place you mutually agree upon.

Reward: For each sister returned, Limm rewards the PCs with an emerald worth 2,000 gp.

DAY 8: THE SHRIEKING CHILDREN SEVERE 17

The sudden growth in this bloom consists of a foul tangle of enormous mushrooms, molds, and thick fibrous roots and vines that quickly start to choke out existing plant life. Along with this fungal bloom come swarms of bloodthirsty mandragoras.

Location: A forested hex in Zones 2–6 that does not contain a settlement.

Bloom: Thousands of four-inch-high mandragoras infest this bloom. Each of these misshapen plants looks vaguely humanoid, with tiny eyes, leaves for hair, and sharp wooden teeth. When the PCs notice the bloom, it's likely due to reports of these creatures biting the ankles of livestock or children, chasing pets, or climbing up onto sleeping citizens to drink blood from exposed necks or arms.

Creatures: The mandragora swarms sleep at night, but during the day anyone who enters the bloom can't help but notice the countless tiny cries and whispers that emanate throughout the area. While there are tens of thousands of mandragoras in this bloom, the PCs need only defeat two swarms before the entire flood of tiny mandragoras shrieks and dies. Each mandragora swarm begins battle with a Piercing Shriek. It then swarms over as many foes as it can, chewing, draining blood, and leaving confused victims in its wake. The mandragora swarms fight until destroyed.

MANDRAGORA SWARMS (2) CREATURE 18

RARE CE LARGE PLANT SWARM

Variant mandragora (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 170)

Perception +30; blood scent, low-light vision

Languages Abyssal, Common

Skills Acrobatics +32, Athletics +29, Stealth +34 (+38 in vegetation)

Str +5, **Dex** +8, **Con** +6, **Int** –1, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +0

Blood Scent As mandragora.

AC 42; **Fort** +30, **Ref** +34, **Will** +28

HP 230, fast healing 15; **Immunities** precision, swarm mind; **Weaknesses** area damage 15, fire 15, splash damage 15; **Resistances** bludgeoning 15, electricity 15, piercing 15, slashing 7

Vulnerability to Supernatural Darkness As mandragora.

Speed 30 feet, burrow 10 feet, climb 30 feet

Swarming Bites ❖ Each enemy in the swarm's space takes 7d8 piercing damage (DC 40 basic Reflex save) and is exposed to mandragora swarm venom. A successful save negates the poison exposure.

Blood Drain ❖ **Trigger** An enemy takes damage from the mandragora swarm's Swarming Bites action; **Effect** The mandragora swarm drains blood from the creature, dealing 9d6 damage. If the creature is a demon, fey, or sorcerer, the mandragora gains temporary Hit Points equal to the damage dealt. A creature that has its blood drained by a mandragora is drained 2 until it receives healing of any kind or amount.

Mandragora Swarm Venom (poison) **Saving Throw** DC 40 Fortitude; **Maximum Duration** 6 rounds; **Stage 1** 4d6 poison damage and stupefied 1 (1 round); **Stage 2** 4d6 poison damage, confused, and stupefied 1 (1 round); **Stage 3** 6d6 poison damage, confused, and stupefied 1 (1 round)

Piercing Shriek ❖ (auditory, evocation, mental, primal) As mandragora, but DC 40 Will save.

Bloom Trophies: Dead mandragoras, linked to the Fruiting Orchard (area **E**).

DAY 9: THE HORNED HUNTERS SEVERE 17

Nyrissa knows that *Briar* can slay her, and as this chapter of *Kingmaker* progresses, she becomes aware of rumors that the PCs have discovered the sword. This element, seemingly fitting so perfectly into the ancient visions she received of her own death, increasingly distresses her, and on day 9 of the month of destruction, she sends a group known as the Horned Hunt—the protectors and wardens of the realm of Thousandbreaths—into the Material Plane to find the PCs and secure the sword.

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Creatures: The Horned Hunt consists of a trio of jotund trolls led by a deadly satyr ranger known as the Horned Hunter. They first appear in the Stolen Lands deep in Thousand Voices at the Castle of Knives (encounter site **TV1**) and immediately seek out the PCs, leaving devastation in their passing.

The Horned Hunter knows quite a bit about the PCs; assuming the PCs have displayed a tendency to protect their people, the Horned Hunter knows that the best way to lure the PCs into a conflict is to begin wreaking havoc to draw them out. If the PCs seem not to care about their people, the Horned Hunt either travels to the next bloom site to ambush the PCs when they come to defeat it, or they attempt to infiltrate the PCs' homes when each of them is alone to try to take them down one at a time. How you use the Horned Hunt is up to you, but the PCs should first learn of their location and actions on this day.

When combat begins, the Horned Hunter Plays the Pipes after positioning himself to affect as many foes as possible. He then attacks with his bow, targeting one enemy at a time. Although his natural inclination is to fire upon humans before any other target, if it's obvious who's carrying *Briar*, he and his trolls focus their attacks on that character.

If the character carrying *Briar* is defeated, the Horned Hunter claims the sword as soon as he can, then uses *tree stride* as soon as possible to make his way back to the Castle of Knives to deliver *Briar* to Nyrissa. See Part 3 for details of what happens if Nyrissa gains control of *Briar* in this way.

THE HORNED HUNTER CREATURE 18

UNIQUE | CN | MEDIUM | FEY

Variant male satyr (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 284)

Perception +35; low-light vision

Languages Common, Jotun, Sylvan

Skills Acrobatics +35, Athletics +35, First World Lore +32, Nature +33, Stealth +35, Survival +33

Str +8, **Dex** +6, **Con** +6, **Int** +4, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +8

Items *+2 greater striking grievous thundering darkwood composite shortbow* (20 arrows), hunting horn, wineskin

Fey Conduit Before she sent him into the Material Plane, Nyrissa used the power of her home within the Fable (see area **M7c** on page 476) to forge a link with the Horned Hunter. During his time on the Material Plane, she can observe the world as if seeing through his eyes and listening through his ears. She cannot bolster the Horned Hunter via this link, and uses it primarily to spy on the PCs and observe their tactics in preparation for what she hopes never occurs—their invasion of Thousandbreaths. If the Horned Hunter claims *Briar*, the sword causes this link to Nyrissa to end immediately.

Sylvan Wine (enchantment, mental, primal) As satyr, but a +3 item bonus to Will saves for 1 hour.

AC 42; **Fort** +32, **Ref** +30, **Will** +30; juggernaut

HP 350, **Weaknesses** cold iron 15

Juggernaut When the Horned Hunter rolls a success on a Fortitude save, he gets a critical success instead.

Speed 35 feet

Melee ❖ horns +34 (agile, deadly d8, versatile P), **Damage** 3d12+16 bludgeoning plus Improved Knockdown

Ranged ❖ *composite shortbow* +35 (deadly d10, range increment 60 feet, reload 0), **Damage** 3d6+16 piercing plus 1d6 sonic

Primal Innate Spells DC 37; **8th** *suggestion*, *tree stride*; **4th** *charm*, *fear*, *sleep*; **Cantrips (9th)** *dancing lights*, *ghost sound*, *inspire competence*, *inspire courage*, *triple time*

Bloom Step The Horned Hunter ignores the effects of non-magical difficult terrain and that caused by a bloom.

Bow Specialist The Horned Hunter gains the critical specialization effect for any bow he wields.

Hunt Prey ❖ (concentrate) The Horned Hunter designates a single creature he can see or hear as his prey. He gains



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a +2 circumstance bonus to Perception checks when he Seeks his prey and a +2 circumstance bonus to Survival when he Tracks his prey, and he ignores the penalty for making ranged attacks within his second range increment against his prey. He can have only one creature designated as prey at a time. If he uses Hunt Prey against a creature when he already has a creature designated, the prior creature loses the designation and the new prey gains the designation. Otherwise, a designation lasts until his next daily preparations.

Fleet Performer ↷ **Trigger** The Horned Hunter Plays the Pipes; **Effect** The Horned Hunter Steps or Strides.

Masterful Hunter The Horned Hunter's multiple attack penalty for attacks against his hunted prey is –3 (–2 with an agile weapon) on his second attack in a turn, and –6 (–4 with an agile weapon) on his third or subsequent attacks. The first time he hits his hunted prey in a round, he deals 2d8 additional precision damage.



THE HORNED HUNTER

Play the Pipes ❖❖❖ (auditory, primal) As satyr (the Horned Hunter uses his hunting horn to use this ability).

JOTUND TROLLS (3) CREATURE 15

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 267

Initiative Perception +29

DAY 12: NIGHTS OF DREAD

The most insidious of the blooms does not manifest physically, but in the dreams of those it touches upon.

Location: This bloom manifests in the PCs' capital. Unlike other blooms, this one does not physically change the region it influences or spread into neighboring hexes.

Bloom: This bloom's effects manifest in the dead of night, at which point many who sleep in the hex suffer nightmares of being chased through the woods, being savaged by wild animals, and of being pursued by an immense dark bird whose wings blot out the stars.

In some cases, these dreams have a greater effect than merely unsettling sleep—for some, they become living nightmares that end with a real magical effect. On the first night, only one creature experiences a living nightmare. Each night it persists, it causes one additional creature to experience a living nightmare (so, two victims on the second day, three on the third, four on the fourth, and so on until the bloom is destroyed). The bloom targets PCs randomly if they sleep in the bloom hex, or random citizens if not (who are slain by the living nightmare). At your discretion, key NPCs or companions can be targeted, in which case you should have a player control the NPC and play out the bloom's effects rather than having the NPC automatically slain.

When a character is targeted by a living nightmare, they endure the phantasmagoric visions and then awaken with a scream as the nightmare culminates in a powerful spell effect. You can use the table on page 441 to randomly determine what sort of nightmare and spell effect the character is targeted by or use these suggestions to create similar effects of your own design (note that all of these spells are ones that target a single creature). All of these spells are heightened to 9th level, have spell attack +30, and are DC 36.

Regardless of the nature of the living nightmare a given victim endures, the living nightmares share a feature in common with the standard nightmares suffered by everyone in the bloom: the presence of an immense black bird

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that watches over the nightmare from the dark night skies above. This monstrous shape never takes direct action in the nightmares, but the dreamers always wake with the conviction that the bird caused the nightmare.

This shape is a creature called the Nightmare Rook, an immense avian that dwells in Thousandbreaths and directs the horrific nightmares from that realm (page 449). A PC who experiences a nightmare can attempt a DC 36 Nature check or DC 30 First World Lore check to Recall Knowledge to identify the Nightmare Rook as a mythological creature said to dwell in the First World; on a critical success, the character also remembers that a creature very similar to the Nightmare Rook was a character in a strange picture book called *Zuddiger's Picnic* published long ago in Pitax. In the tales and the picture book, the protagonist encounters the Nightmare Rook and is carried away, only managing to escape by luck. The PCs can secure a copy of *Zuddiger's Picnic* by completing the Houten Legacy quest (page 425). See Part 2 of this chapter or pages 624–627 for more about the book.

To defeat this bloom, a PC must ignore the nightmare itself and confront the watching, ever-present Nightmare Rook. Whenever you describe a PC's nightmare, but before they wake to endure the resulting spell effect, describe the nature of their nightmare and the fact that a giant black bird looms watching nearby. Give the PC a chance to react to this element of the nightmare. If they confront the rook in any way, the PC can take the following activity. If they don't confront the bird, describe the nightmare ending in a horrific fashion, much to the watching bird's delight, and then have the PC awaken to endure the living nightmare's spell effect.

CONFRONT THE NIGHTMARE ROOK

CONCENTRATION

If the PC confronts the Nightmare Rook, ask them to describe how they wish to do so, then select an appropriate skill check to match. For example, a direct physical attack would be modeled by Intimidation, for example, while a sneaky attack or ambush would use Deception. An attempt to appeal to the bird for mercy would use Diplomacy, using music or song to distract it uses Performance, and simply sneaking away from the bird's view would use Stealth. Any spellcasting solution would use the corresponding Arcana, Nature, Occultism, or Religion skill. Regardless of the skill, the PC attempts a DC 40 check.

Critical Success The confrontation catches the Nightmare Rook off guard and frightens it away; the PC awakens with the bloom trophy clutched in a hand, does not suffer the living nightmare's spell effect, and the bloom is defeated.

Success The Nightmare Rook is startled by the PC's brazen confrontation. It retreats but does not leave. The PC awakens knowing that the nightmares will continue but that the bird's resolve has been shaken. The PC does not suffer the spell effect of the living nightmare. Reduce the DC to Confront the Nightmare Rook by 2 for all further attempts by any PC.

Failure The Nightmare Rook caws in delight at the PC's failure. The nightmare catches up to the PC, who wakens with a scream and endures the living nightmare's spell effect.

Critical Failure As failure, but the living nightmare is particularly harrowing. The PC takes a –4 circumstance penalty to their saving throw against the spell effect or the spell gains a +4 circumstance bonus on its attack roll, as appropriate.

Bloom Trophies: Black raven feathers pulled from a nightmare, linked to the Nightmare Spire (area **D**).

Story Award: Award the PCs 40 XP upon defeating this bloom.

DAY 16. THE FROZEN BLOOM SEVERE 17

An incursion of giants from a frozen graveyard ruled by a deadly, four-armed warlord in Thousandbreaths accompanies a bloom of ice and snow.

Location: A mountain hex.

Bloom: Snow begins falling over this hex regardless of weather conditions in the skies above. The vegetation that blooms and grows here consists of tangles of alpine shrubbery, twisted pine trees, and sheets of thick, slippery lichen. The temperature in this area drops to extreme cold (*Pathfinder Core Rulebook* 517), and bodies of water in the region freeze over.

An intimidating link to Thousandbreaths rises in this bloom—a towering, 30-foot-tall gravestone made of ice and inscribed with a thousand names manifests at the center of the hex. The language of these names appears to be in each reader's native tongue, and anyone who thinks to look for their own names or the names of friends or family invariably finds them on the gravestone with eerie speed. To destroy this bloom, the massive ice gravestone must itself be destroyed. The gravestone is 10 feet wide and as hard as stone (Hardness 14, HP 150 [75 BT]). It can be knocked over with a DC 45 Athletics check made as a three-action Manipulate activity; the DC decreases to 35 if the gravestone is below its Broken Threshold. Knocking the gravestone over in this way destroys it. The gravestone is immune to acid damage but has weakness 15 to fire and sonic damage. Cold damage repairs the gravestone for a number of Hit Points equal to the damage the cold would normally have inflicted; the freezing temperatures in the

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bloom repair damage done to the gravestone at the rate of 15 Hit Points per turn. If destroyed, the icy gravestone topples and shatters into countless razor-sharp shards, each the size of a dagger; these serve as the bloom trophies.

Creatures: When this bloom opens, a four-armed frost giant named Kargstaad sends six hearty frost giants from Thousandbreaths through to hold the region; Kargstaad himself remains in the Frozen Boneyard (area **C**). These giants are natives of the First World, with skin blue as ice and eyes that glow with white light; they heal wounds at an astounding rate and are stronger and more dangerous than normal frost giants. Once the giants arrive in the Stolen Lands, the urge to chase and crush the delightfully fragile creatures they find proves too much to resist, and they move out of the bloom to explore the Stolen Lands. The wandering band of giants can be encountered anywhere you wish, but most likely the PCs will first hear of them after they attack a small outlying village or start crushing merchant caravans. The giants meet no real opposition as they travel and raid, so they quickly come to see this world's denizens as trivial challenges. They fearlessly fight to the death until one of them falls, forcing the others to finally appreciate that there is real danger on the Material Plane. At this point, the giants adopt a more defensive pose and make a fighting retreat back toward the bloom.

KARGSTAAD'S GIANTS (6) CREATURE 15

RARE CE LARGE COLD GIANT HUMANOID

Variant frost giants (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 171)

Perception +27; low-light vision

Languages Common, Jotun

Skills Athletics +31, Crafting +25, Intimidation +27, Stealth +25 (+29 in snow)

Str +8, **Dex** +4, **Con** +6, **Int** +0, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +4

Items *+2 resilient white dragonhide breastplate*, *+2 striking greataxe*, sack with 5 rocks

AC 37; **Fort** +29, **Ref** +25, **Will** +25

HP 270, fast healing 15; **Immunities** cold; **Weaknesses** fire 15

Catch Rock ↷

Speed 30 feet; ice stride

Melee ❖ *greataxe* +29 (magical, reach 10 feet, sweep), **Damage** 2d12+22 slashing

Melee ❖ fist +29 (agile, reach 10 feet), **Damage** 2d8+22 bludgeoning

Ranged ❖ rock +29 (brutal, range increment 120 feet), **Damage** 3d10+13 bludgeoning

Chill Breath ❖ (cold, evocation, primal) As frost giant, but 7d6 cold damage and a DC 36 Reflex save and Escape DC.

Ice Stride As frost giant.

Throw Rock ❖

Wide Swing ❖ As frost giant.

Bloom Trophies: Icy gravestone shards, linked to the Frozen Boneyard (area **C**).

DAY 17: THE KNURLY BRIARS SEVERE 17

This bloom links the Stolen Lands to the not-quite-abandoned Knurly House.

Location: A hill or plains hex.

Bloom: This bloom manifests in an immense mound of creeping briars and brambles. These hideous, fast-growing brambles extend from the unkempt yard of the Knurly House, the home of a bitter and wretched hag known as the Knurly Witch.

The brambles and briars grow to a height of 15 feet, creating heavy undergrowth (*Pathfinder Core Rulebook* 514), making it difficult for creatures to move around. Their sharp thorns are mobile and angry, functioning as hazardous terrain. A creature that takes two Move actions in a round in this hex takes 2d6 piercing damage from the thorns at the end of their turn, or 4d6 if they take three Move actions.

Creatures: While the Knurly Witch herself doesn't emerge from her house in the Stolen Lands, her presence can be felt throughout these briars in the form of half-heard cackles, insensible mutterings, and brief glimpses of a strange but towering humanoid shape moving just out of sight through the brambles. These shapes are the "gardeners" of the Knurly Briars, immense and hideously malformed athachs.

As the Knurly Witch's gardeners, these athachs carry sickles and large bags of strangely pulsating seeds. They move through the brambles, pruning back dead plants and harvesting the eerie red seeds that periodically grow on the vines, only to replant the seeds in the ground. It is this act of pruning and seeding that keeps this bloom growing; if all of the athachs are slain, the bloom reacts by causing the brambles and vines to shriek and whip about in a frenzy. All creatures in the brambles at this time take 8d6 slashing damage from the thorns (DC 35 basic Reflex save). One round after the death of the last athach, a foul-smelling pod of plant matter erupts from the ground at each location where an athach was slain. A pod takes 1 minute to grow to full size, after which a healthy new athach emerges from it and attempts to return to work. In order to defeat the bloom, all three pods (Hardness 10; HP 50 [BT 25]) must be destroyed before they can spawn. When this happens, the brambles shriek again, but instead of slashing at those caught within them, they melt away into green light and smoke, leaving behind scattered lengths of knotted vines and brambles.

BLOOMBORN ATHACHS (3) CREATURE 17

RARE CE HUGE GIANT HUMANOID

Variant athach (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 27)

Perception +31; darkvision

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Languages Aklo, Jotun, Sylvan
Skills Athletics +32, Intimidation +32
Str +9, **Dex** +5, **Con** +6, **Int** +2, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +5

AC 40; **Fort** +33, **Ref** +30, **Will** +31
HP 375; **Weaknesses** cold iron 15
Attack of Opportunity ↻ At the start of each of its turns, the bloomborn athach gains an extra reaction that it can use only to make an Attack of Opportunity with its claw.
Catch Rock ↻

Speed 40 feet
Melee ❖ fist +34 (reach 10 feet), **Damage** 3d10+17 bludgeoning
Melee ❖ jaws +34, **Damage** 3d12+17 piercing plus athach venom
Melee ❖ claw +34 (agile), **Damage** 3d8+17 slashing
Ranged ❖ rock +34 (brutal, range increment 120 feet), **Damage** 3d4+17 bludgeoning
Athach Venom (poison) As athach, but DC 38 Fort save.
Swift Claw ↻ As athach.
Throw Rock ❖

Bloom Trophies: Two-foot-long vines of tangled, knotted brambles, linked to the Knurly House (area **H**).

DAY 22. RISE OF THE MIRE WORMS — SEVERE 17

A worm-infested bloom of algae, moss, and drooping swamp trees erupts into a remote part of the Hooktongue Slough.

Location: A hex in Hooktongue Slough.

Bloom: The source of this bloom is a hideous swampland in Thousandbreaths known as the Mire, a trackless, soggy realm ruled by a squirming, noxious wizard called the Wriggling Man. This dangerous foe does not enter the Material Plane with this bloom, but he does send four squirming worms cast off from his writhing body into the Stolen Lands.

Creatures: Upon arriving in the swamp, the four worms grow to immense size and slither their way through the surrounding swampland, consuming any living creature they come across. These four worms travel together at a rate that matches the bloom's expansion—they can always be encountered in the latest hex to be claimed by this bloom.

These so-called mire worms are hideous segmented creatures with hook-shaped jaws that extend from their rubbery maws when they bite. Each worm is also armed with a jagged, poisonous stinger-tipped tongue. They function identically to azure worms, save that their sting attack is at the tip of their tongue instead the tip of their tail.

Killing the mire worms defeats the bloom and causes their bodies to shrink back down to their original size—the length of a human finger. Although dead, these worms continue to twitch in a most unsettling manner. The worms resemble no known species, but a DC 40 Occultism check to Recall Knowledge suggests the worm may be one from a worm that walks.

MIRE WORMS (4) — CREATURE 16

Elite azure worm (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 6, 57)
Initiative Perception +24

Bloom Trophies: Twitching worms, linked to the Mire (area **G**).



KARGSTAAD'S GIANT

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DAY 25: THE MISBEGOTTEN TROLL SEVERE 17

This bloom manifests on the site of a large structure or ruin, filling the region with tangles of vegetation.

Location: A hex with a refuge, ruin, or structure that the PCs have already explored but haven't developed into a settlement or (if possible) haven't even claimed as part of their kingdom. It's best if this is a site that is supported by a map from a previous chapter, so that when the PCs come to this bloom, they'll be on familiar ground yet facing a new enemy. Excellent choices include the hexes containing the Forgotten Keep (page 150), the Troll Lair (page 202), Vordakai's Tomb (page 277), Whiterose Abbey (page 358), or the boggard village of M'botuu (page 156).

Bloom: While the majority of the blooms do not bring the more powerful denizens from their connected glades in Thousandbreaths, this one does. Sprouting in an immense cage-like fortress called the Baleful Lantern, this bloom of tangled trees and spiny berry bushes manifests in the Stolen Lands along with the Lantern's denizen, a hateful and cruel monster known only as the Misbegotten Troll.

Creature: The vegetation that radiates out from this bloom grows swiftly, but the core of the bloom is linked to the Misbegotten Troll, who hitched a ride into this world to find fresh new victims to torment and eat.

It's likely that the PCs will first hear about this bloom after rumors of raids on outlying areas of the kingdom appear. After countless years preying upon fey, the troll is looking for some variety to add to his dinner table—a human or half-orc in particular. Whether the PCs come to confront the troll after he's first started to raid or after he's abducted one or more possible meals is left to you to decide. If you want to inject a particular sense of urgency, the troll's victim could well be an NPC important to the PCs.

As the PCs approach the Misbegotten Troll's new home, it should be obvious that someone has moved into the ruin. Smoke from unseen cook fires billows from the entrance or vents, and numerous territorial markers made of fresh bones, slaughtered locals, or other grisly trophies decorate the approach to the site.

The methods that the Misbegotten Troll uses to defend his new lair from attackers depend greatly on the layout and nature of his new home, and thus no details are given here apart from the villain's stat block and notes on his basic combat tactics. If his chosen lair is too small to easily admit him physically, he sets up his new home at the location's entrance. The troll is a loner, but he does keep four particularly large and ill-tempered, black-pelted smilodons handy to serve as guardian beasts. The Misbegotten Troll deploys two of them as guards near the entrance to his lair; the other two remain at his side at all times for additional protection. The troll also wears a short chain threaded through his belt, from which hang several tiny cold iron cages, each of which contains a tormented sprite—Limm's sisters (see the Pixie's Sisters quest on page 429). The cries and shrieks of these sprites as the troll moves give him an unsettling accompaniment. Since the Misbegotten Troll himself is the living heart of this bloom, his death causes the bloom to collapse.



MISBEGOTTEN TROLL

THE MISBEGOTTEN TROLL CREATURE 18

UNIQUE | CE | LARGE | GIANT | TROLL

Variant troll king (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 315)

Perception +31; darkvision

Languages Aklo, Jotun, Sylvan

Skills Athletics +35, Intimidation +35

Str +9, **Dex** +4, **Con** +8, **Int** +0, **Wis** +3, **Cha** +6

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Items chain of lovelies, *+2 greater striking glaive*, *+2 greater resilient full plate*

AC 40; **Fort** +36, **Ref** +27, **Will** +27, +2 status to saves vs. fear effects

HP 430, regeneration 45 (deactivated by acid or fire); **Weaknesses** fire 20

Attack of Opportunity ↻

Vigorous Shake ↻ As troll king.

Speed 30 feet

Melee ❖ *glaive* +35 (deadly d8, forceful, reach 15 feet), **Damage** 3d8+17 slashing plus 3d8 piercing

Melee ❖ jaws +35 (reach 10 feet), **Damage** 2d12+23 piercing

Melee ❖ claw +35 (agile, reach 10 feet), **Damage** 2d8+23 slashing

Forced Regeneration ❖ (concentrate) As troll king, but regains 25 HP.

Jangle the Chain ❖ (auditory, emotion, enchantment, manipulate, mental, primal) The Misbegotten Troll shakes his chain of caged sprites, causing the supernatural cages to amplify their despair. All creatures other than the Misbegotten Troll or his smilodon pets within 30 feet must attempt a DC 40 Will save. The Misbegotten Troll can't Jangle the Chain again for 1d4 rounds.

Critical Success The creature is unaffected and is temporarily immune to Jangle the Chain for 24 hours.

Success The creature is sickened 1 by despair.

Failure The creature is stunned 1 by sadness, and then sickened 1 by despair once the stun effect ends.

Critical Failure The creature is stunned 3 by sadness, and then sickened 2 by despair once the stun effect ends.

Primordial Roar ❖ (auditory, emotion, fear, mental) As troll king, but DC 40 Will save; this ability doesn't affect his pet black smilodons.

Rend ❖ claw

Unstoppable Charge ❖❖❖ As troll king.

Vicious Ranseur When the Misbegotten Troll attacks with his glaive, it manifests dozens of hooks and spikes along its length and blade. He deals an additional 3d8 piercing damage to any creature he strikes but inflicts 1d8 piercing damage to himself with each glaive Strike.

BLACK SMILODONS (4) CREATURE 14

Variant smilodon (Speartooth; see page 104)

Initiative Perception +25

Treasure: In addition to his glaive and armor, the string of cages carried by the Misbegotten Troll have value. There is one cage per PC, and as long as the four sprites remain trapped, this "chain of lovelies" (as the Misbegotten Troll calls them) is worth 500 gp for its craftsmanship but no one other than the troll himself can jangle the chain to produce any magical effect. While trapped, the sprites cannot take any actions at all. The cages don't have doors, but it requires success at only a DC 15 Athletics check to force a cage open. Doing so releases the sprite trapped within; if all of the sprites are released, the grateful fey swarm around the PCs with cries of thanks before vanishing back to the First World. As they do, each PC gains the Fey Luck reaction below, usable once only. Freeing the sprites also fulfills the Pixie's Sisters quest (page 429).

FEY LUCK ↻

FORTUNE PRIMAL

Trigger You fail or critically fail a saving throw.

Frequency once

The luck granted to you after freeing the sprites from their cruel cages saves you from an undesirable fate. Adjust a failed saving throw to a success, or a critically failed saving throw to a failed saving throw.

Bloom Trophies: Broken cages from the chain of lovelies, linked to the Baleful Lantern (area **I**).

DAY 26. WAR OF THE HIGH FOLLY SEVERE 17

The final bloom of the month of destruction opens near the PCs' capital, unleashing an army of First World monsters upon the kingdom.

Location: A hex adjacent to the PCs' capital.

Bloom: The final bloom emerges dangerously close to home, at the heart of the PCs' kingdom and within sight of their capital. This bloom manifests at dawn with a sudden and explosive growth of twisted trees, thorny vines, and evil-looking fungi. Protruding from the center of it is a ghostly image of an impossibly tall alabaster tower atop a hill that looks too round to be natural; this is a projection of a structure in Thousandbreaths called the High Folly—the lair of the black dragon Ilthuliak. A ghostly image of the black wyrm flying in circles around the tower should give the PCs cause to worry, but at this time Ilthuliak has no way to physically strike at the PCs and does not factor into the battle.

As such, this bloom is automatically noticed—if not by the PCs (if they're not around when this bloom occurs) then by all of their allies back at home. The clamor coming from the tangle of vegetation makes it sound as if a battalion of First World monstrosities hides within, and indeed four armies of murderous beasts, crazed satyrs, giant worms, slavering wyverns, lumbering giants, and flesh-eating plants lurks within, along with a powerful bloom sard.

The armies of First World monsters attack the PCs' capital an hour before sunset, besieging the city with increasing violence—left unopposed, these armies soon destroy the capital and slaughter everyone who dwells within. On sundown each day that the bloom is active,

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the PCs' kingdom must take the Endure Bloom Siege activity below to determine how the capital endures—this is a special Kingdom activity that takes place outside of a Kingdom turn. If the PCs can act quickly and defeat the sard or the First World armies before the first sundown, they have to Endure Bloom Siege only once, but if this bloom is ignored for even a few days, the results can be devastating.

Destroying the bloom requires the PCs to deliver a decisive blow to the monsters, either by defeating the First World armies with their own in a War encounter or by defeating the bloom sard personally in encounter mode. If either the bloom's armies or the sard are defeated, the bloom itself collapses, leaving behind a three-hundred-foot-diameter scar of barren sand.

ENDURE BLOOM SIEGE

DOWNTIME

If the bloom was active after the previous sundown, the kingdom's capital must Endure the Bloom Siege.

If the PCs defeated the bloom since the last Endure Bloom Siege activity (either by slaying the rampaging sard or by defeating the bloom army), the result of this Endure Bloom Siege activity is improved one degree of success—this represents the fact that the invaders had less than a full day to do harm.

You can Endure Bloom Siege with a Defense check or a Magic check. Regardless of the kingdom skill chosen, this is a DC 34 check on the first day. The DC increases by 2 every day thereafter until the bloom is defeated or the capital is completely destroyed.

Critical Success The capital endures the bloom siege with no damage, but the citizens are still worried. Increase Unrest by 1.

Success The city's defenses hold back much of the assault, but damage still occurs. Gain 1 Decay and either destroy one wall or place Rubble into one lot of your choice in the capital's Urban Grid. If you have no empty lots, reduce one structure in the city to Rubble. Increase Unrest by 1.

Failure The city's defenses strain and threaten to collapse! As success, but place Rubble into three lots of the PCs' choice in the capital's Urban Grid. Increase Unrest by 1d4.

Critical Failure The city's defenses are overrun! As failure, but gain 2 Decay, place Rubble into six lots of the PCs' choice in the capital's Urban Grid, and increase Unrest by 1d4+2.

Creatures: The bloom sard's first attack on the region is against an outlying farm, crossroads, or other location of your choice in the hex in which the capital is located. Its first attack occurs at noon on day 26, and it continues to rampage through the region as long as this bloom persists. These attacks panic the populace, and at noon every day after its first attack, until it is defeated or this bloom is finally ended, the kingdom gains 1 Unrest.

If the PCs opt to fight the sard, they track it through the surrounding region automatically. Unless they use magic like teleportation to cut down their travel time, though, it'll take the PCs 1d8 hours to navigate the sard's trail of destruction through the hinterlands to finally catch up to it; succeeding at a DC 30 Survival check reduces this to only 1 hour. Once confronted, the sard focuses its wrath on the PCs, but if it is reduced to fewer than 50 Hit Points it attempts to flee on its turn. If the sard escapes, it returns to the bloom, recovers, and continues its rampage the next day. Persistent PCs might be able to track it down in its lair in the bloom at your discretion, but only if the sard is slain does the bloom end.

If the PCs end the bloom by defeating the army, the bloom sard is stranded on the Material Plane. It becomes a weakened sard (an 18th-level creature) instead and staggers off into the wilds. At your option, the sard (still quite powerful even weakened) can continue to be a danger until the PCs defeat it, but its defeat at this point is not needed to end the bloom.

BLOOM SARD CREATURE 20

Elite sard (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 6, 231)

Initiative Perception +37

Battlefield: All four of the First World armies attack the PCs' capital one hour before sundown on Day 26. The capital's defenders can potentially have the advantage in the battle if there are structures that can be used to fortify armies with ranged attacks. At your option, if the PCs built their capital in a region with natural defenses (such as swamps or rugged mountains), then the First World armies might be penalized by difficult terrain as well.

If the PCs choose not to risk defenders against the army, or if there simply aren't any armies in the city, and the PCs haven't broken the morale of the armies by slaying the bloom sard, then the army surges through the capital and the conflict is an automatic defeat for the PCs. Otherwise, the battle plays out as a normal War encounter—see Appendix 3 for Warfare rules.

If the PCs win the battle, roll to Determine Victory (page 578 in Appendix 3); on a success or better, the enemy is destroyed and the bloom ends. On a failure or worse, the First World forces retreat, but the bloom doesn't end—the army takes 1d3 days to recover and recruit more monsters from the First World and then attacks once again with its recovered and rebuilt armies. In the meantime, the capital must spend those

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days continuing to Endure the Bloom Siege (unless the PCs end the bloom by defeating the sard). At your option, the PCs could confront the First World armies in the bloom itself, but doing so should be a much more dangerous fight, with difficult terrain combining with the dim light caused by the strange gloomy haze in the region—and neither of these battlefield terrain features impacts the First World army. Worse, the terrain in the bloom works against invaders, making all of the PC armies in the bloom Mired 2 when a battle begins.

If the PCs lose the battle, you should Determine Defeat normally (see page 578 in Appendix 3). On a success or better, the First World army retreats back to the bloom but attacks again the next day an hour before sundown. On a failure or worse, the army occupies the capital. From this point on, starting immediately after this failed battle at sunset, each time the kingdom has to Endure the Bloom Siege, they automatically get a critical failure. Once the capital is destroyed, the armies move on to strike at other settlements until the bloom is destroyed.

If the PCs defeat the bloom by slaying the sard, the four First World armies become stranded in the region. They no longer make attacks on the capital, but they move through the kingdom and continue to be a nuisance until they are defeated, or until the PCs defeat Nyrissa at the end of this chapter, in which case these stranded armies disperse completely.

FIRST WORLD ARMY (4) ARMY 16

RARE CE SKIRMISHERS

Scouting +28, darkvision

Description This army is composed of an eclectic mix of fey, beasts, and plants—a supernatural mob of monsters with a wide range of options in battle.

AC 38; **Maneuver** +30; **Morale** +25

HP 6 (RT 3)

Melee weapons and claws +33

Ranged bows and hurled thorns +33 (5 shots)

Battlefield Adaptability ❖ (unique tactic) The First World army has a wide range of creatures in its ranks, and it can shift its tactics to support those with different mobilities. It can take this action to achieve one of the following benefits: ignore ground-based difficult terrain, reduce Mired to 0, become concealed, or gain a +2 circumstance bonus on Maneuver checks to Advance and to Disengage. The effect lasts until the start of the First World Army's next turn.

Primal Magic ❖❖ (primal, unique tactic) **Requirement** The First World army is not engaged; **Effect** The First World army uses its primal magic against another army on the battlefield and must attempt a Morale check against the target's Morale DC. If they succeed, the First World army applies one of the following effects, determined randomly, to the target army.

- **1–2 Entangling Vines** Coils of whipping vines grow out of the ground to entangle the army. The army increases its Mired condition by 1 (2 on a critical hit).
- **3–4 Horrific Visions** The soldiers' minds are assaulted with horrific illusions. The army increases its Shaken condition by 1 (2 on a critical hit).
- **5–6 Primal Storm** A churning storm cloud above the army strikes the soldiers dozens of times with bolts of lightning, inflicting 1 point of damage to the army (2 points of damage on a critical hit). Until the end of the targeted army's next turn, it functions as if in high wind and rain (see Battlefield Terrain Features on page 578).
- **7–8 Sensory Assault** The soldiers become overwhelmed with strange lights or tricked by illusions. Until the end of their next turn, the army takes a –2 circumstance penalty on all attacks and Maneuver checks.
- **9–10 Overwhelming Magic** Roll twice and apply both results, but the First World army suffers a –4 circumstance penalty on its Morale check against the target army's Morale DC.

Supernatural Attacks (primal, unique tactic) Whenever a First World army scores a critical hit on another army, it increases that army's Weary condition by 1 as their attacks cause some soldiers to become poisoned, fall asleep, shrink in size, or suffer other eerie side effects.

Swift Recovery ❖❖ (primal, unique tactic) **Frequency** once per battle; **Effect** The army calls upon its magical connection to the First World to recover. This either restores 2 hit points or reduces the army's Weary condition value by 2.

Tactical Training (unique tactic) The First World Army can use the following tactical actions: counterattack, dirty fighting, feint, and taunt.

Bloom Trophies: Handfuls of sand taken from the scar left by the bloom's passing, linked to the High Folly (area **J**).

DAY 28. BEWARE THE JABBERWOCK EXTREME 17

If the PCs don't force the House at the Edge of Time to manifest on the Material Plane in the forest of Thousand Voices by day 28 of the month of destruction, and Nyrissa has not yet retrieved *Briar*, then the fey queen sends in her deadliest minion: a lesser jabberwock she grew from blood left over from her ancient battle with the true jabberwock so long ago. The procedure by which she created and raised this lesser jabberwock is a closely guarded secret known only to a few denizens of the First World, for the resulting monster, while not as deadly as a true jabberwock, is a devastating foe nevertheless. It has orders to destroy the PCs—Nyrissa figures that their deaths should render her visions of her own demise moot just as surely as her recovering

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Briar. If she has already retrieved *Briar*, she won't send the lesser jabberwock to attack the PCs; in this case, feel free to have the PCs encounter the monster in Thousandbreaths or in the House at the Edge of Time/Castle of Knives as you wish.

On the dawn of this final event, a strange thing happens in the skies above. Although there's not a cloud in the sky, roars of thunder echo across the entire Stolen Lands. The thunder comes in diminishing intervals, initially every 10 minutes, but by noon, the thunder booms like the approaching footsteps of an immense creature. Use this ominous event to let the PCs know that something is coming.

Exactly 1 hour after noon, the loudest peal of thunder yet strikes, and with a flash of unsettling green light above the PCs, the boundaries between this world and the First are sundered, and a true monster steps through—a lesser jabberwock. To do this, Nyrissa must first cast *discern location* on a PC. If she hasn't observed them via the Horned Hunter's Fey Conduit, she'll need a body part or significant item once owned by the PCs. While it's unlikely she has a body part, she might own an item—any particularly powerful or noteworthy magic item or object a PC had an emotional attachment to will work, and if over the course of this campaign a PC sold or lost such an item, you can rule that Nyrissa's agents recovered it. (If you do so, make sure to let the PC discover it in area **M7d** later in this chapter!)

Creature: A lesser jabberwock is, despite its name, a deadly foe. This hideous reptilian beast stands nearly 30 feet high, with a long, scaly neck, a vaguely draconic body, and a long whiplike tail. Its arms and legs are thin but incredibly strong, ending in sharp talons. Immense draconic wings flap on its back, and its ovoid head is a nightmare of bulging eyes, sharp teeth, and long, thin antennae or whiskers.

As the battle begins, if the PCs have the sword *Briar*, it immediately glows with a vibrant green light and wakens to its full capacity, as if it had gained 20 sharpness points. The sword returns to its proper level of awakening once the lesser jabberwock is defeated.

If this battle begins in a settlement, the lesser jabberwock's arrival can potentially damage or destroy a structure—when this battle begins, have one PC attempt a DC 42 Engineering check. On a failure, the structure closest to the targeted PC becomes damaged, while on a critical failure that structure is destroyed and reduced to Rubble.

The lesser jabberwock uses Intimidation to determine its initiative, then races into the midst of the PCs on the first round of combat to Strike with its bite. On the second round, it Burbles to confuse the PCs that surround it. On following rounds, it makes melee Strikes, preferably against the PC wielding *Briar*. If the monster is reduced to fewer than 215 hit points, it takes to the air and circles, firing eyes of flame while it heals back up to at least 320 hit points before landing and entering melee again. If denied this level of mobility, the monster simply focuses its fury on single targets, hoping to take the PCs down one at a time. If the monster defeats *Briar*'s wielder, it claims the weapon and takes to the air. The gate through which Nyrissa sent the creature into the Material Plane is closed, so it must return to the First World via the portal at the Castle of Knives—it flies toward that site with all due haste, eager to return the hated weapon to its mistress. Otherwise, the lesser jabberwock fights to the death.

LESSER JABBERWOCK CREATURE 21

RARE | CE | HUGE | DRAGON | TANE

Variant jabberwock (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 150)

Perception +36; darkvision, scent 120 feet, *true seeing*

Languages Aklo, Common, Draconic, Gnomish, Sylvan

Skills Acrobatics +37, Athletics +41, Intimidation +38, Nature +34, Survival +37

Str +10, **Dex** +6, **Con** +7, **Int** +2, **Wis** +7, **Cha** +6

Planar Acclimation As jabberwock.

AC 47; **Fort** +38, **Ref** +33, **Will** +36

HP 430, regeneration 20 (deactivated by *vorpal* weapons); **Immunities** paralyzed, sleep; **Weaknesses** *vorpal* weapons 20, vorpal fear; **Resistances** fire 20

Frightful Presence (aura, emotion, fear, mental) 100 feet, DC 41

Vorpal Fear As jabberwock.

Claws That Catch ↷ As jabberwock.

Speed 35 feet, fly 60 feet

Melee ❖ jaws +38 (deadly 2d10, magical, reach 15 feet), **Damage** 4d10+18 piercing

Melee ❖ claw +38 (agile, magical, reach 15 feet), **Damage** 4d6+18 slashing plus Improved Grab

Melee ❖ tail +38 (magical, reach 15 feet), **Damage** 4d8+18 bludgeoning plus Improved Knockdown

Melee ❖ wing +36 (agile, magical, reach 15 feet), **Damage** 4d6+18 bludgeoning

Ranged ❖ eyes of flame +38 (fire, magical, range increment 60 feet), **Damage** 8d6 fire plus 2d6 persistent fire

Primal Innate Spells DC 44; **Constant (10th)** *true seeing*

Burble ❖❖ As jabberwock, but DC 44 Will or Reflex save, and a sonic beam for 22d6 sonic damage.

Jaws That Bite As jabberwock.

Whiffling ↷ (aura) As jabberwock, but DC 41 Acrobatics or Athletics.

DAY 30. MONTH'S END

On day 30 of the month of destruction, the event ends in one of two ways.

One or more blooms remain active: Nyrissa can

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LIVING NIGHTMARES

d8	Spell Effect	Living Nightmare Description
1	*baleful polymorph*	You are hunted by predators and wake as a harmless animal.
2	*blindness*	You gaze upon something so horrific that you are blinded.
3	*dominate*	Your allies are possessed. Kill them before they kill you.
4	*feeblemind*	Your thoughts are not your own, as if something else were thinking for you.
5	*flesh to stone*	You are buried alive but remain aware as the years pass and you fossilize.
6	*phantasmal killer*	You are attacked by a frightening monster or your most fearful foe.
7	*polar ray*	You endure an eternal blizzard after the world has frozen.
8	*warp mind*	The world around you keeps changing into different horrifying realities.

attempt to take the Stolen Lands out of the Material Plane and into the Apology. She must attempt a DC 19 flat check to do this if there is only a single active bloom. For each additional bloom that remains active, the DC is reduced by 2. If she's successful, consult Concluding the Chapter on page 477 for the ramifications of this disastrous development. If she fails, all of the blooms collapse, and she must wait 1d6 months before attempting the theft again by causing new blooms. In this event, feel free to re-use some of the blooms presented on the previous pages, or use them as inspiration for designing blooms of your own.

No blooms remain active: The PCs have thwarted Nyrissa's plans for now, but in time she can start the process all over again. She must wait 2d6 months before starting a new month of destruction in order to attempt to take the Stolen Lands again. This should give the PCs plenty of time to begin rebuilding their kingdom, and to take the fight to the nymph's own realm of Thousandbreaths. During this time, the PCs should either encounter minor blooms of strange plant life, or hear rumors of such, so that they know that while the threat posed by the previous month of destruction has passed, another one could well be looming in the near future. A character who studies one of these smaller blooms can attempt a DC 38 Nature or Religion check can confirm that the danger has only been stalled—a critical success at this check gives the character the exact number of months remaining before Nyrissa starts a brand new bloom.



LESSER JABBERWOCK

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PART 2:

A THOUSAND BREATHS

As this chapter begins, the PCs should be aware that their kingdom is under attack by something beyond the mortal realm. The manifestation of the blooms, the incursions of strange monsters, and even the appearance of the strange trophies after a bloom is defeated all point to the First World as the source of the dangers.

THOUSANDBREATHS

There are many events in Part 1 of this adventure that should convince the PCs that some force from the First World has taken an interest in the Stolen Lands—speaking with the nereid Evindra, the pixie Limm Ticklewing, or interrogating captured prisoners from blooms will confirm this. They can also research the topic in libraries they've constructed in their kingdom, or they might even know about it from using skills to Recall Knowledge. Eventually, the PCs should learn that if they wish to confront their enemy, they must travel to a specific part of the First World called Thousandbreaths—but the more they know about this realm beforehand, the better their chances will be.

When the PCs wish to find out more, use the Research rules (*Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide* pages 194–195).

RESEARCHING THOUSANDBREATHS LIBRARY 16

Recalled Knowledge A PC attempts to recall what they have learned over the campaign about the topic–a single PC cannot attempt any of the following Research checks more than once, but each of these attempts takes only a single action to Research; **Maximum RP** 4

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Research Checks DC 33 First World Lore, DC 35 Nature, DC 40 Occultism

Interviews The PC interviews a knowledgeable NPC (such as Evindra or Limm) on the topic (each of these checks takes 2 hours to Research); **Maximum RP** 8

Research Checks DC 33 Diplomacy, DC 37 Intimidate (with a critical failure annoying the NPC enough that they refuse to provide more information)

Library Research The PC spends 8 hours researching the topic in a Library or similar structure (either one they've built in one of their settlements, or one located in an allied city such as Restov); **Maximum RP** 10

Research Checks DC 33 Library Lore, DC 33 First World Lore, DC 35 Nature, DC 37 Occultism, DC 37 Religion, DC 37 Perception

2 Research Points The source of the blooms and fey incursion is certainly from the First World.

4 Research Points The specific source of the blooms within the First World is a realm known as Thousandbreaths, which is ruled by a nymph queen named Nyrissa.

6 Research Points Thousandbreaths earned its name in eons past when Nyrissa earned the pledge of a thousand powerful fey creatures who served her–their "breaths" are what helped Nyrissa stabilize and claim this reach of the First World as her own domain. Visitors are not often welcome to Thousandbreaths, and most uninvited guests never escape the realm. When Thousandbreaths draws near to the Material Plane, its influence infuses a region with whispering sounds and abundant overgrowth.

8 Research Points Thousandbreaths drew near to Golarion 20 years ago, linking to a woodland known then as the Branthlend Forest. The other realm's influence has resulted in this woodland's name changing to Thousand Voices. Thousandbreaths itself has touched upon other worlds in the past–the Thousand Voices forest is but the most recent.

10 Research Points While visitors are rare to Thousandbreaths, one notable instance is said to be the painter Karn Zuddiger, who described his visit to the domain in the guise of a children's picture book called *Zuddiger's Picnic*. The book gained notoriety in part due to Karn's murderous killing spree only a month after the book's publication some 20 years ago. As a result of Karn's violent outburst, most copies of *Zuddiger's Picnic* were destroyed. If the PCs haven't secured their own copy of *Zuddiger's Picnic* by this point, this check also reveals that a local aristocrat named Belinda Houten is said to own a copy of this rare book–see page 425.

12 Research Points Thousandbreaths is a heavily forested realm. Travel through the woodlands without taking advantage of its paths or rivers is exceptionally dangerous. Nyrissa, the ruler of the realm, is also known in some tales as the Queen of Forgotten Time, the Count's Last Mistress, or the Heartless Queen.

14 Research Points There are ten glades in Thousandbreaths–nine lesser glades each ruled by one of Nyrissa's favored minions, and a prime glade in which Nyrissa's home, the House at the Edge of Time, stands. When Thousandbreaths links to the Material Plane, it manifests a worn-down, ruined duplicate of the House at the Edge of Time in that world–a ruin known to explorers of Thousand Voices as the Castle of Knives.

16 Research Points Little is known of how Thousandbreaths affects those who visit it, but what has been deduced includes the fact that it is always twilight in Thousandbreaths, that travel off the path through the woods quickly grows dangerous as the thorny undergrowth resists passage, and that distance and time are strangely inconsistent–those who travel to Thousandbreaths and then return to Golarion find that much less time has passed than they expected.

18 Research Points The nine lesser glades not only provide a route to Nyrissa's home, but also function as the realm's foundation. Each glade is "tethered" to a powerful entity so full of life that its presence acts as an anchor, and without these nine entities, the glades of Thousandbreaths would be uprooted. This would have a calamitous effect on the realm, and while it would weaken Nyrissa's defenses, it alone would not defeat her.

TRAVELING TO THOUSANDBREATHS

When Nyrissa founded Thousandbreaths, it existed fully in the First World, but after she was punished by the Eldest, they shed this domain from that plane. Today, Thousandbreaths exists as its own demiplane, where much of the realities of the First World hold sway, yet it serves also as a prison from which Nyrissa cannot stray for long.

Due to its nature as an obscure demiplane, travel to Thousandbreaths from another plane is difficult. The PCs could use *plane shift* to travel there but only if they've fully researched Thousandbreaths by gaining at least 18 Research Points. Even then, they'll need a special tuning fork to travel to the realm—although a copy of *Zuddiger's Picnic* can function in place of such a focus for spellcasting. *Gate* can create a portal to Thousandbreaths, although as an uncommon 10th-level spell, the PCs might not have access to it.

A fixed portal does exist that links Thousandbreaths and the Material Plane—the main entrance to the ruins known as the Castle of Knives deep in the forest of Thousand Voices. This portal flared open for a few months when Nyrissa's attention first came to the stolen lands about two decades ago (it was at this time that Karn Zuddiger stumbled through the portal while exploring the forest, emerging just before it closed to go on to pen *Zuddiger's Picnic*), but has remained inert since then. It's not until the blooms begin during Part

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THOUSANDBREATHS



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1 of this chapter that the Castle of Knives portal opens back up. As long as the blooms remain active, the portal remains impossible to miss—any who approach the Castle of Knives see it as a vine-shrouded rent in reality. While the PCs won't learn of this portal's activation while researching Thousandbreaths, they can certainly infer its existence, but it's most likely they'll learn about it from one of their fey allies such as Evindra or Limm Ticklewing. Of course, unless the PCs carry three different Bloom trophies with them, they won't be able to pass through this portal at all.

Once the blooms begin, a remarkable transformation takes place in the castle's ruins—the castle appears as a strange structure of sharp towers and confusing architecture of dozens of colors that seem strangely too vibrant for the surroundings. The entire castle is surrounded by a wrought iron fence that contains a single gate flanked by statues of beautiful women. The transformation lasts until the PCs uproot Nyrissa's realm, but the iron gate itself continues to function as a portal to Thousandbreaths as long as that realm continues to exist as a demiplane.

Regardless of the method the PCs use to travel to Thousandbreaths, they always appear in the same place: the Byway (area **A**).

A RESTLESS LAND

Thousandbreaths is a demiplane that lies adjacent to the Material Plane, but many of the realm's features still adhere to those of its source—the First World. As Thousandbreaths is under Nyrissa's direct control, other realities exist in this demiplane as well.

Eternal Twilight: It is always twilight in Thousandbreaths. No matter what time the PCs enter and how long they stay there, the sun never sets (although in fact time is unaffected and passes normally—the time of day is merely fixed in place). This ambient light provides dim light in the realm.

Glades: A number of large clearings exist in Thousandbreaths—these are known as glades, and each contains a unique encounter area detailed below. Each glade is linked to one of the blooms that manifests in the Stolen Lands—a character carrying a bloom trophy from the linked area receives a +1 status bonus on attack rolls, weapon damage rolls, skill checks, saving throws, and ability checks while in that glade.

Sleeping: Visitors who sleep in Thousandbreaths are subjected to living nightmares (see page 441) if the Nightmare Rook (see area **D**) still lives or if the Nights of Dread bloom hasn't been defeated.

Sounds: These are the voices: the thousand voices of Thousandbreaths, the source of the region's name. In truth, there are far more than a mere thousand breaths in Thousandbreaths, as the disembodied voices are from those taken and remade by the queen, cries of helplessness in a pitiless and unending twilight. Beyond the screams there are other sounds: weeping, singing of children's rhymes, shouts of anger, feral cries, and howls—PCs who listen too closely might even hear familiar voices that could well sound like villains or friends who have died or gone missing over the course of the Kingmaker Adventure Path. The sounds of Thousandbreaths cause a –2 circumstance penalty on all Perception checks made to hear things.

The Woods: Moving through the woods without using the paths and rivers is dangerous. The off-path woods are treated as greater difficult terrain and hazardous terrain, and characters take 1d6 piercing damage for each Move action they take when they travel through these thorny, tangled woods.

PATHS AND RIVERS

Travel through Thousandbreaths is easiest via its network of paths and rivers, yet navigating them is nerve-wracking. Eyes blink from the dark of the forest, lights are dim and seem to have trouble illuminating beyond the paths, and even stranger lights dance and twitch in the sky above, almost as if the stars can't decide on their routes through the darkening sky.

Two types of passages exist within the realm of Thousandbreaths—paths and rivers. Travel along a path is possible in both directions, but travel along a river always leads downstream—even if a person attempts to follow a river upstream by flying above it

UNBLOOMED ENCOUNTERS

If the PCs make it to Thousandbreaths before the month of destruction concludes, they'll face more dangerous encounters here, but if they wait too long in hopes of defeating more blooms, they run the risk that Nyrissa might absorb their kingdom. Eight of the nine glade encounters detailed here (areas **B–I**) are presented with the assumption that their associated bloom has manifested and been defeated, and are thus Moderate 18 encounters. If a glade's associated bloom hasn't manifested or hasn't been defeated by the PCs, though, some of the creatures and energies that would have been expended on that bloom remain active in the glade and it becomes a Severe 18 encounter. Notes on what to add to each glade encounter to make it a Severe 18 encounter appear at the end of the encounter in an "Unbloomed" entry.

If all of the creatures in a glade encounter are defeated before the glade's associated bloom manifests during the month of destruction, that bloom does not manifest at all when its day comes.

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PATHWAY PERILS

1d4	Result
1	This is a grassy trail, the edges of which are littered with statues of curious creatures that are at once human and animal. The trees here have an unsettlingly fleshy look about them, with parts of people woven or grafted into them, some of which speak nonsense to the PCs as they pass. At one point during the journey, each character must attempt a DC 38 Will save to avoid becoming confused by these voices for 1d6 rounds (this is an emotion, mental, primal effect).
2	This path is narrow, only 10 feet wide, with thorny branches hanging low over it. It takes 2d4 hours to reach the next glade.
3	The edges of this path grow thick with strange flowers that seem to writhe and move on their own. Each flower has a tangle of tentacle-like vines hanging down from its stem. These plants are dangerous and exude nightmare vapor (*Pathfinder Core Rulebook* 553) into the path once the PCs are halfway down the path to their destination, exposing the entire party to the poisonous effect.
4	This 10-foot-wide path seems to be a barely used animal track, although countless bloated animal carcasses lie strewn amid the undergrowth along both sides of the path. Characters who travel this path are exposed to a virulent form of bubonic plague (*Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide* 118, but this is an 18th-level disease with a DC 38 Fortitude save).

or reached is always the one they would have reached by moving downstream. The rivers always flow away from area **K** toward area **B**.

Any character who tries to fly above the top of the wood's trees discovers an unsettling truth about the reality of this realm—there seems to be no world above the canopy. No matter how high they fly, the tops of the trees extend to what seems to be 200 feet above. Only Nyrissa and the Nightmare Rook (see area **D**) can actually travel above the treetops of Thousandbreaths.

Regardless of the speed or method used to navigate a path or river, it always takes 1d4 hours to reach the next glade. Each time the PCs use a path to travel, roll a DC 11 flat check; on a success, the pathway is perilous in some way—roll on the Pathway Perils table (see above) to determine in what way.

UPROOTING THOUSANDBREATHS

Nyrissa, despite her power, does not actually have within herself the ability to reshape and maintain the entire realm of Thousandbreaths. She can create glades and their contents, but in order for them to maintain their shape, each glade must be tethered to a powerful entity so full of life that its presence acts as an anchor.

By defeating anchors, the PCs weaken the underlying structure of Thousandbreaths and cause it to drift further and further from the First World. Each time they defeat all of the guardians of a glade (with the exception of area **F**), there's a chance that the defeat is enough to cause Thousandbreaths to tumble cataclysmically into the Material Plane.

When the PCs defeat all the guardians of a glade, attempt a DC 20 flat check. On a success, Thousandbreaths is uprooted. On a failure, this DC is reduced by a value depending on the power of the defeated anchor (see the table below), so that the next flat check is against a lower DC. If the PCs defeat all of the anchors, listed below, Thousandbreaths is automatically uprooted. Slaying an anchor's guardian defeats it, as does transporting a guardian out of Thousandbreaths, for once a guardian is absent from this demiplane—even if for only a second—the tether they provide snaps. Given a year, Nyrissa could restore a defeated anchor, but for the context of this campaign, you can assume a defeated anchor remains defeated.

UPROOTING DC REDUCTIONS

Area	Guardian	Reduction
B	4 Storm-Struck Arboreals	–1
C	Kargstaad	–2
D	Nightmare Rook	–2
E	Immense Mandragora	–1
G	The Wriggling Man (area **K17**)	–4
H	The Knurly Witch	–4
I	Destroy the Baleful Lantern	–1
J	Ilthuliak	–4

If Thousandbreaths is uprooted, it manifests fully within the forest of Thousand Voices in the Stolen Lands, its glades appearing as different areas in the forest. When this cataclysmic event occurs, the sound of a thousand screams tears through the air, a horrific noise as the realm expels its thousand breaths at once. The denizens of the glades are traumatized by this event, and all surviving guardians become slowed 1 for the next 24 hours.

All of the otherworldly elements of Thousandbreaths vanish when it uproots, but for the most part the general natures of the encounters in unvisited glades should be relatively unchanged. More importantly, once Thousandbreaths is uprooted, Nyrissa can no longer use the *Apology* to absorb the Stolen Lands, as uprooting Thousandbreaths causes all active blooms in the Stolen Lands to end instantly (although any creatures active in those blooms remain in the area where the bloom was once located).

Only the House at the Edge of Time remains within what was once the demiplane—the plane's borders now encompass only the glade that contains that structure and its surrounding lake. The PCs can still come and go via the

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portal at the Castle of Knives or other methods of planar travel, but now the Byway (area **A**) manifests at the lake's edge near the bridge that leads to the House's isle.

Given time, Nyrissa may be able to rebuild Thousandbreaths through the use of *create demiplane*, but once Thousandbreaths is uprooted, her plan to absorb the Stolen Lands is over. At this point the Stolen Lands are safe from her machinations—yet the PCs themselves most certainly are not, and in this development, the nymph queen begins a new campaign of vengeance against the PCs; see page 459 for more on this development.

Story Award: Should the PCs manage to uproot Thousandbreaths and cast the demiplane into the Material Plane, award them 120 XP.

A. THE BYWAY

All who travel to Thousandbreaths from other planes arrive here, at the Byway. This archway is formed by a pair of beautiful women shaped in iron. Each statue raises one hand toward the other, forming an arch; the other hand holds high a sword that bears a striking resemblance to *Briar*. The first time *Briar* is brought through this gate, it gains a Sharpness Point—as this occurs, both it and the blades of the statues momentarily glow with green light. Nyrissa notices this effect and thus knows when *Briar* enters Thousandbreaths, but she does not react. If the sword is in the hands of her agents, they'll bring it to her soon enough, and if it is in the hands of her enemies, she does not want to confront them and instead hopes that the various perils of Thousandbreaths finish them off.

B. WATCHERS ON THE WHIRLING SHORE MODERATE 18

A broad lake of dark water fills the majority of this forest glen, leaving a fifteen-foot-wide shoreline. Black swans glide along the lake's surface, apparently unimpressed by the immense but strangely silent whirlpool that churns at the lake's center. Along the forest edge, many of the trees seem to be dying or dead.

The swans are simply swans, and while the lake's vortex is powerful (functioning identically to the one detailed on page 428 but only with a diameter of 100 feet), it doesn't threaten those who wade along the shores. The circular lake itself is 200 feet across.

Bloom Trophies: Black swan carcasses, linked to the Whirling Lake bloom (page 428).

Creatures: The true threat here comes from the immense arboreals that guard the lake's shores. Although these lightning-scarred guardians might look to the casual observer like dead trees, they are very much alive and quickly move to attack anyone that passes nearby. There are four of these storm-struck arboreals in all—one stands guard next to each exit from the lake glade.

If a storm-struck arboreal can't reach the PCs, it uses its electricity spells to attack, making sure to catch other arboreals in the area of effect if it can to provide healing. The storm-struck arboreals fight to the death.

STORM-STRUCK ARBOREALS (4) CREATURE 16

RARE NE HUGE PLANT

Variant arboreal regent (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 25)

Perception +28; low-light vision

Languages Aklo, Sylvan

Skills Athletics +33, Nature +26, Stealth +25 (+35 in forests), Survival +30

Str +9, **Dex** +1, **Con** +6, **Int** +0, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +0

AC 37; **Fort** +28, **Ref** +25, **Will** +30

HP 370; **Immunities** electricity;



KARGSTAAD

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Weaknesses axe vulnerability; **Resistances** bludgeoning 15, fire 15, piercing 15

Axe Vulnerability A storm-struck arboreal takes 15 additional damage from axes.

Electric Healing Whenever the storm-struck arboreal would take electricity damage or is targeted with an electricity effect, it gains 15 temporary HP.

Speed 40 feet

Melee ❖ branch +33 (reach 15 feet), **Damage** 3d12+15 bludgeoning

Melee ❖ root +33 (trip), **Damage** 3d10+15 bludgeoning

Primal Innate Spells DC 30; **8th** *chain lightning*; **7th** *lightning bolt* (×3)

Sunder Objects When a storm-struck arboreal damages an item or structure it deals an additional 3d12 damage to that item or structure.

Unbloomed: If the Whirling Lake bloom (page 428) has not been defeated, the four elder elemental tsunamis from it lurk within the waters of this lake—these elementals work with the storm-struck arboreals to defend the glade.

ELDER ELEMENTAL TSUNAMIS (4) CREATURE 14

See page 429

Initiative Perception +25

C. THE FROZEN BONEYARD MODERATE 18

Snow falls steadily in this forest glade, which appears to be an ominously oversized cemetery. Dozens of ten-foot-tall headstones rise from the snow, leaning awkwardly as if the ground below had grown unstable. An old tower leans precariously against the supportive branches of several trees at one end of the glade, while an immense marble vault looms at the other, at the edge of a frozen lake.

The temperature in this glade is extreme cold (*Pathfinder Core Rulebook* 518). Nyrissa rarely comes to this grove anymore; she has little interest in this frigid corner of Thousandbreaths and leaves its care to Kargstaad, a foul-tempered, four-armed frost giant who lives in the vault at the edge of the boneyard's frozen lake. This glade, despite the appearance of a frozen cemetery, is not an actual cemetery—Nyrissa simply found the appearance of a frozen burial ground soothing when she was in her darker moods.

The tower is little more than a spiral stair built into a 200-foot-tall circular stone shell. It is in dreadful repair but is in no danger of collapsing. The stairs end at a dizzying vantage point in the open rooftop that somehow still doesn't allow a view over the treetops.

Bloom Trophies: Icy gravestone shards, linked to the Frozen Bloom (page 433).

Creature: Kargstaad and his giant followers dwell here, eternally provided for by the glade when it comes to hunting for food or water. Collected as trophies ages ago by Nyrissa, these giants know little but their lives in this glade. When this glade's bloom opens, Kargstaad sends his minions through to protect the bloom, but the giants, starved for entertainment, quickly abandon it. Once the bloom closes, Kargstaad knows his giants have failed him, and the arrival of the PCs gives him an opportunity to smooth over this failure if only he can capture them for his mistress.

In combat, Kargstaad rages and charges in to engage his foes in melee. If unable to reach them, he hurls gravestones as rocks. Kargstaad fights to the death.

KARGSTAAD CREATURE 19

UNIQUE | CE | LARGE | COLD | GIANT | HUMANOID

Variant frost giant (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 171)

Perception +33; low-light vision

Languages Aklo, Common, Jotun, Sylvan

Skills Athletics +39, Crafting +33, Intimidation +37, Stealth +33 (+37 in snow)

Str +10, **Dex** +6, **Con** +8, **Int** +4, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +8

Items *+2 greater resilient hide armor*, *+2 striking hatchets (4)*, sack with 5 rocks

AC 43; **Fort** +35, **Ref** +31, **Will** +33; juggernaut

HP 360, fast healing 20; **Immunities** cold; **Weaknesses** fire 20

Attack of Opportunity ↷

Catch Rock ↷

Juggernaut When Kargstaad rolls a success on a Fortitude save, he gets a critical success instead.

Speed 30 feet; ice stride

Melee ❖ *hatchet* +37 (agile, magical, sweep), **Damage** 3d6+18 slashing plus 2d6 cold

Ranged ❖ rock +35 (brutal, range increment 120 feet), **Damage** 2d10+18 bludgeoning

Chill Breath ❖ (cold, evocation, primal) As frost giant, but 9d6 cold damage and a DC 41 Reflex save and Escape DC.

Hatchet Onslaught ❖❖❖ **Requirement** Each of Kargstaad's four hands wields a hatchet. **Effect** Kargstaad Strides up to half his speed, then makes four hatchet Strikes, applying his multiple attack penalty as normal.

Ice Stride As frost giant.

Rage ❖ **Requirements** Kargstaad isn't fatigued or raging. **Effect** Kargstaad gains 25 temporary hit points, deals an extra 12 points of damage with thrown rocks, and deals an extra 6 points of damage with hatchets. He takes a –1 penalty to AC and can't use actions with the concentrate trait (except Seek) unless they also have the rage trait.

Throw Rock ❖

Wide Swing ❖ As frost giant.

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Unbloomed: If the Frozen Bloom (page 433) has not been defeated, four of Kargstaad's giants are encountered at his side. (The remaining two can be encountered elsewhere in Thousandbreaths as you see fit, perhaps as an encounter while traveling a pathway between glades.)

KARGSTAAD'S GIANTS (4) CREATURE 15

See page 434

Initiative Perception +27

D. THE NIGHTMARE SPIRE MODERATE 18

A mile-wide clearing in the endless forest opens under the twilight sky to make way for a field of jagged hills and thorny plains. A single stone spire rises a mile into the sky.

While the stone spire seems to be unnaturally tall, this is actually a strange visual distortion that affects creatures within 100 feet of the ground—the spire's peak is in fact only 200 feet high.

Bloom Trophies: Raven feathers from a nightmare, linked to the Nights of Dread bloom (page 432).

Creature: Perched atop the needle-like spire is what appears to be an enormous crow. This is one of the most notorious of Thousandbreaths' denizens: the Nightmare Rook. This monstrous guardian of the skies above Thousandbreaths can visit the dreaming minds of outlanders who are foolish enough to sleep in Nyrissa's realm, inflicting horrific living nightmares upon them. Yet it also serves as an expedient way to travel for many of the region's creatures, for the Nightmare Rook is one of two creatures (the other being Nyrissa herself) that can fly above the trees of this realm.

The Nightmare Rook carries passengers only at Nyrissa's direct request or as a result of magical control. It has excellent vision, and unless the PCs take pains to be stealthy as they enter this glade, the immense bird sees them and turns to face them as they approach. If they move more than a hundred feet into the clearing, it shrieks, spreads its wings, and swoops to attack.

The Nightmare Rook's primary tactic is to split up the party by Snatching them and then flying to a different glade to drop them into the peril therein (it takes the Rook 2d6 turns to reach another glade by flight, but it always takes it just one to return to its spire, regardless of how long it took to reach the other glade). The Rook is particularly fond of dropping victims into the Mire (area **G**) or the Fruiting Orchard (area **E**). Thousandbreaths prevents creatures from being dropped into the woods themselves; a character who's dropped anywhere other than a glade falls 2d10×10 feet but finds themselves somehow landing at the same spot they were Snatched up from. The Rook returns to this glade as long as PCs remain within to repeat this process until it is reduced to fewer than 250 HP, at which time its frustration takes over and it lands to finish the fight with its spells and melee Strikes. It saves *alter reality* to duplicate a spell needed to remove a debilitating effect on itself as needed. If reduced to 90 or fewer HP, the Nightmare Rook calls for surrender and promises to fly the PCs to any glade they wish if they spare its life. Of course, this is a lie, as any PC who sees through its deception can tell. Any PCs who take the Rook up on this offer are brought to the Mire or the Fruiting Orchard (equal chances of



NIGHTMARE ROOK

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